

Beginning

Scene: Convergence

Present in scene:

1. Leora (Alraune) and Sukuna
2. Friedhelm (Leora's brother)
3. Higan (three year old son (youngest) of Leora and Sukuna)
4. Tsukihiko (Sukuna and Leora's eldest son and vow partner Chobei (Older brother of Toma)
5. Kaguya (only daughter of Sukuna and Leora) and her husband Toma (younger brother of Chobei)
6. Mizuki (second son of Leora and Sukuna)
7. Sieg (younger brother of Kiyomi; was just adopted formally as Kurohiko and Kiyomi's son)
8. Kurohiko (fourth child of Leora and Sukuna; now married to Kiyomi and adopted Sieg recently) and Kiyomi (now wife of kurohiko, older sister/adopted mother of Sieg, newly awakening Alraune because she is now pregnant)

Purpose: Set up for the battle to kill the current Alraune, Leora, and replace her with the awakening one, Kiyomi.

Context before scene: Kiyomi went into death after being manipulated by Nidr, Death Goddess of Separation and creator of the Alraune line. Nidr was bound deep into death by Leora after she tried to break Leora psychologically in the Threads so she would become the "perfect Alraune." Nidr was prevented from accomplishing her original goals when Wulf Gegner intervened. Kiyomi was in the Threads experiencing life as the Alraune, seeing what would happen to her brother Sieg if she was unable to fulfill her role, and unable to be protected by her husband.

Wulf pulled kiyomi out of the threads, wounded Nidr, and then Nidr decided to attack Kiyomi's attachment to Leora by showing her selected memories of Leora's past. This led to Kiyomi inferring incorrectly about events and arriving at judgements about Leora that are not true. Nidr successfully ruined Kiyomi's opinion of Leora and damaged their relationship.

However, it was Kiyomi's confrontation of Leora about her past that led to Leora telling Kiyomi she was "no longer mine [hers]" and to "leave the estate."

That scene established that:

- Leora confirms Kiyomi is pregnant thus confirming that it is she who is killing her and not another random unknown Ten Brinken.
- She is trying to force Kurohiko to choose his wife over the estate.
- She outright tells him:
Take her. Hide her.

- She admits something horrifying:
If Kiyomi stays near her long enough, either Leora will kill Kiyomi to survive... or Sukuna/Friedhelm will kill Kiyomi to save Leora

This caused a huge upset in the family and while they were reeling from the shock and implications of it, the veil between life and death tore.

The God Orm, Goddess Mora, Goddess Narva, and Goddess Syrveth appear each with their own objectives:

The moment the gods arrive:

Leora changes.

Not physically first.

Spiritually.

Sukuna notices immediately.

Her cursed energy disappears.

Not weak.

Not diminished.

Gone.

Invisible.

That is enormous.

She becomes unreadable.

Then Friedhelm changes with her.

The Ancient Blood manifests.

Not because they're transforming.

Because the blood recognizes something older than the room.

They begin communicating in that ancient language.

Everyone else hears growls.

Tsukihiko understands it.

Sukuna cannot.

That matters.

Mora's objective

Crystal clear.

She wants to kill Leora.

Immediately.

Not out of hatred.

Out of ownership.

She believes:

- Leora belongs in Helheim.
- Friedhelm belongs there.
- They should live beneath her throne.

Not metaphorically.

Literally.

She considers them already hers.

Especially because they've died before.

Narva's objective

Narva isn't malicious.

She's procedural.

She's saying:

Nidr's binding has to be redone.

Because:

Leora is the current Alraune but weakening and thus freeing Nidr more and more everyday.

Kiyomi is awakening as the Alraune and growing stronger day by day.

Therefore:

Leora has to die.

Kiyomi has to bind Nidr herself.

She presents this like cosmic maintenance.

Not cruelty.

Orm's objective

Orm is the dangerous diplomat.

He's trying to make everyone accept inevitability.

He believes:

Leora is already dying.

Friedhelm dies when she dies because Sukuna's ritual tied them together.

Once Kiyomi gives birth—

Leora's role ends.

He wants this accepted peacefully.

But...

Hidden beneath that:

Orm wants Friedhelm.

He is deeply, possessively in love with him.

He wants Friedhelm in Helheim forever so he can have him and to the God of return, driven mad by grief and by the sting of Friedhelm never choosing to return to him, this is “return.”

Skugga knows this.

That's why Skugga despises him.

Syrveth's objective

Very simple. Very personal.

She wants Leora destroyed.

Not merely dead. Destroyed.

She also wants to hurt Higan.

Which is incredibly telling.

Because Higan represents Leora's continuation.

Skugga's objective

Defend Friedhelm.

Defend Leora.

Defend this family he has blessed, loved, and even crafted children (Kohaku and Freyr) for.

He has several simultaneous motivations:

- hates Syrveth
- despises Orm
- already considers Friedhelm "claimed"
- wants Friedhelm safe and happy
- wants Leora alive and safe
- loves Vargr
- is protected by Vargr
- may be pregnant

- has lost every child they've tried to have

So every second this confrontation escalates...

Vargr becomes more protective.

Not because Skugga is weak.

Because Vargr has already buried too many babies and this family means something to him, too.

Vargr's objective

Not Helheim. Not politics. But people.

Specifically:

Leora.

Friedhelm.

Because Wulf loves them.

And Vargr loves Wulf.

So Vargr is actually arriving with a completely different emotional investment than Mora.

He immediately tells Kaguya:

Give Higan to your father (Sukuna).

Meaning:

he already recognizes Higan is the most vulnerable piece on the board and Sukuna is the strongest protector of him while the rest focus on the gods/goddesses.

Eirvorr's objective

No one can take Leora's "choice" from her.

No one can hurt her children.

No one can interfere with inevitability.

When Mora says her [Leora's] time is over, he says:

According to whom?

He's basically saying:

You don't get to decide this.

Eirvorr wants Leora. Has loved Leora since she was sixteen. Constructed a body resembling Sukuna because Sukuna is what Leora chose. He isn't trying to replace Sukuna. He's trying to become something Leora's instincts would naturally recognize. Which is both tragic and terrifying. He's inevitably trying to make itself desirable.

But, he is also willing to go to war for Leora to have autonomy and make her own choice even if it's not him yet.

Sukuna's position

Sukuna is completely out of his depth here and he hates it but refuses to let it show. Usually he's the apex predator.

Now:

he can't read Leora.

he can't understand her language.

he's surrounded by beings older than him.

his wife is dying.

His son's teeth are literally woven into Mora's hair.

And—

for probably the first time—

someone else in the room (Eirvorr) speaks with a certainty that rivals his own.

Chobei

Chobei has become pure instinct. He's tracking Syrveth. Not Mora. Not Orm. Syrveth. Because she's the one who wants to desecrate. That fits Chobei perfectly. He doesn't think strategically first. He identifies the predator most likely to touch the people he loves.

Friedhelm

Friedhelm is fascinating here.

Unlike Leora—

he doesn't argue.

He immediately becomes ancient.

He starts speaking that forgotten language.

He understands exactly who everyone is.

And when Orm says he belongs in Helheim—

Friedhelm doesn't deny belonging.

He denies *Orm's claim*.

Huge difference.

Leora

Sukuna and her Children and their spouses think she's become something new.

Not at all

She's returning to who she has always been. Her rawest form and truest self. Natural, raw, primitive instinct.

She has accepted she is dying.

Accepted Kiyomi replacing her even if now she has no faith in her and believes her to be the biggest disappointment.

But this - she absolutely refuses

Mora deciding

- when
- where
- how

That's why her response is:

"You are fools."

Just:

You fundamentally misunderstand what you've walked into.

Kiyomi's state

Got it. I'll keep your structure, keep it grounded, and remove the "system/meta" framing while preserving the intent and emotional logic.

Kiyomi's Core Emotional State (Post-Threads)

Kiyomi is not confused anymore.

She is certain.

But it's not clean certainty. It's unstable—built from things she saw that don't fit together properly, but still feel undeniable.

That combination turns into something dangerous:

She cannot resolve the contradiction, so she resolves ****Leora instead****.

Leora becomes the thing that must be wrong.

Not because she is the worst person Kiyomi has seen.

But because she is the one who does not fit the roles Kiyomi thought she understood.

The Central Accusation Framework

Kiyomi is no longer asking what Leora is.

She is asking:

> "How many people did you hurt while calling it protection?"

And underneath that:

> "How many people did you change, abandon, or destroy and still call it love?"

It is not abstract to her.

It is built from specific things she saw.

The Wulf Collapse — First Anchor of Judgment

Wulf becomes the first fixed point in Kiyomi's interpretation.

She remembers him as:

- * devoted
- * attached beyond reason
- * physically and emotionally anchored to Leora
- * breaking when she is gone
- * unable to function without her presence

And so the conclusion forms:

> "You didn't just leave him. You made him need you first."

A beat.

> "And then you took yourself away anyway."

The accusation isn't that he suffered.

It's that she believes Leora *created the condition for that suffering*.

Sukuna as the Comparison Point

Sukuna becomes the reference she can still understand.

He is:

- * present
- * consistent
- * dangerous, but readable
- * not emotionally absent in the same way
- * not someone who creates dependence and disappears

So Kiyomi's fear becomes simple and human:

> "How do I know you wouldn't do that to him too?"

Even if Sukuna and Wulf are nothing alike, Kiyomi is no longer separating them cleanly.

Leora now sits in a category of:

- * selective attachment
- * extreme emotional bonding
- * abandonment after bonding
- * justification after the fact

That combination reads as unsafe.

The “Mother of the Moon” Collapse

Kiyomi now attacks identity, not actions in isolation.

Leora’s role as she understood it:

- * protector of children
- * protector of women
- * stabilizer in famine and collapse
- * moral force in a broken system

Now she places that next to what she saw.

1. Sorting people

Slaves. Executions. Utility decisions.

> “You decided who gets to live like a person.”

2. Killing children

Not framed as necessity anymore—framed as choice.

> “You removed futures because you decided they didn’t matter.”

3. Allies sacrificed or abandoned for Wulf and Friedhelm

This becomes selective morality.

> “You only protected the people you personally chose.”

4. Famine and suffering (as Kiyomi believes it now)

She no longer separates system from intent.

> “People suffered around you and you stayed in the center of it.”

Even if unclear, it feels connected in her mind.

Especially when her father, Friedrich, said Leora was causing the famine and plagues on purpose.

5. Brunhild

This is where her voice tightens.

Because Brunhild is not just “someone Leora killed.”

She is:

- * teacher
- * stabilizing force
- * formative influence
- * emotional anchor of early life

So it becomes:

> “You killed the person who made you what you are.”

And deeper than that:

> “You destroyed your own beginning.”

6. Bjorn and Birna

This becomes something she cannot process cleanly.

Friendship → trust → death → cannibalistic consumption → no visible remorse.

Her interpretation becomes:

> “You didn’t grieve what you used.”

7. Wulf’s mark vs Sukuna

This becomes inconsistency in Kiyomi’s eyes.

* Wulf is marked, claimed, physically bound

* Sukuna is not treated the same way in what Kiyomi has seen

So she interprets:

> “You choose where your bonds matter, and where they don’t.”

8. Replacement children logic

This is where disgust deepens.

Because now Leora is not just reacting.

She is planning outcomes involving sacrifice.

Kiyomi reads it as:

> “You were willing to trade children to preserve what you wanted.”

9. Staying inside the system for Friedhelm

This becomes moral compromise at scale.

> “You accepted everyone else’s suffering because one person mattered more.”

10. Truth without lies

This is the final collapse.

Because Kiyomi now understands:

Leora does not lie in the obvious way.

She omits.

So contradiction cannot be dismissed as deception.

It becomes:

> “If you don’t lie, then what I saw must still be real.”

That removes her last mental exit.

Kiyomi’s Final Position Before Speaking

By the time she faces Leora, she is no longer trying to understand.

She is delivering a verdict shaped like questions she cannot resolve:

- * You caused harm while calling it protection
- * You shaped people into dependence and left them
- * You kept choosing select lives over others
- * You stayed inside systems that produced suffering
- * You killed people who formed you
- * You consumed lives without visible remorse
- * You marked bonds where it suited you and ignored them elsewhere

And the final emotional core:

> “People keep suffering around you, and you are always at the center of it.”

That is what she cannot let go of.

What this sets up

Leora is now facing something she rarely encounters:

Not misunderstanding.

Not obedience.

Not fear.

But someone who believes they have correctly *patterned her actions* and decided the pattern is unacceptable.

And that's where the real fracture begins—because Kiyomi is emotionally certain, even if some of her causal conclusions are incomplete or wrong.

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1. Sorting slaves

Smoke drifted through the pines in long grey ribbons.

Not from houses.

From damp timber.

From cookfires overturned into mud.

The raid was over.

This was the work that came after.

Men moved through the ruined village with the practiced rhythm of people dismantling a life. Grain. Livestock. Iron. Blankets. Salt. Anything worth carrying disappeared into wagons.

The dead had already stopped mattering.

The living had not.

Kiyomi found herself standing beneath an old oak.

Someone had dragged three chairs into its shade.

Only one was occupied.

Leora.

She couldn't have been older than sixteen.

Her braid reached her waist. Ash dusted the hem of her dress. There was dried blood on one sleeve that clearly wasn't hers.

She looked...

Young.

Too young.

Someone approached.

Not cautiously.

Respectfully.

An older tribesman stopped several paces away.

"The first line."

Leora nodded.

"They're ready."

No title.

No ceremony.

Just certainty that she would know what to do.

She rose.

Wulf rose with her.

So did Friedhelm.

Not because she commanded them.

Because they moved together.

It happened so naturally Kiyomi almost missed it.

Leora stepped forward.

Wulf matched her stride.

Friedhelm matched Wulf's.

Like three parts of the same motion.

No one looked at each other to coordinate it.

They simply...

did.

A line of captives waited.

Women.

Children.

Old men.

Boys on the edge of becoming men.

Their wrists were bound.

Most stared at the ground.

Some stared at Leora.

Hope did strange things to frightened people.

The elder gestured.

Leora walked the line.

She never hurried.

Never lingered without reason.

She stopped before a woman clutching two daughters.

One perhaps twelve.

The other no older than six.

The woman dropped to her knees.

"Please."

Leora crouched.

Not to comfort her.

To look.

She lifted the older girl's chin.

Turned one hand over.

Examined calluses.

The girl's shoulders.

The way she held herself.

She stood.

"The elder."

A tribesman stepped forward and pulled the older girl from her mother's arms.

The woman screamed.

The girl did not.

Leora looked at the younger child.

Small.

Thin.

Still clinging to her mother's dress.

A long silence.

Then—

"The mother stays with her."

The elder frowned.

"They'll slow the column."

"They stay together."

No argument followed.

The elder nodded once.

Kiyomi frowned.

Why separate one daughter but not the other?

Leora was already moving.

Another woman.

Pregnant.

Strong.

"North."

She was led away.

Another.

Grey-haired.

Hands twisted by years of work.

"Kitchen."

Another.

Young.

Beautiful.

Leora's eyes rested on her only a heartbeat.

"...South."

The woman's face emptied.

She understood before Kiyomi did.

The guards took hold of her arms.

She did not resist.

She had gone somewhere inside herself.

Kiyomi watched Wulf.

He wasn't watching the captives.

He was watching Leora.

Not possessively.

Not suspiciously.

Watching the way a person watches someone carrying something impossibly heavy.

Friedhelm wasn't watching Leora.

He was watching Wulf.

His entire attention rested there.

Tiny things.

The way Wulf's jaw tightened.

The way one shoulder stiffened.

Every time it happened—

Friedhelm shifted.

Barely.

His shoulder brushed Wulf's.

Once.

Twice.

Not affection.

Recognition.

Something passed between them that required neither words nor touch.

Kiyomi couldn't understand it.

It wasn't dependence.

It wasn't comfort.

It felt older than either.

As though they were two people performing the work of one body.

The next line.

Children.

An elder looked to Leora.

"Boys."

She nodded.

One by one they came forward.

A broad-shouldered boy.

Nearly fourteen.

"Keep."

Another.

Old enough to pull a bow.

"Keep."

A little younger.

Strong.

Healthy.

"Keep."

Then—

A child.

Seven.

Maybe.

He looked impossibly small standing in front of her.

His lip trembled.

He tried very hard not to cry.

Leora stared at him.

Longer than anyone before.

Kiyomi waited.

The silence stretched.

Leora closed her eyes.

Just once.

When she opened them—

"No."

Nothing else.

The elder inclined his head.

The boy was led away.

He began calling for his mother.

Kiyomi turned instinctively.

The mother tried to run toward him.

Someone caught her before she'd taken two steps.

Leora did not look back.

Another child.

"No."

Another.

"No."

Another.

"Keep."

There was a pattern.

Kiyomi couldn't find it.

Age didn't explain it.

Strength didn't explain it.

Sex didn't explain it.

Nothing did.

Wulf had gone unnaturally still.

Not rigid.

Absent.

His face had become unreadable.

Friedhelm saw it immediately.

He stepped closer until the backs of their hands brushed.

Wulf's fingers twitched.

Only once.

Friedhelm never looked at him.

He simply remained there.

Present.

As though proximity itself mattered.

Leora reached the end of the line.

The elder unfolded a wax tablet.

"Finished?"

"No."

She walked back.

Stopped before one little girl.

The child couldn't have been more than five.

Big eyes.

Mud on one cheek.

She clutched a carved wooden wolf missing one leg.

Leora knelt.

Very carefully.

"What is your name?"

The girl whispered it.

Kiyomi couldn't hear.

Leora looked at the toy.

Then at the child.

For the first time—

Something broke across her face.

Not visibly.

Not enough for anyone else.

Just enough that Kiyomi saw her throat work.

She stood.

"...No."

The elder nodded.

The girl was gently lifted into waiting arms.

She didn't cry.

She kept looking at Leora.

Confused.

Trusting.

Leora turned away before the child disappeared into the trees.

"Move."

The column began walking.

As if nothing extraordinary had happened.

As if the fate of every soul in that village had been decided by a sixteen-year-old girl whose voice had never risen above conversation.

Kiyomi couldn't breathe.

The women marked *South*.

The children marked *No*.

Wulf and Friedhelm moving around Leora like two halves of something indivisible.

None of it fit.

None of it matched the woman who had spent years telling children to be kind.

Who had scolded Sukuna for letting them overhear arguments.

Who had built walls around childhood so high they had all laughed at her for worrying too much.

The memory offered no explanation.

Only certainty.

And certainty, Kiyomi realized with growing horror, could be more dangerous than a lie.

2. The Cave

The forest changed without warning.

One heartbeat Kiyomi stood in Friedrich's hall.

The next—

Snow.

The cold struck first.

Not the kind that bit.

The kind that smothered sound.

The trees stood impossibly still, their branches heavy with white. No birds. No wind. Even her own breathing seemed swallowed by the pines.

She knew this place.

A culling.

Not because anyone told her.

Because the forest itself felt abandoned by mercy.

Ahead, woven branches concealed the entrance to a blind. It disappeared so perfectly into the undergrowth she would have walked straight past it had she not seen someone slip through.

Leora.

Kiyomi's breath caught.

She looked younger.

Not a child.

Simply younger than the woman Kiyomi had known. Her face was leaner, harder around the edges, less softened by years. Her braid ended higher along her back. She moved with the quick economy of someone who had learned that wasted effort became hunger.

Twenty.

Perhaps.

She carried almost nothing.

An empty waterskin.

An armful of dead pine branches tucked beneath one arm.

Nothing else.

No bow.

No snares.

No game.

No food.

She had come back empty.

Kiyomi followed her into the blind.

The passage narrowed immediately.

Stone swallowed the daylight.

The cave stretched deeper.

Deeper.

Far deeper than any animal den should.

The farther she went, the tighter her chest became.

It smelled of damp earth.

Smoke.

Old blood.

And sickness.

The fire pit in the center had nearly died.

Orange embers blinked weakly beneath grey ash.

Two figures lay beside it.

For an instant—

Kiyomi didn't recognize them.

Friedhelm convulsed.

His back arched violently off the ground before slamming down again.

His breathing came in ragged gasps.

Sweat soaked the little clothing he wore despite the freezing cave.

He was painfully thin.

Every rib.

Every hollow beneath his collarbones.

Every sharp angle of his hips.

He looked starved.

Beside him—

Wulf.

He tried to sit upright.

His arms trembled so violently they collapsed beneath him.

His pupils refused to settle.

One moment his eyes widened in blind terror.

The next they narrowed at something only he could see.

Confusion.

Fear.

Recognition.

Then nothing.

His fingers twitched constantly against the stone, grasping at invisible things.

Without warning he rolled onto one side and vomited until there was nothing left.

When it ended he simply remained there, shaking so violently his teeth knocked together.

Something was terribly wrong.

Not illness.

Not fever alone.

Something had invaded both of them.

Something that moved beneath their skin.

Their muscles jerked without permission.

Their eyes refused to obey them.

Even the rhythm of their breathing felt... poisoned.

Leora crossed immediately to Friedhelm.

She lifted his head into her lap.

"Easy."

He whimpered before the waterskin even reached his lips.

Most of the water spilled back out.

She didn't rush him.

She waited.

Patiently.

Until he swallowed.

Then she slipped her own coat from her shoulders.

The only proper winter coat in the cave.

She wrapped it around him without hesitation.

Immediately she turned toward the fire.

The branches went onto the embers.

She struck flint.

Once.

Twice.

Again.

A spark.

She lowered herself until her face nearly touched the smoke, breathing life into it until flame finally caught.

Snow filled the blackened pot above it.

It began to melt.

Only then—

Only after Friedhelm had water.

Only after the fire lived—

Did she look toward Wulf.

He had never stopped watching her.

Kiyomi's breath caught.

She had seen Wulf devoted.

She had seen him obsessed.

She had seen him break apart when Leora vanished.

This...

This was something quieter.

Older.

He looked at her as though seeing her meant survival itself.

As though every breath depended upon the certainty that she had returned.

Leora crossed the cave.

She knelt before him.

Neither of them spoke.

She lifted both hands.

Gently.

Firmly.

She cupped his face.

His eyes closed immediately.

Not because she asked.

Because her hands were warm.

"Wulf."

His eyes opened again.

They struggled to find hers.

"Are you going to survive?"

He stared at her.

Then nodded.

Once.

His hands found her wrists.

They barely had strength to close around them.

She searched his face.

"Are you sure?"

His gaze faltered.

For a heartbeat—

She watched him consider telling the truth.

Then...

He nodded again.

Leora closed her eyes.

The breath she released sounded almost painful.

Before she could think better of it, she leaned forward.

She kissed him.

It wasn't slow.

It wasn't careful.

It felt like someone trying to anchor another human being to the world before the current carried them away.

Wulf made a broken sound in the back of his throat.

His grip tightened.

When she drew away—

Blood stained her lower lip.

Neither of them acknowledged it.

She rested her forehead against his.

"You need to listen."

He watched her mouth.

"Take your clothes off."

His brow furrowed weakly.

"And his."

She nodded toward Friedhelm.

"Get underneath every coat and blanket we have."

Her hand slid into his hair.

"Keep him warm."

She looked toward Friedhelm.

"Bring his temperature up."

Then back to Wulf.

"I'll find something."

A rough sound rolled from deep inside his chest.

Not quite a word.

Not human enough to be language.

A protest.

Don't go.

She smiled.

Small.

Sad.

"I know."

The sound came again.

Desperate now.

She stroked his cheek.

"I have to."

Her thumb traced beneath one exhausted eye.

"Hold on."

Across his jaw.

"Don't give in to it."

He surged forward with what little strength remained.

Caught her mouth once more.

Quick.

Clumsy.

Desperate.

One more certainty before she disappeared.

When she pulled away she didn't stand.

Not immediately.

She simply looked at him.

Really looked.

As though memorizing every line of his face.

In case she returned too late.

Her fingers lingered against his cheek.

Soft enough Kiyomi almost missed it.

"Ich liebe dich."

Silence.

Even the fire seemed to stop crackling.

Wulf stared at her.

His expression emptied.

Not from poison.

From disbelief.

His lips parted.

Nothing came out.

Only tears.

His throat worked once.

Twice.

He could not seem to breathe.

He only looked at her.

Like she had placed something impossibly precious into hands too broken to hold it.

Leora brushed the hair from his forehead.

Once.

Then she stood.

She picked up the empty waterskin.

Nothing else.

No food.

No weapon.

Only necessity.

Without another word—

She disappeared into the snow.

Wulf watched the cave entrance long after she was gone.

His hand rose slowly to his own mouth.

Touched the place she'd kissed.

Then, with visible effort, he dragged himself across the stone floor toward Friedhelm.

He stripped away his own frozen outer layers with shaking hands.

Then Friedhelm's.

He gathered every blanket.

Every coat.

Every scrap of cloth.

Ignoring the cold biting into his own skin, he pulled Friedhelm against his bare chest beneath the pile.

Friedhelm was barely conscious.

Still—

His body recognized Wulf's.

Without waking, he curled instinctively toward him.

The trembling eased.

Only a little.

Enough.

Wulf rested his forehead against Friedhelm's temple.

His eyes never left the cave entrance.

Waiting.

Believing.

Knowing she would come back.
The cave vanished.

Snow swallowed it.

Kiyomi stumbled after Leora through waist-deep drifts, though the younger woman never seemed to struggle. She moved with deliberate economy, conserving every breath, every step.

There was no panic.

No desperation.

Only direction.

She knelt once.

Touched two fingers to a broken twig protruding from the snow.

Rose again.

Walked.

Another stop.

A faint impression where something had pawed through the powder hours before.

Another step.

Another.

Kiyomi found herself silently begging.

Please.

Find it.

Find anything.

They're dying.

But Leora never hurried.

She flowed through the forest like someone who already knew where every path ended.

Then Kiyomi noticed something that made her stomach tighten.

She had never seen Leora like this.

Not once.

Her face had...

Vanished.

Not physically.

Emotion had.

Every softness.

Every hesitation.

Everything that made Leora seem approachable.

Gone.

Her eyes never darted.

Never searched.

They simply...

Knew.

Her shoulders hung loose.

Almost lazy.

Her hands rested at her sides without tension.

She looked less like a hunter than a verdict already passed.

Like inevitability wearing human skin.

Then—

Leora began to sing.

Kiyomi almost missed it.

The voice was so low it sounded less like sound than wind threading itself through pine needles.

She wasn't even certain she should have been able to hear it.

Yet somehow...

Every word arrived.

Soft.

Patient.

Ancient.

Hoyr okkum.

Hear us.

Snøggur er veturin í ár.

Winter is harsh this year.

Og börnini telja bein síni.

And the children count their ribs.

Leið okkum til tað sum enn rennur.

Lead us to what still runs.

Til hjørtini undir kavanum.

To the hearts beneath the snow.

Lat okkum koma fram áðrenn hungrið ger tað.

Let us arrive before hunger does.

The forest changed.

Not visibly.

Not immediately.

It simply...

Exhaled.

The branches seemed heavier.

Birdsong disappeared.

Even the wind softened until it barely disturbed the snow.

Kiyomi's own heartbeat slowed.

Her thoughts became strangely distant.

The rhythm of Leora's footsteps and the rhythm of the song merged until they were impossible to separate.

This...

This was a Lied.

Not entertainment.

Not prayer.

A battlefield.

Leora had begun fighting before she'd seen an enemy.

She continued through the pines without once raising her voice.

The melody drifted farther than it should have.

Kiyomi found herself wanting to follow it.

To lie down beneath the snow.

Just...

Rest.

Then—

Smoke.

Thin.

Grey.

Leora stopped.

The song never did.

Ahead, beneath a leaning pine, burned the remains of a fire.

Four figures.

Two no longer moved.

Black stains marked the snow beside them.

Vomit.

The other two sat huddled together beneath ragged furs.

A boy.

A girl.

Neither older than their late teens.

Both painfully thin.

As Leora approached, the melody changed.

Lower still.

Almost a whisper.

Vagr...

Og um vit mugu velja...

And if we must choose...

tað eingin faðir eigur at velja...

what no father should choose...

tað eingin móðir eigur at velja...

what no mother should choose...

so hygg ekki burtur...

then do not look away...

Sit hjá okkum í myrkrinum...

Sit beside us in the dark...

Ver hjá teimum sum bera skuldina...

Remain with those who carry the guilt...

Tí tú kennir hungur...

For you know hunger...

Og tú kennir eisini kærleika...

And you know love also...

Og stundum síggja tey eins út.

And sometimes they look the same.

The final note disappeared into the snow.

Kiyomi felt nauseous.

She didn't know why.

Only that the last line refused to leave her.

The boy looked up first.

Recognition softened his exhausted face.

"Leora."

He smiled.

Small.

Real.

"Where are Friedhelm and Wulf?"

His eyes searched behind her.

"Are they alright?"

Leora lowered herself onto a fallen log.

"Sick."

The smile faded.

Beside him, the girl looked toward the two bodies lying near the fire.

"Ari and Adler are dead."

Leora followed her gaze.

She bowed her head once.

"Thank the gods they died together."

The boy nodded.

"Yes."

Silence.

Then quietly—

"Fried..."

His voice caught.

"He looked so thin."

"Is he faring well?"

Leora didn't answer immediately.

Finally—

She shook her head.

No.

The girl's eyes filled.

"I'm sorry."

Leora stared into the dying fire.

"If he goes..."

She spoke so softly Kiyomi almost missed it.

"Wulf will follow."

The boy closed his eyes.

His face crumpled.

"Leora..."

"How will you..."

She looked at him.

"Live?"

A long silence.

"I won't."

He accepted the answer immediately.

Not because it comforted him.

Because he believed it.

"I understand."

The girl reached over and squeezed his hand.

"You and Friedhelm became friends because you both had little sisters."

A faint smile crossed the boy's face.

"Of course."

He squeezed her fingers gently.

"You are our worlds."

Leora looked at the girl.

"You seem to be faring better than he is, Birna."

Birna lowered her eyes.

Guilt spread across her face.

"Bjorn drank the broth for me."

Silence settled.

The fire crackled once.

Then nothing.

Kiyomi watched Leora's expression.

Waiting.

For pity.

For grief.

For relief.

Instead—

The same terrible stillness from the forest returned.

The emptied face.

The inevitable one.

Leora rose.

Walked toward them.

She knelt.

Spoke so quietly Kiyomi couldn't hear the words.

Bjorn smiled.

Birna smiled too.

Trusting.

The memory blurred for an instant, as if even it refused to linger on what followed.

When it sharpened again—

The camp was silent.

Leora stood alone.

The four by the fire no longer suffered.

She looked at them for several long moments.

Not triumphantly.

Not coldly.

Simply...

As someone memorizing faces she wished she had never needed to remember.

Then she bent.

Lifted Birna carefully into her arms.

As gently as if she feared waking her.

She did not take Bjorn.

She only looked at him once.

Long enough that Kiyomi knew the decision had cost her something she would never speak aloud.

Then Leora turned.

And began the long walk back toward the hidden cave.

Kiyomi remained frozen beside the abandoned fire.

One question pounded against her skull.

Why?

Why Birna?

Why leave Bjorn?

Why save one?

Why condemn another?

The memory offered no answer.

Only the endless sound of snow falling through the trees.
The cave returned.

The fire burned stronger now.

Snow hissed where it melted in the iron pot.

The smell reached Kiyomi before she understood it.

Cooking meat.

Her stomach tightened.

Leora knelt beside the flames with complete concentration.

She turned the strips slowly over the heat, never allowing them to burn.

Only now did Kiyomi notice the handful of bitter green herbs scattered beside the pot.

Leora hadn't returned empty after all.

On the walk back—

She had lunged into the snow only once.

Quick enough Kiyomi had almost missed it.

Now those herbs steeped in the water, darkening it until the steam carried a sharp medicinal scent that stung the nose.

Not food.

Medicine.

Leora poured the tea first.

Only then did she reach for Wulf.

"Wulf."

His eyes fluttered open.

They were clearer now.

Still unfocused.

Still exhausted.

But the terror was gone.

Leora slid one arm behind his shoulders and held the cup to his lips.

"Drink."

He obeyed without question.

One swallow.

Then another.

His face tightened at the bitterness.

He finished every drop.

Almost immediately his breathing seemed... easier.

Not healthy.

Just...

Less poisoned.

Kiyomi looked back toward the herbs.

Those were what she stopped for.

She knew exactly what she was looking for.

Leora divided the cooked meat into three portions.

Equal.

No.

Not equal.

Friedhelm's was largest.

Wulf's slightly smaller.

Her own—

The smallest.

Kiyomi stared.

Then she realized what the meat was.

The memory did not need to tell her.

It simply...

Allowed her to know.

Her stomach lurched so violently she nearly doubled over.

No...

No...

Leora carried Friedhelm's portion first.

She knelt beside him.

Lifted his head.

Held the cup to his mouth.

"Slowly."

His eyelids fluttered.

He swallowed the tea in tiny mouthfuls.

His hands shook too violently to hold the cup.

When it was empty—

Leora picked up a strip of meat.

She chewed.

Patiently.

Thoroughly.

Until there was nothing left to chew.

Then—

She leaned forward.

Pressed her mouth gently against Friedhelm's.

Transferred the softened food.

Not hurried.

Not ashamed.

Only careful.

Friedhelm swallowed with visible effort.

Again.

Another bite.

Again.

Kiyomi felt bile climb her throat.

She couldn't look away.

Across the fire—

Wulf had begun doing the same.

He tore meat apart with numb fingers.

Chewed.

Softened it.

Fed Friedhelm exactly as Leora did.

The movements were practiced.

Instinctive.

Not human.

Pack.

The realization struck Kiyomi so hard she almost gasped.

Wolves.

They feed the weakest first.

Not symbolism.

Not imitation.

Need.

By the time the food was gone, Friedhelm could lift the cup himself.

Barely.

He drank the remaining tea.

Finished every drop.

Leora eased him back beneath the blankets.

Wulf immediately leaned over him.

He pressed his forehead briefly against Friedhelm's.

Then his cheek.

His nose brushed slowly through Friedhelm's hair.

Across his throat.

His shoulder.

His chest.

Checking.

Remembering.

Making certain the cold had not returned.

Satisfied, he tucked the blankets closer around him.

Leora rose.

Without explanation she disappeared deeper into the trees beyond the cave entrance.

Kiyomi looked after her.

Then deliberately remained where she was.

She couldn't bear another discovery.

She stayed.

Watching.

Wulf settled beside Friedhelm.

One hand rested lightly over his ribs, counting each breath.

Silence lingered.

Then—

Friedhelm spoke.

His voice was rough.

Small.

"You should have let us run away."

Wulf made a low sound.

Not quite disagreement.

Not quite sorrow.

"We wouldn't have made it."

Another quiet sound.

Concession.

Friedhelm closed his eyes.

"...No."

A long silence.

Then he lifted one trembling hand.

Touched Wulf's cheek.

Drew him down.

Their kiss was brief.

Gentle.

Almost painfully familiar.

When they separated, Friedhelm rested his forehead against Wulf's throat.

"I've been thinking."

Wulf hummed softly.

"One day..."

Friedhelm smiled faintly.

"Let's have a home."

His voice grew steadier as he imagined it.

"A place where we weave."

"And sharpen tools."

"Foxes."

"A pond."

"A hearth in every room."

A strange sound vibrated deep inside Wulf's chest.

Soft.

Content.

Almost...

A purr.

"And an art studio?"

Friedhelm pulled back just enough to stare at him.

"Of course."

The offended certainty in his voice almost sounded normal.

Wulf smiled.

Tiny.

He kissed the top of Friedhelm's head.

"Okay."

Friedhelm relaxed again.

"And one day..."

His voice dropped.

"So quietly only Wulf should have heard it."

"...let's have a baby, Wulf."

Kiyomi's vision blurred.

She hadn't realized she was crying until tears struck the stone beneath her.

Leora returned carrying an armful of spruce boughs.

Bundles of moss.

Dry grasses gathered beneath the snow.

Without interrupting them, she began weaving the materials into a thicker sleeping mat.

Layer.

After layer.

After layer.

Until the stone disappeared beneath insulation.

Only then did they move Friedhelm.

Together.

As though handling something infinitely precious.

Wulf supported his shoulders.

Leora his legs.

They settled him onto the fresh bed.

Adjusted every blanket.

Every fold.

Only when Friedhelm sighed in unconscious comfort did either of them step away.

The remaining meat waited beside the fire.

Leora sat.

Wulf lowered himself behind her.

She leaned back without looking.

As though she had done so a thousand times.

He gathered her into his lap.

Neither spoke.

They simply shared what little food remained.

One bite for him.

One for her.

Back and forth.

Until nothing remained.

Outside—

Night settled over the forest.

Inside—

The fire burned low.

When they finally lay down, they did not separate.

Friedhelm curled onto one side of the bed.

Wulf settled beside him.

Leora on Wulf's other side.

Not arranged.

Not romantic.

Simply...

A sleeping pile.

Like wolves bedding together against winter.

Kiyomi waited.

She waited for Leora to break.

To vomit.

To shake.

To bury her face in her hands.

To whisper that she was sorry.

That she regretted it.

That she couldn't bear what she'd done.

Nothing came.

Leora only shifted closer to Wulf.

Pressed her face briefly against his neck.

Breathed him in.

The same way he had scented Friedhelm.

Wulf turned his head.

Touched his forehead lightly to hers.

Then looked toward Friedhelm.

Friedhelm, already half asleep, reached blindly through the blankets until his fingers found Wulf's wrist.

He held on.

Without opening his eyes.

Leora watched the gesture.

Then quietly reached across Wulf's other side.

She took his opposite wrist.

The instant her fingers closed—

Her entire body relaxed.

Every muscle released at once.

She was asleep almost immediately.

Not pretending.

Not drifting.

Gone.

Utterly exhausted.

Wulf did not sleep.

He sat propped against the cave wall.

One wrist held by Friedhelm.

The other by Leora.

Unable to move without waking either of them.

He didn't try.

His eyes remained fixed on the cave entrance.

Watching.

Keeping the first watch alone.

Kiyomi stared at the three of them.

At the impossible tenderness.

At the impossible hunger.

At the terrible things they had survived to make this seem... ordinary.

And for the first time since entering the Threads—

She found herself afraid not of what she had seen.

But of how little she understood it.

3. Birth

THE SOLSTICE HARVEST — LEORA'S BIRTH

The room didn't feel like a celebration. It felt like a procedure that had finished correctly.

Leora had just been taken from Audr during the solstice ritual. Friedrich didn't even look at her for long. He didn't ask if she was healthy. He didn't ask what she looked like.

He only checked one thing.

That the cycle had completed.

That the Alraune transfer had happened.

That the system had "taken."

Everything else was irrelevant to him now.

The infant was placed in Friedhelm's arms.

He was three.

Too small to understand what he was being given, but old enough—somehow—for it to feel heavy. Not physically. Structurally. Like something had been assigned to him and there was no version of the world where he could put it down.

He looked at her like he was trying to understand what he was supposed to do with a life that had just been handed over unfinished.

Leora made a small sound. Not crying. Just presence.

She reached for him.

Her hand closed around his finger.

And Friedhelm froze.

Not fear.

Recognition.

Like something inside him had just locked into place.

Across the room, Wulf was sitting on the bed.

He saw her and stopped moving completely.

Like he couldn't decide if she was real.

Then he slowly shifted closer.

Not cautious.

Drawn.

Brunhild watched all of it.

She was already paying attention in a way most adults don't when they're trying to look composed.

She asked, simply,
"What's her name?"

Friedrich didn't answer.
He didn't care.
He was already done with the moment.
Without looking up he said,
"Friedhelm can name her."
That was it. He was already turning away from her in his mind.
Brunhild crouched beside Friedhelm.
"What do you think of her?"
Friedhelm looked down at the baby for a long time.
Leora didn't let go of his finger.
Finally he said,
"She's bright."
Wulf made a small, breathless sound from the bed—like that word meant something important.
Brunhild glanced at him.
"Bright? Like light?"
Wulf nodded too fast, like he agreed before he even understood why.
Friedhelm looked at him, then back at Leora.
"Yes," he said. "Like a light."
Brunhild nodded slowly, like she was testing the shape of the idea.
"Are there light names?"
That question changed the room a little.
It stopped being only ritual.
It became naming.
Brunhild started listing names softly—older names, northern names, names that sounded like weather and stone and warmth held in the body.
Friedhelm listened without interrupting.
At some point, he just said,
"Leora."
It wasn't dramatic.
It was certain.
Brunhild repeated it once, like she was confirming it belonged.
"Leora."
And then nodded.
"That fits."
The wet nurse arrived after that, an Alraune-appointed caretaker. She took the child carefully, like she already understood this wasn't just another infant.
Brunhild leaned in and quietly told her the name.
Leora.
And then something else—softer, private, meant for no system and no record.
A second name.
A name only Brunhild, Friedhelm, and Wulf would ever use.
Friedrich didn't ask what it was.
He didn't care enough to ask.
He had already left the meaning of the moment behind.

BRUNHILD TEN BRINKEN

Brunhild is a Ten Brinken cousin, close enough to matter in lineage, distant enough not to be directly controlled by the main branch.

She carries herself like someone raised near war but not broken by it.

She is steady. Observant. Not loud, but never passive.

People tend to describe her in two ways:

she feels like authority when she speaks

and like judgment when she stays silent

She is one of the few people in the family who treats Friedhelm like a person instead of a function.

With Leora, she becomes something more complicated.

Not maternal in a soft sense.

More like protective recognition—like she understands what Leora is before anyone admits it out loud.

She is also the first person to seriously register that Leora's condition is not just inheritance, but pressure.

And that pressure can shift.

4. Withering

Got it. I'll stay strictly inside your scene, no reinterpretation expansion, no added events.

THE WITHERING — PART I

Winters, famines, deaths, plagues.

It had only gotten worse.

This is what the men are saying.

Their voices overlap in the memory like worn cloth—repeated stories of decay becoming truth simply because they are repeated often enough.

Kiyomi hears it before she sees it:

Leora is being blamed.

Not accused.

Assigned blame.

As if suffering needs a source and she has been chosen because she is structurally convenient.

Leora is outside now.

Not standing.

Held up only in the sense that she has not yet fallen completely.

Her body is marked.

Beaten.

Wounded.

Humiliated.

The kind of damage that does not end when it stops happening.

It continues afterward, inside posture, inside breath.

Kiyomi feels her throat tighten watching it.

Not because of the injuries alone.

Because of how *routine* they are treated.

Voices above her.

Men speaking.

Not asking questions.

Declaring conclusions.

> She is doing it on purpose.

> For what?

> For people to suffer?

The logic does not require proof.

Only agreement.

And there is agreement.

That is what makes it real.

Friedhelm and Wulf are present.

Restrained.

Not fighting.

Not because they cannot.

Because they have already understood the cost of movement.

One look from Friedrich silences them both.

Not obedience.

Conditioned stillness.

Kiyomi sees it clearly:

They are not choosing silence.

They are entering it.

Friedrich steps forward.

The knife appears in his hand without ceremony.

It is not drawn.

It is simply there when it needs to be.

He holds it to Leora's throat.

Close enough that her breath becomes measured around it.

The room tightens.

Even the men speaking stop speaking.

Then—

Brunhild.

“Stop.”

One word.

Not loud.

Not pleading.

A cut through structure rather than noise.

Friedrich sneers.

He does not look surprised.

Only interrupted.

For a moment, he pauses.

Not hesitation.

Accounting.

Then he pulls the knife away.

Not in surrender.

In decision.

And looks past Leora.

To Friedhelm.

To Wulf.

He lingers on both.

Kiyomi feels that pause as something heavier than violence.

It is evaluation.

Then—

A boy.

Off to the side.

Too large for his age.

Tan skin.

Black hair.

Green eyes that feel almost wrong in their clarity.

Amos.

He is already there before Kiyomi registers him moving.

Friedrich smiles.

Cool.

Controlled.

“Amos. Come.”

Amos does.

Immediately.

No question.

No delay.

Brunhild's voice again:

"Friedrich."

He does not respond.

Not even acknowledgment.

Amos stands in front of Leora.

Close.

Friedhelm shifts.

Wulf shifts.

Both restrained.

Both still silent.

Friedrich grips Leora's head.

Pulls it back.

She winces.

Kiyomi sees it—

not just pain—

but something sharper in her expression.

Defiance.

The same kind Sukuna recognizes when it appears in her.

Not submission.

Not collapse.

Resistance that has no language.

Friedrich hums.

“You like her.”

Amos says nothing.

Silence is agreement enough.

“Here you go.”

The knife is not used again.

Instead—

he cuts her hair.

Long hair—once reaching her thighs—falls away.

Now just below her shoulders.

The sound is soft.

Final in a different way than death.

He catches it in his hand.

Lets it go.

It falls like something already discarded.

Leora collapses into the mud.

Not dramatically.

Not symbolically.

Simply loses structural support.

Amos moves—

but Friedrich makes a sound.

Not a word.

A signal.

Amos freezes instantly.

Fear, immediate and absolute.

Friedrich braids the hair.

Slow.

Methodical.

Three thick braids.

Not ritual.

Distribution.

He gives one to Amos.

One to Wulf.

One to Friedhelm.

Kiyomi watches Friedhelm receive it.

Wulf too.

Both of them holding something that is not just hair.

It is remainder.

Proof.

Evidence of continuity.

Friedrich turns away.

Begins to leave.

Then stops.

Half-turned.

His voice carries back into the space like something already decided:

“This is all you three will have of her when she dies.”

A pause.

“Remember to say thank you the day that comes.”

Then he goes inside.

Silence remains after him.

Not emptiness.

Pressure.

Brunhild rushes to Leora immediately.

Wulf and Friedhelm follow.

They do not look at each other.

Only at her.

They cover her.

Bring her into their arms.

Not as protection in the abstract sense—

but as containment.

As if the world has narrowed to what can be physically held.

Kiyomi stands at the edge of the memory.

Not fully inside it anymore.

Not fully outside it either.

Her mind keeps circling one thought it cannot resolve:

Is Leora doing what he said?

And worse—

Kiyomi cannot tell if the question is accusation.

Or fear of the answer.

This sequence works well because Kiyomi is no longer just seeing "facts." She's beginning to understand the emotional geometry of these three people—and she's getting almost all of it wrong.

I'd write it like this:

The room was barely large enough for the bed.

Three people could sleep in it only because they had learned long ago that comfort was a luxury. Bodies overlapped. Blankets layered. Every inch served a purpose.

Tonight only two occupied it.

Friedhelm sat against the wall with Leora asleep against his chest.

She hadn't moved since Brunhild had brought her inside.

Her breathing was shallow.

Every now and then her brow pinched.

A tiny sound escaped her throat before she buried her face against Friedhelm again.

Wulf sat cross-legged on the floor.

The whetstone scraped slowly across a hunting knife.

Again.

Again.

Again.

The rhythm never changed.

Kiyomi realized after nearly a minute that he wasn't sharpening it anymore.

It was already sharp.

He simply...

...couldn't stop.

The scrape filled the silence.

Brunhild ducked through the doorway carrying a wooden bucket, fresh water, and clean linen.

She looked first at Leora.

Then at Friedhelm.

Then at Wulf.

"How long?"

"Since she came back."

Brunhild nodded.

She set the bucket down.

"I'm going to clean her."

Before she could kneel—

Friedhelm shifted.

Not violently.

Simply enough to place himself between Brunhild's hands and Leora.

A warning.

Low.

Almost inaudible.

Brunhild stopped immediately.

"I know."

She didn't sound offended.

Only patient.

"I won't touch her."

The warning vanished.

Friedhelm relaxed again.

Brunhild reached instead for the coat hanging beside the bed.

Leora's coat.

She straightened it carefully.

Almost absently.

"Wulf."

The whetstone stopped.

"Keep the fire hot."

He nodded once.

She looked back toward Friedhelm.

"If her fever climbs..."

She hesitated.

"...or she declines suddenly..."

Kiyomi watched Friedhelm's entire face change.

Only for a second.

His mouth tightened.

His eyes lost focus.

Like he'd already imagined it.

"...send for me immediately."

He nodded once.

Nothing more.

Brunhild walked around the bed.

Slowly.

She looked down at the two of them.

Then—

despite the warning from earlier—

she reached out.

Her fingers disappeared into Friedhelm's pale hair.

One slow stroke.

Then another.

His shoulders loosened.

After that...

she brushed Leora's hair away from her face.

Her voice softened.

"So there you are..."

She spoke another name.

Not Leora.

A smaller name.

A private one.

One Kiyomi had never heard before.

Friedhelm's eyes closed.

Wulf looked up from the fire.

Something in all three of them relaxed at once.

Kiyomi frowned.

Who...

...was she to them?

Brunhild stepped toward Wulf.

She rested a hand briefly against his shoulder.

"Amos' father has become important."

Silence.

"But politics changes."

Wulf stared into the flames.

"Don't do anything foolish."

Nothing.

Not even a nod.

Only the muscle in his jaw tightened.

His grip around the knife whitened.

Brunhild watched him another second.

Then quietly left.

The door closed.

Silence returned.

Only the fire.

Only breathing.

Only steel against leather.

Then—

Leora whimpered.

Soft.

Small.

Her body trembled.

Kiyomi jerked.

She hadn't made a sound before.

She had looked...

fine.

No.

Not fine.

Quiet.

Had she...

...been holding all of that in?

Friedhelm immediately shifted.

"So there you are..."

His voice was barely above a whisper.

He eased her upright.

She didn't wake.

He cleaned dried blood from the corner of her mouth.

Washed the mud from her cheek.

Unbraided what remained of her shortened hair.

Brushed it gently.

Then braided it again.

Slowly.

Carefully.

Like restoring something sacred.

Wulf looked over.

Their eyes met.

No words.

Just one look.

Something passed between them.

Something so practiced Kiyomi couldn't even begin to read it.

The hairs on her neck stood up.

Wulf looked back toward the fire.

"We should kill him."

Friedhelm continued braiding.

Nothing.

"We should."

Still nothing.

He finished tying the braid.

Adjusted the blanket.

Only then did he answer.

"Brunhild is usually right."

Wulf frowned.

Deeply.

"Why would I wait to kill something that threatens my foxes?"

Kiyomi blinked.

Foxes?

What foxes?

Friedhelm looked up.

"He doesn't threaten me."

The sound Wulf made...

Kiyomi had no word for it.

Not human.

Not quite.

A low, aching contradiction.

Like grief refusing reality.

"If he takes her..."

His eyes never left Leora.

"...you will suffer."

Silence.

"That possibility alone is enough."

His fingers tightened around the knife.

"I should kill him."

Friedhelm reached across the bed.

Covered Wulf's wrist.

"I will have you."

Wulf finally looked at him.

"I will have you..."

His thumb brushed once over Wulf's knuckles.

"...Elski."

The word landed inside Wulf like prayer.

But it wasn't enough.

Wulf shook his head.

"You don't understand."

His voice had become rough.

"Without her..."

He looked at Leora.

"...you will suffer."

"And when you suffer..."

He swallowed.

"...you disappear."

"You stop eating."

"You stop sleeping."

"You stop speaking."

"You stop looking at me."

His voice cracked.

"And then..."

"...I lose both of you."

Silence.

Friedhelm slowly withdrew his hand.

As though burned.

"You know nothing of me then."

The words struck Wulf like a blow.

He looked away.

The knife rested forgotten beside him.

Hours passed.

The fire burned low.

Leora suddenly lurched.

Blood splashed into the basin.

A wet cough.

Another.

More blood.

Friedhelm was already moving.

"Wulf."

He was on his feet before the word finished.

"Get Brunhild."

He ran.

Barefoot.

Out into the night.

Kiyomi followed instinctively—

Only to freeze.

A tall figure stepped into the corridor.

Friedrich.

He had clearly been waiting.

Without raising his voice—

"Wulf."

The young man stopped instantly.

Every muscle in his body locked.

Friedrich smiled.

"Come."

Wulf didn't move.

Not at first.

Then—

slowly—

he obeyed.

Friedrich turned toward the corridor leading to his office.

Never once looking back.

Wulf followed.

Kiyomi felt cold spread through her entire body.

No.

Not Brunhild.

Anywhere but—

Not with him.

The office door closed behind them.

And the memory refused to end.

Got it. I'll stay inside *your structure*, your beats, and your sequence — and I won't reinterpret or add new thematic framing. Just tightening and making it more immersive, slightly more restrained, less explanatory.

THE WITHERING — PART III (CLEAN IMMERSIVE VERSION)

Kiyomi opened the door slowly.

Wulf sat on a chair, tunic open, chest exposed. His gaze was lowered toward the grain of the desk in front of him, as if it had become the only stable thing in the room.

Friedrich sat behind the desk.

Composed. Comfortable.

Like nothing about this moment was unusual.

“She coughs.”

Wulf's jaw tightened. “Blood.”

Friedrich hummed.

“So?”

Wulf didn't look up.

Kiyomi noticed marks on Wulf's chest.

Faint. Irregular.

Did they come from Friedhelm?

Or something else?

Friedrich leaned back slightly, watching him.

Wulf made a small sound of frustration. “She could die.”

Friedrich rested his head in his hand.

“And?”

Wulf finally looked up.

“Call Brunhild.”

A pause.

Friedrich smiled faintly. “You’re so beautiful when you’re defiant.”

Wulf went still.

Kiyomi hated that tone.

Friedrich sighed. “You know what you have to do.”

Wulf froze.

“Please...”

His voice cracked, but the words were practiced. Controlled.

“Mein geliebter Gebieter, I beseech thee to call for Brunhild and the healer to see Leora.”

Friedrich’s smile sharpened.

“Die Alraune, nicht Leora. Sie ist kein Name, nur eine Art.”

He reached forward, gently pushing a strand of Wulf’s hair behind his ear.

“And you did not address me or the request correctly.”

Kiyomi felt the air shift.

Wulf’s shoulders dropped slightly.

“Mein geliebter Gebieter,” he said again, quieter now, “I ask you in full submission to consider calling a healer or Brunhild to see to the status of the Alraune.”

Friedrich watched him for a long moment.

Then:

“No.”

Wulf looked like something in him had gone very still.

Friedrich tilted his head. “You know, you’re pretty when you cry.”

Wulf didn’t respond.

Friedrich stood, rang a small bell.

A servant entered.

“Call the healer. Send for Brunhild. The Alraune needs to be secured.”

The servant left immediately.

Friedrich stepped forward and sat on the edge of the desk in front of Wulf.

“Tonight you will dine with me. Roasted rabbit. Your favorite.”

No reaction.

Wulf stayed still.

Friedrich’s smile lingered.

“I’ll have a bath drawn for you. Warm clothes. Warm food. A warm bed. A luxury others don’t have right now.”

He leaned slightly closer.

“I’m sure you’ll show me your appreciation.”

From outside the room, Brunhild’s voice rose—sharp, cutting through the house.

Kiyomi moved before she fully understood why.

When she returned, Leora was already in the room.

Covered in blood.

Brunhild had her turned onto her side.

A hollowed bone was inserted carefully as she worked.

Draining.

Controlled.

Leora's body shook faintly.

Friedhelm held her steady so she would not move.

Wulf stood nearby, rigid, watching everything without blinking.

Kiyomi couldn't look for long.

Later, when the room had quieted—

Brunhild spoke.

"Is she doing it?"

Friedhelm turned sharply.

"Never ask me that again."

A beat.

Brunhild nodded once.

"That confirms what I thought."

Friedhelm's expression hardened.

"Let's hope your thought was right."

Brunhild looked at him.

"But you can't be sure she isn't."

Silence.

Friedhelm did not answer.

Kiyomi felt it settle in her chest anyway.

Not spoken.

Not proven.

But forming.

So she is doing it.

You're right — I stripped out the *frame entirely*, which is the whole point of this scene in your structure. I'll restore it cleanly without adding new interpretation or reframing.

THE FIELD — BRUNHILD (KIYOMI WITNESS)

Kiyomi is already watching before she understands what she's looking at.

The field opens wide in every direction—wind pressing through grass that bends and rises like something alive. There is too much space for anything to hide in. Too much clarity. Nothing soft about it.

Brunhild stands waiting.

Shield forward. Spear already set. Not tense. Not preparing. Finished preparing.

Leora stands farther out.

Two small axes in her hands.

Kiyomi notices the difference immediately, even if she doesn't understand why it matters.

Brunhild moves first.

The impact is immediate.

Shield drives into Leora's space. Spear follows the same line. Not chasing—placing itself where escape would have been if escape had existed.

Leora is pushed back.

Again.

Brunhild does not let her reset. Every attempt to stabilize is cut off before it becomes real. The field compresses around Leora step by step until there is almost nowhere left to move.

Kiyomi feels it before she can name it.

This is not chaos.

This is control.

Leora forces her way inside anyway.

One axe disrupts the spear. The other strikes the shield edge. It is not enough to break Brunhild, but it is enough to break rhythm.

For a moment, something changes.

They are too close now.

Inside each other's space.

Brunhild adjusts immediately.

Shield comes inward. Spear begins to retract. Her stance corrects itself as she moves, rebuilding control before it is lost.

It almost resets.

Kiyomi exhales without realizing she was holding her breath.

Leora is forced back a step.

Then another.

Brunhild presses forward again.

Harder.

The shield rush collapses everything into one compressed line. The spear follows. It is clean. Final.

Leora does not fall.

The strike staggers her, but she stays inside the space of the fight.

Kiyomi sees it.

The first real crack.

Brunhild has overextended.

Just slightly.

The shield is still forward. The spear is still committed. Her recovery is delayed by a fraction of a second.

It should not matter.

It does.

Leora moves into it.

Axes rise.

Kiyomi tenses.

This is the end.

Brunhild sees it too.

Kiyomi sees it in her posture—that instant recognition, that correction about to happen. She will fix it. She will step back, reset, close it—

She does not.

The correction begins.

Then stops.

Brunhild holds the opening.

Just enough.

Kiyomi does not understand why.

Leora does not understand anything at all.

She only sees the space and takes it.

One axe locks Brunhild's arm. The other follows the exposed line.

Brunhild does not stop her.

The strike lands.

For a moment, Brunhild is still standing.

Kiyomi expects her to fall immediately.

She does not.

She remains upright as if the body is refusing to accept what has already happened.

Then she lowers herself into the grass.

Not collapsing.

Settling.

Like the fight has simply been put down.

Leora stands over her, breathing hard, seeing only what she did.

Not what was allowed.

Kiyomi feels her stomach twist.

Because she understands only one thing clearly.

Leora killed her.

And she did not even hesitate.

—

Got it. I'll keep this strictly in-scene, follow your sequence precisely, and preserve the emotional logic without adding new framing or reinterpretation.

RETURN — THE EIGHTH GATE

The memories do not end.

They blur into one another without transition, without warning, until Kiyomi can no longer tell where one life stops and another begins.

Leora's face. Friedhelm's hands. Wulf's voice. The cave. The field. The blood. The fire.

Too many versions of the same unbearable truth.

At some point, Kiyomi stops reacting.

Not because she understands.

Because she cannot anymore.

It becomes a rhythm.

A weight.

Something she is carried through rather than something she observes.

Then—

something breaks it.

A sound like breath dragged through pain.

Wulf.

He is there suddenly, not as a memory but as presence.

Panting. Bleeding. Kneeling in the water with her.

The waters of the Eighth Gate are still.

Black, smooth, reflecting nothing clearly.

Kiyomi is half-standing in it, though she does not remember entering.

Wulf grabs her.

Not gently.

Not roughly.

Urgently.

His hands close around her shoulders, then her arms, stabilizing her as if she might dissolve.

“Kiyomi,” he gasps.

She cannot respond.

Her eyes are still full of elsewhere.

He pulls her in close, lifting her fully from the water.

She is light in his arms, like something not fully anchored anymore.

Behind them, the gate does not move.

It simply **is**.

Wulf turns.

He carries her back.

They move through the threshold.

The First Gate waits ahead.

Not open.

Not closed.

Just present.

Vargr is there.

Already waiting.

Still.

Watching.

Wulf reaches the edge of the gate and stops.

He does not step through.

He lowers Kiyomi carefully, holding her upright just long enough for Vargr to take her.

Their hands overlap for a moment—Wulf and Vargr both supporting her weight.

Then Wulf releases.

He does not cross.

He steps back instead.

Into the water.

Not forward.

Not out.

Back.

Vargr takes her fully.

And guides her through.

Kiyomi crosses.

Into life.

She hits the ground immediately.

Not gracefully.

Not controlled.

Just collapse.

Her breath breaks as soon as she feels solid ground under her again.

And then—

she sobs.

Not quietly.

Not contained.

Her hands go to her hair, pulling hard as if trying to anchor herself through pain.

“No—no—no—”

Her voice fractures.

She sees them.

Still.

The boy and girl.

The children.

The cave.

The feeding.

The names.

The choices.

Sieg.

Sieg alone in her mind now, small and collared, the thought of him folding into everything else until it becomes unbearable.

Her future.

Her body.

The Alraune.

It all stacks too quickly.

She cannot separate it anymore.

She makes a broken sound and bends forward again, retching onto the ground.

Again.

And again.

Her body refuses what her mind is still trying to process.

Vargr stands above her.

Does not speak.

Does not move to comfort.

Just watches.

Kiyomi does not notice when Vargr turns away.

But he is gone when she looks up again.

Time passes incorrectly.

She does not stand.

She cannot.

When she tries, her legs fail halfway.

She drags herself through the estate corridors instead.

Kurohiko.

She needs to find him.

She does not know why anymore.

Only that if she cannot see him, something will not hold.

Rooms blur as she opens doors.

Empty.

Empty.

Empty.

Her breath is too fast. Too shallow.

Her vision tilts sideways.

She grips the wall, tries to steady herself, but her stomach twists violently and she retches again, sinking to her knees.

The floor is cold under her hands.

Her head drops forward.

She cannot tell anymore if she is still inside the memories.

Or if they are still inside her.

—

Understood. The structure was correct, but the *texture* wasn't there — too report-like, not enough lived-in collapse.

I'll re-render it with more immersion: less "sequence delivery," more sensory degradation, emotional drift, and Kiyomi losing coherence inside the scene.

PART ONE

Phase I: The Memory Poison Settles

Scene 1 — Dr. Moto's Office

Kiyomi is hiding.

Not in a place.

In herself.

It is not rest. It is not recovery. It is what remains when the mind stops being able to organize its own contents.

Her body is still in the estate somewhere, but she is not sure where the boundary between “after” and “still there” begins.

Hours have passed in broken fragments.

She remembers crying until there was nothing left in it but noise.

She remembers trying—again and again—to return to the Threads.

Each attempt ends the same way.

Nothing opens.

Only pressure.

Only refusal.

Only the feeling that something is looking back when she closes her eyes.

Sieg.

Collar too tight.

Too small.

Her daughter—she cannot hold the shape of her anymore without it turning wrong.

Leora in places she should not exist.

And herself—

always herself—

splitting into versions that do not agree on what she is allowed to be.

Alraune.

The word no longer sits in language.

It sits in her bones.

She vomits at some point.

She does not remember when.

Afterward, she is still on the floor.

Shaking.

Trying again anyway.

Failing again anyway.

Dr. Moto finds her without entrance or announcement.

He simply exists in the doorway when she looks up.

There is a pause.

Not dramatic.

Just recognition of wrongness.

Her skin is too pale.

Her eyes do not settle on anything for long enough to be normal.

Her hands are not steady even when she tries to still them.

He watches her for longer than a doctor should before he decides what she is.

Then he guides her out of wherever she has collapsed into and brings her to his office.

Not gently.

Not roughly.

Professionally.

As if force is not required for something already unstable.

The office should mean safety.

It does not.

The moment she enters, her attention catches on the shelves.

Not because she is looking.

Because something inside her already knows what is there.

Books.

Wrong books.

Books she has never read but recognizes anyway.

Threads-texts.

Alraune records.

Genealogies that feel like memory that does not belong to her life.

Ten Brinken bloodlines written in ink that feels too old to still be dry.

Medical charts she understands without knowing why she understands them.

Her throat tightens.

Slowly.

As if the room itself is closing around a shape she cannot escape.

Moto begins the examination.

He avoids her eyes when he can.

Pulse.

Breathing.

Small instructions she barely processes.

He writes more than he speaks.

Too precise.

Too controlled.

Like writing is the only thing preventing him from acknowledging what is in front of him.

Kiyomi keeps looking at the books.

Each glance makes something in her tighten further.

Not fear yet.

Something worse than fear.

Recognition without permission.

Then Moto pauses.

Just slightly.

A hesitation so small it almost does not exist.

But Kiyomi feels it anyway.

He looks at her differently.

Not as a patient.

As a question that has changed shape mid-answer.

"...Congratulations."

The word lands wrong.

Like it belongs to a different conversation entirely.

Kiyomi does not respond.

Her mouth does not know what it is supposed to do with it.

Moto continues anyway.

Careful.

Measured.

“Very early.”

A pause.

“But yes.”

“You are pregnant.”

The room goes quiet in a way that is not silence.

It is subtraction.

Something removed.

Something essential.

Kiyomi stares at him as if he has spoken from another body.

Then the second shift happens.

Moto’s pen slows.

Stops.

His eyes narrow slightly—not suspicion exactly, but recalibration.

Something about her no longer fits his expectations.

“Family history?”

Kiyomi blinks.

“Ancestry?”

Her breath stutters.

“Bloodline?”

Each word feels heavier than the last.

Then—

“Are you a Ten Brinken?”

The name hits wrong.

Too specific.

Too close.

Kiyomi’s lips part.

Nothing comes out immediately.

Then—

“Leora thinks we’re distantly related.”

Silence breaks something.

Moto stops writing completely.

The sound of pen leaving paper is louder than it should be.

The room changes again.

Not physically.

Structurally.

The air feels slower.

More deliberate.

Moto sets the pen down as if he no longer trusts it.

“What’s wrong?”

He does not answer his own question.

Not yet.

And Kiyomi understands before he speaks.

That is the worst part.

Not revelation.

Anticipation of it.

Her thoughts begin collapsing inward.

Not cleanly.

Like sinking.

Snake folding into itself.

World tree splitting and re-rooting through its own trunk.

Threads overlapping until there is no longer a distinction between path and possibility.

Alraune.

It is not a title.

It is a condition of being overwritten.

And then the thought arrives fully formed.

Not chosen.

Not argued.

Just there.

We did everything right.

They waited.

They were in love.

They slept together as man and wife.

It should have been enough.

It should have stabilized something.

But it didn't.

Leora must be dying.

Nidr's voice is not present, but its logic is.

Awakening equals consequence.

Pregnancy equals collapse.

Meaning has already been assigned.

She is only arriving late to it.

Kiyomi's breath breaks.

Not once.

Repeatedly.

Her hands curl into the fabric of her own sleeves as if she can hold herself together through pressure alone.

Then—

a sound that is barely voice.

"Is she dying?"

A pause.

It fractures further.

"Am I killing her?"

Moto exhales.

Not judgmental.

Not kind.

Just exhausted by truths that arrive too late to prevent damage.

“Yes.”

A beat.

“It seems you are.”

And the room does not recover from that.

It simply remains that way.

—

Got it. I'll keep your structure intact, preserve the emotional dissonance, and lean harder into *felt contradiction* rather than explanation.

PART TWO

Phase II: The Family Gathering

Scene 2 — Arrival at the Training Grounds

Kurohiko finds her before she fully manages to steady herself.

He does not ask questions immediately.

He simply looks at her.

As if he already knows she has come back wrong.

There is a pause between them—small, ordinary to anyone else, but heavy enough that Kiyomi feels it settle into her ribs.

Then he speaks.

“Dinner is soon.”

A beat.

“They’re outside.”

His hand lifts slightly, not quite reaching her yet.

“Playing.”

Another pause.

“Come.”

He takes her there.

The estate opens into training grounds that should feel familiar.

But they don’t.

Not anymore.

The air is too clean.

The light too soft.

The sounds too alive.

And everything is—

beautiful.

That is the problem.

It is too intact to hold what she has seen.

Too whole to survive contact with it.

Kiyomi sees them one by one.

Like a sequence she cannot interrupt.

Chōbei running across the grass.

Tsukihiko just ahead of him.

Always just ahead.

Chōbei reaches again.

Misses again.

Tsukihiko laughs—bright, careless—and twists away like a fox slipping through hands that were never meant to close around him.

Chōbei keeps chasing.

Still laughing too.

Still trying.

As if failure is part of the game, not the end of it.

Toma sits slightly apart.

Kaguya beside him.

Yarn spread between them like a language only they understand.

Toma's fingers fumble through the shape of something meant to be simple.

Kaguya sighs softly every time he gets it wrong.

She corrects him without stopping her own work.

Not harsh.

Not patient either.

Just... certain.

Toma looks completely aware of every correction.

And completely content to receive them.

Mizuki sparring lightly with Sieg.

Wooden blades.

Controlled motion.

Sieg is smaller than the others around him, but he moves with focus that does not belong to his age.

Mizuki taps his guard aside.

Sieg adjusts.

Again.

Again.

No anger.

No frustration.

Just repetition.

Friedhelm is further in.

Higan in his arms.

He lifts him once.

Twice.

Higan shrieks every time, delighted in a way that has no memory of fear in it.

Friedhelm catches him each time without effort.

Like gravity is negotiable if you understand it well enough.

And then—

Sukuna.

Leora.

Kiyomi stops before she understands she has stopped.

The world narrows around them.

Sukuna circles her.

Slow.

Deliberate.

Like he is inspecting something that belongs to him and refuses to behave as an object should.

Leora does not step away.

She does not leave.

She pretends annoyance in a way that is almost casual.

Almost practiced.

He reaches for her.

Hair first.

Wrist.

Waist.

Neck.

Each touch familiar enough that it does not register as intrusion.

It registers as routine.

Like something repeated so many times it has lost the shape of surprise.

Leora scratches his shoulders in return.

Then his neck.

Then slides her fingers through his hair.

Not pushing him away.

Not pulling him closer.

Just... there.

Sukuna leans in.

Buries his face against her neck.

Holds her like someone anchoring himself to something warm enough to survive contact with.

He breathes her in.

Deep.

Like he is confirming she is still real.

Leora smiles.

Not forced.

Not performative.

Simply present.

Kiyomi cannot reconcile it.

The woman in front of her does not fit inside anything she has seen.

Not the cave.

Not the field.

Not the sorting.

Not the child decisions.

Not Wulf.

Not Friedhelm.

Not anything.

It does not layer.

It collides.

And refuses to resolve.

Kurohiko notices before she speaks.

Of course he does.

He always does.

He steps slightly closer.

Not intruding.

Just enough.

Careful.

He reaches up and moves a strand of her hair behind her ear.

A simple gesture.

Grounding.

“What's wrong?”

Kiyomi does not look at him.

Her eyes are still caught on Leora.

On Sukuna.

On the impossibility of coexistence.

“Nothing.”

The word comes out too quickly.

Too flat.

A lie that does not even fully belong to her.

End Phase II.

Understood. I'll keep the scene *tight, escalating through subtext*, and let the rupture happen through perception shifts rather than explicit explanation.

PART TWO (continued)

Phase III: The Predator Notices

Scene 3 — Initial Conversation

It starts too normally to feel like anything important.

That is the first mistake.

The grounds remain alive around them—still laughter somewhere behind them, still movement, still the illusion of a world that is not about to change shape.

Leora joins them without announcement.

She simply appears within the group's orbit as if she had always been part of it.

Black riding trousers.

Black boots.

Black coat hanging loose from her shoulders.

Black turtleneck beneath it, worn thin at the edges like it has seen too many days without rest.

Kiyomi notices her body before she notices her face.

Too still in the wrong places.

Too tired in the right ones.

Cold—not in temperature, but in persistence.

Red-rimmed eyes that do not belong to sleep deprivation alone.

Pale skin that catches the light differently than it should.

Moonlit.

Fading.

And Kiyomi's stomach tightens without permission.

I am killing her.

The thought is not spoken.

It is already inside her.

Leora speaks.

Nothing important at first.

Something about dinner.

Something about training schedules.

Something that would normally dissolve into the background of a family gathering.

No one reacts strangely.

No one pauses.

Except Leora.

Leora is watching Kiyomi.

Not openly.

Not aggressively.

Just... registering.

Like a hand hovering near a blade it has not yet decided to draw.

The conversation continues.

Then shifts.

Small questions begin to appear in it.

Not accusations.

Not yet.

Observations that do not belong to casual speech.

Pauses that are slightly too long.

Repetitions that feel like testing rather than confusion.

Kiyomi answers.

Too quickly.

Too carefully.

The air changes by fractions.

Nothing anyone can point to.

But something in Leora's posture adjusts.

Not defensive.

Not hostile.

Contained.

Sukuna notices first.

Of course he does.

He stops circling the space he occupies.

Not fully.

Just enough that his weight redistributes.

Hands remain in pockets.

Shoulders loose.

Expression unchanged.

But the stillness shifts.

Predator stillness now.

Not relaxed.

Prepared.

His eyes move between Leora and Kiyomi.

Measuring.

Not reacting.

Chōbei drifts closer to Tsukihiko without meaning to.

Tsukihiko does not notice at first.

Toma's hands slow over the yarn.

Kaguya stops correcting him mid-motion for the first time.

Mizuki glances up from Sieg's stance correction.

Friedhelm looks up fully.

Kurohiko's attention sharpens without changing expression.

The group does not break apart.

But it realigns.

Around something none of them have named.

Leora speaks again.

And this time the temperature drops—not in the air, but in the exchange itself.

A question.

Simple.

Directed.

Kiyomi answers again.

Still too fast.

Still too controlled.

And Leora goes still.

Not visibly.

But completely.

It is subtle enough that most people would miss it.

Sukuna does not.

His head tilts slightly.

Just enough.

Like he is listening to something beneath the conversation.

Something no one else can hear yet.

And then—

it happens.

Not escalation.

Recognition.

Leora looks at Kiyomi differently.

Not anger.

Not hurt.

Something older.

Heavier.

Like memory striking memory.

Like something being identified that should not exist outside a very small number of people.

Sukuna sees it at the same moment.

His expression does not change.

But his attention locks fully.

Predator focus now.

Absolute.

The space tightens.

Chōbei unconsciously moves closer to Tsukihiko again.

Kurohiko's gaze sharpens.

Mizuki shifts his stance without realizing.

Friedhelm stops moving entirely.

Even Toma looks up.

The group does not speak.

But they are no longer casual.

They are waiting for something to happen.

Leora exhales once.

Controlled.

Then speaks.

Not loudly.

Not sharply.

"I should go."

No one stops her.

At first.

Because no one has decided yet what just changed.

Kiyomi does not think.

She moves.

And the moment she steps forward—

everything in the space understands she has made a decision the room cannot take back.

Leora has already turned slightly.

Sukuna's attention is fully engaged now.

Friedhelm shifts.

Kurohiko moves a fraction closer.

Chōbei freezes mid-step.

Mizuki's hand tightens on wood.

Toma stops breathing for half a second.

And Kiyomi—

cannot let her go.

—

You're right to flag that—that question is structurally important, and removing it changes the whole pressure of the scene. I'll correct that and stay faithful to your sequence, only tightening immersion and emotional escalation without stripping key dialogue.

Leora does not turn immediately.

The pause stretches.

Too long to be casual.

Too short to be hesitation anyone wants to name out loud.

Sukuna notices it first.

Not fully at first—just a fractional discontinuity in her movement, like a step in a dance arriving half a beat earlier than expected.

His eyes sharpen.

Something in him reorients.

Leora turns.

Not abruptly.

Not slowly.

Completely.

Her gaze lands on Kiyomi and stays there.

No confusion.

No irritation.

Only recognition.

Not of the words.

Of what stands behind them.

No one speaks.

The space is no longer a gathering.

It has become a held breath shared between too many bodies.

Chōbei is still mid-shift toward Tsukihiko.

Toma has stopped moving entirely.

Mizuki's grip on wood tightens without thought.

Friedhelm is motionless.

Kurohiko watches Kiyomi now instead of Leora.

Sukuna does not move at all.

But his attention is absolute.

Predatory stillness.

Leora exhales.

A short, contained sound.

Not relief.

Not annoyance.

Recognition.

Something in her face goes distant for a fraction of a second—like she is hearing something under the surface of the world.

Then she looks at Kiyomi again.

And Kiyomi speaks.

Her voice does not feel like her own when it comes out.

“What if one day you look at me and think *‘You are not mine’* anymore?”

Leora pauses her stride so slightly even Sukuna misses it at first.

Then he catches it.

Immediately.

His expression tightens.

Leora does not move forward.

She also does not turn away.

Kiyomi continues, breath catching—

“And if you decided that, does that mean that one day... if Friedhelm is laying in a cave, starving, vomiting black that you’d—”

Leora stops walking.

Fully.

The silence snaps into place around it.

No one breathes correctly anymore.

Kiyomi hesitates.

Everyone is listening now like the answer will determine something irreversible.

“Would you take up the bow and hunt me?”

Leora does not turn around.

No one speaks.

The tension thickens into something almost physical.

Kiyomi pushes forward anyway, voice unsteady now—

“Would you bring me back to the den and portion me into thirds?”

Leora’s hands remain in her pockets.

Loose posture.

Still relaxed.

Still wrong in its calm.

Kiyomi inhales shakily.

The sound is too loud.

Leora turns.

Not fast.

Not slow.

Final.

Her eyes meet Kiyomi's.

And there is no shock there.

No emotional rupture.

Only understanding.

And something colder underneath it:

confirmation that Kiyomi has been shown something she should not have seen.

Kiyomi waits.

No one speaks.

No one understands the question in the way it is meant to be understood.

Sukuna is still as a mountain.

Leora makes a short exhalation sound.

Low.

Controlled.

Familiar in a way that does not belong in this room.

Kiyomi remembers it.

The den.

Blood-warm air.

Wulf's hands.

Friedhelm watching.

The Vargref being carved and sealed into skin.

Kiyomi's gaze flicks—

down.

To Leora's hip.

Not consciously.

Something inside her forces the confirmation.

Sukuna follows it instantly.

Faster than anyone should be able to.

His attention locks onto the same point.

A scar.

Subtle.

Irregular.

Not decorative.

Not obvious unless already known.

His expression tightens.

Not understanding.

Calculating.

Trying to place meaning onto something that refuses to resolve.

Leora's face changes.

Not emotionally.

Structurally.

The warmth that usually sits behind her presence disappears.

What remains is colder.

Stripped of softness.

Not anger.

Not fear.

Recognition of exposure.

Her eyes sharpen into something unreadable.

And she speaks again.

Quiet.

Controlled.

But no longer distant.

“You shouldn’t have seen that.”

A beat.

Then—

“What did you see?”

The question lands differently than anything before it.

Not curiosity.

Not accusation.

Containment.

Like she is trying to determine how much of Kiyomi has already been altered.

Confrontation — Part I

Kiyomi's lips parted.

For a moment, no sound came.

When it finally did, her voice was unsteady enough that every word seemed to hurt on its way out.

"...Why didn't you wait for Wulf to come off the field before you left?"

Silence.

Leora did not answer.

She did not shift her weight.

She did not blink.

She became so still that Sukuna found himself watching her chest, trying to determine whether she was still breathing at all.

Kiyomi swallowed.

"I watched him."

Her voice broke.

"I watched his face constantly."

She looked at Leora as though she wished she could unsee everything.

"He never looked anywhere except at you... or Friedhelm."

Another breath.

"He loved you."

The words landed heavily.

"You told him in that cave that you loved him."

"I saw it."

"You took his mark on your hip."

"You put yours on his arm."

Her hands shook harder.

"You bound yourself to him..."

She looked toward Sukuna only briefly before looking back.

"...but I've never seen you wear a bracelet."

"A ring."

"Anything from your marriage to Sukuna."

The words hung in the air.

Kiyomi lowered her eyes.

"You knew."

"You knew leaving would destroy him."

She laughed once.

It sounded sick.

"I spent years feeling sorry for you."

"I thought you were stolen."

"I thought you were dragged away from your children."

"I thought you were surviving."

She looked back up.

"But that isn't what happened."

"It was your choice that led to all of it."

Leora remained motionless.

Only her eyes changed.

The pale silver of them seemed to brighten until they looked almost white beneath the evening light.

Kiyomi noticed.

It frightened her.

Still she continued.

"And then..."

Her voice became quieter.

"I pitied you because I thought being married against your will..."

"...living every hour waiting to be violated..."

"...would have been unbearable."

A tear slipped down her face.

"But I was foolish."

"How could I have known..."

"...that you agreed to stay?"

"To become breeding stock."

"To remain the Alraune."

"To go back into that machine."

Her breathing became ragged.

"And then..."

"...you talked about having replacement children."

"A daughter."

"A son."

"So your real children would be safe."

She stared at Leora in disbelief.

"You were willing to trade children..."

"...to preserve what you wanted."

The disgust in her own voice startled even her.

"You slept with Wulf."

"You were going to have children."

"A daughter for slaughter."

"You were going to do all of it..."

"...for Friedhelm."

Her shoulders shook.

"You were willing to surrender your life."

"Your freedom."

"Everything."

"For Friedhelm."

"And Wulf..."

She laughed again.

This time it dissolved into tears.

"...had no idea."

"He was second place."

"He always was."

She covered her mouth.

The sob that escaped anyway was ugly.

Raw.

Uncontrolled.

"You accepted everyone else's suffering..."

"...because one person mattered more."

She stared at Leora through tears.

"Poor Wulf."

"You didn't just leave him."

"You made him need you first."

The words barely made it out.

"And then..."

"...you took yourself away anyway."

Kiyomi was crying openly now.

Not graceful tears.

Not quiet grief.

She shook so violently Kurohiko nearly stepped forward before catching himself.

"How..."

"How do I know..."

"...you wouldn't do that to me too?"

"To Sukuna?"

"To all of us?"

She looked at Leora as though seeing her for the first time.

"I saw Friedrich place you into Friedhelm's arms."

"He was three."

"Wulf looked at you..."

Her voice softened.

"...and loved you immediately."

"It was written all over his face."

She wiped at her cheeks with trembling hands.

"And maybe..."

"...maybe you met Sukuna..."

"...and maybe you truly fell in love with him."

She tried to continue.

Failed.

Bent forward as another sob tore through her.

When she finally found enough breath to speak again, her voice had become almost hoarse.

"But even if you didn't love Wulf anymore..."

"...you owed him."

"You owed him enough to go back."

"To save him from your father."

"To release him from what Friedrich did to him."

Her eyes filled again.

"Wulf did it for you."

"He took Friedhelm's place."

"He gave himself..."

"...over..."

"...and over..."

"...and over again."

"For medicine."

"For water."

"For clothes."

"For food."

"For protection."

"Everything..."

"...paid for with his body."

"His mind."

"His soul."

She looked at Leora one last time.

Then whispered,

"And you left him..."

Her voice disappeared.

When it returned it was barely audible.

"...in the shit..."

"...the mud..."

"...the blood..."

"...and the rain..."

"...while ravens croaked overhead."

Confrontation — Part II

The silence that followed was somehow worse than the accusation.

Kiyomi stood trembling, her breathing ragged from crying.

When she spoke again, her voice had lost its anger.

What remained was heartbreak.

"...Do you know what they call you?"

Leora did not answer.

Kiyomi

Confrontation — Part II

Kiyomi wiped at her face with the heel of her hand.

It accomplished nothing.

Fresh tears replaced the old ones almost immediately.

When she spoke again, her voice had changed.

It was quieter now.

Quieter was worse.

"Do you know what they call you?"

Leora said nothing.

Kiyomi looked past her, toward the village below the estate.

"The people in the village."

"The farms."

"The countryside."

"They call you..."

Her throat tightened.

"...the Mother of the Moon."

The title hung in the air.

"They say you illuminate what others can't see."

"That when everything is dark..."

"...you are the one who finds the way."

She laughed weakly.

"I believed them."

She looked directly at Leora.

"I thought you were the protector of children."

"The protector of women."

"The one who fed people when famine came."

"The moral force inside a broken world."

Another silence.

"But now..."

Her face twisted.

"...now I understand what people mean when they say..."

"Beautiful predators have always disguised hunger as kindness."

The words landed like stones.

"I watched you sort people."

"You decided who would become slaves."

"You decided who would be executed."

"You decided whose lives still had value."

"You decided who was useful enough to remain a person."

She shook her head.

"I watched you look at women..."

"...beautiful women..."

"...and send them north."

Her voice cracked.

"I knew what waited for them."

"I watched you decide which women were already past their prime."

"You betrayed them."

"You didn't even hesitate."

She pressed a shaking hand against her stomach.

"And the children..."

She nearly couldn't continue.

"You removed futures because you decided they didn't matter."

"I watched children..."

"...children..."

"...be sent to die like animals."

Her eyes searched Leora's face desperately.

"What I couldn't understand..."

"...what I still can't understand..."

"...is why."

"They were healthy."

"They could have survived."

"They could have been integrated."

"They could have become free."

"They could have strengthened the Tribes."

"They had futures."

"So why?"

Her voice rose.

"Why couldn't you let them have a chance?"

A beat.

Her face contorted.

"Did you enjoy it?"

"The moment..."

"...when hope became despair?"

Nobody moved.

Nobody interrupted.

Kiyomi kept speaking.

"I watched you share food with people."

"Share shelter."

"Ask about their mothers."

"Their sisters."

"Their homes."

"And then..."

"...when morning came..."

"...you cut their throats."

She swallowed hard.

"You shed loyalties like a duck sheds water."

Her breathing shook.

"It is a wonder anyone ever believed a word you said."

She laughed once.

There was no humor in it.

"Then I heard someone say..."

"...that the Alraune can compel."

"I suppose that answers the question."

Her eyes returned to Leora.

"And then..."

"...I finally understood the famines."

She spoke the next words as if reciting a sentence she wished were false.

"You manufactured them."

"You used the power of the Alraune."

"When people starved..."

"...you were the reason."

"When women were beaten and sold for food..."

"...you were the reason."

"When children died in the streets..."

"...you were the reason."

"When Wulf had to walk into your father's bedroom during winter..."

Her voice broke again.

"...you're why he had to."

The courtyard had become impossibly still.

Even the wind seemed to have stopped.

Kiyomi looked at Leora with eyes full of grief rather than hatred.

"I know what happened after your father cut your hair."

"I learned what everyone was too afraid to say."

"The Third Alraune."

She looked between the gathered faces.

"The greatest catastrophe in Ten Brinken history."

"She survived systematic cruelty."

"She never learned love."

"She never broke."

Her gaze settled back on Leora.

"She was defiant."

Sukuna's expression changed almost imperceptibly.

Defiant.

The word lodged somewhere deep inside him.

Because it described Leora with unsettling precision.

Kiyomi continued.

"She was everything you are."

"Beautiful."

"Brilliant."

"Alien."

"Entirely aware of what she was."

"She turned every instinct of the Alraune against the people who created her."

"Obsession."

"Desire."

"Projection."

"Fortune."

"Influence."

"She weaponized every one of them."

"Deliberately."

Her breathing steadied just enough to finish.

"Every tradition."

"Every cruelty."

"Every attempt to break an Alraune..."

"...exists because of the Third."

Her voice became almost a whisper.

"And now because of you."

"You proved them right."

"You used your power to hurt instead of help."

"To wither instead of grow."

"To make the human become inhuman."

She wrapped her arms around herself as though she were freezing.

"And because of you..."

Her hand trembled against her abdomen.

"...I am supposed to suffer the same fate..."

"...when you die."

.

Confrontation — Part III

Kiyomi looked suddenly unsteady.

Her face had gone pale.

She swallowed once.

Then whispered,

"...Bjorn."

Another breath.

"...and Birna."

Across from her, Leora became somehow even stiller.

Sukuna watched her closely.

She had not moved since Kiyomi began speaking.

Now he was no longer certain she was breathing.

Then—

Something crossed her face.

Not fear.

Not grief.

The faintest tightening at one corner of her mouth.

Almost contempt.

Almost.

Kiyomi saw it.

"I watched you walk toward them."

Her voice shook.

"You were singing."

Softly, almost unconsciously, she repeated the words she could never forget.

Vagr...

Og um vit mugu velja...

And if we must choose...

tað eingin faðir eigur at velja...

what no father should choose...

tað eingin móðir eigur at velja...

what no mother should choose...

so hygg ekki burtur...

then do not look away...

Sit hjá okkum í myrkrinum...

Sit beside us in the dark...

Ver hjá teimum sum bera skuldina...

Remain with those who carry the guilt...

Tí tú kennir hungur...

For you know hunger...

Og tú kennir eisini kærleika...

And you know love also...

Og stundum síggja tey eins út.

And sometimes they look the same.

The courtyard remained silent.

"I felt it."

"Your Lieder."

"The forest..."

"...became quieter."

"Everything relaxed."

"So did they."

"They didn't fear you."

"They welcomed you."

Her voice cracked.

"They trusted you."

Kiyomi looked directly into Leora's eyes.

"Bjorn loved Friedhelm like a kindred spirit. A brother."

"He asked about him."

"He asked about Wulf."

"They were sorry they were sick."

"They asked you..."

"...what you would do if they died."

A tear rolled down her cheek.

"You told them you wouldn't live."

"I believed you."

She laughed bitterly.

"I believed every word."

She closed her eyes.

"When you looked at Birna..."

"I thought you were relieved."

"I thought you were happy she had survived."

Her eyes opened again.

"I didn't understand."

"I didn't know..."

"...you were evaluating her to determine if you could eat her."

Silence.

"When it was over..."

"You returned."

"You fed Wulf."

"You fed Friedhelm."

"And afterward..."

"...you ate with them."

Her voice became smaller.

"I kept waiting."

"For you to break."

"To cry."

"To look sick."

"To hate yourself."

"You never did."

Another long silence.

"That was when I realized..."

She shook her head slowly.

"...this wasn't the first time."

"You had carried that burden before. When you sorted slaves, some were sent to become your dinner. What a burden."

"And if the world demanded it again..."

"...you would carry it again."

Sukuna heard every word.

He understood them.

Yet his mind refused them.

He remembered the first months after bringing Leora into the estate.

The day he had quietly stopped eating human flesh.

Not because anyone had demanded it.

Because he had looked at her—

—and found himself unwilling to become something that might drive her away.

He had believed that choice belonged to him alone.

Now Kiyomi was telling him the woman he had changed himself for had once survived a world where even that boundary had been erased.

His stomach turned.

He looked toward his children.

He saw it happen before anyone spoke.

Confusion.

Revulsion.

Shame.

Questions.

The same fears that had haunted him for years.

The children of a cannibal.

He had buried that history so they would never carry it.

Now another history had been dragged into the light.

And through it all—

Leora did not defend herself.

She did not lower her head.

She did not ask forgiveness.

She simply stood there.

Cold.

Motionless.

Almost unbearably calm.

Kiyomi drew one long, shaking breath.

When she spoke again, her voice was scarcely audible.

"You didn't grieve..."

She looked at Leora as though searching for the woman she thought she knew.

"...what you used."

I think the strongest version is to let ***Livrun*** land almost like a curse. Up until now, Kiyomi has been making accusations. This is the first moment where she proves she has seen something she should never have seen.

Kiyomi's voice had become quieter with every accusation.

Not calmer.

Emptier.

"I don't understand."

Her hands trembled so violently she finally stopped trying to hide it.

"I don't understand how you lived with any of it."

Silence.

"I don't understand why you did it."

She swallowed hard.

"...Why did you kill Brunhild?"

For the first time since the confrontation began—

Friedhelm moved.

"No."

His voice cracked.

It wasn't denial.

It was warning.

He took one step forward.

"No."

Everyone looked at him.

His breathing had changed.

His chest rose too fast.

His eyes had widened—not with anger.

With panic.

He looked at Kiyomi as if she were walking toward the edge of a cliff she could not see.

"Stop."

His voice shook.

"Stop talking."

No one had ever heard Friedhelm sound like this.

Not Sukuna.

Not Kurohiko.

Not the children.

There was terror in him.

Raw.

Primal.

He took another step.

"Stop this."

His hands were shaking now.

"Stop before you compound your fate, Kiyomi."

The words landed strangely.

Not like a threat.

Like a plea.

Like someone begging another person not to place their hand into a fire.

Kiyomi looked at him through swollen eyes.

She didn't stop.

This hurt too much now.

"She..." Her voice broke.

"...she gave you a name."

A sound tore out of Friedhelm.

It wasn't human.

It was short.

Violent.

Something ripped from so deep inside him that every person present instinctively stiffened.

Even Higan stopped moving.

The courtyard seemed to hold its breath.

Sukuna looked at Leora.

Her eyes—

They weren't silver anymore.

The moonlight inside them had darkened.

Gold.

Not warm.

Not bright.

Ancient.

Predatory.

She hadn't moved a single inch.

Her hands remained in her pockets.

Her posture remained loose.

But Sukuna suddenly realized—

She hadn't blinked in a very long time.

Kiyomi drew one slow, shaking breath.

It felt like she was stepping somewhere she could never return from.

"I saw her."

Another breath.

"I saw her hold you."

"I saw her protect you."

"I saw her help Friedhelm name you."

Her voice cracked completely.

"She loved you."

No one spoke.

No one understood.

Only Friedhelm looked as though every word was another knife.

Then Kiyomi whispered the name.

"...Why did you kill her..."

A pause.

"...Livrun?"

The world stopped.

Friedhelm's face emptied.

Not of emotion.

Of everything.

As though his mind had simply ceased functioning.

Sukuna had no idea what the word meant.

Neither did Kurohiko.

Or Chōbei.

Or Mizuki.

Or Sieg.

But they all knew—

Kiyomi had just spoken something that did not belong to this world.

Something buried.

Something no outsider should have known.

Sukuna's eyes never left Leora.

She finally inhaled.

Once.

Slowly.

Her gaze settled fully on Kiyomi.

There was no anger in it.

No surprise.

Only certainty.

Someone had taken Kiyomi into the past.

Someone had shown her what had been hidden for decades.

And in that single moment—

Leora knew exactly who had done it.

Got it — I'll keep the back-to-back structure and the emotional logic you've built, and I'll adjust tone to reflect Kiyomi's limited personal history with Leora (2–3 years, not lifelong framing), while keeping your dialogue intact and intensifying the misinterpretation pressure without reshaping your intent.

CONFRONTATION — CONTINUED SCENE (REWRITE, PRESERVING YOUR BEATS)

The silence after Leora's final words does not release.

It tightens.

Like the air itself has been instructed not to move.

Sukuna feels it in his ribs before he understands it in his mind.

Kiyomi stands trembling inside it.

Not because she is afraid of violence.

Because she has already said too much to take back.

Leora does not turn immediately.

She stays still for a moment too long—like something inside her is deciding whether Kiyomi is still inside the circle of people worth softness.

Then she exhales.

Short.

Flat.

Almost bored.

And turns.

Not sharply.

Not emotionally.

Like she has already finished the conversation somewhere else, and this is just the body catching up.

Her eyes land on Kiyomi.

And there is no warmth left in them.

Only recognition.

And something heavier.

Not rage.

Not cruelty.

Disappointment that has already finished forming.

“You are a very stupid little girl.”

The words are not loud.

They do not need to be.

Leora tilts her head slightly, studying Kiyomi as if seeing her properly for the first time in a long while.

“And you disappoint me.”

Kiyomi flinches.

Not from volume.

From correctness.

Leora takes a step forward.

Then another.

Unhurried.

Unavoidable.

“You want answers,” she says softly. “So you came with conclusions already formed and called them questions.”

Her gaze flicks over Kiyomi like she is assessing damage that has already occurred.

“And now you are surprised the world does not bend to fit them.”

A pause.

“You are not seeing me,” Leora continues. “You are seeing what was placed inside you before you ever spoke to me.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrow slightly.

He does not like that phrasing.

Leora continues anyway.

“And you have decided it is truth.”

Kiyomi’s lips part—

but Leora raises a hand slightly.

Not commanding.

Just stopping.

“And you are wrong.”

Silence compresses again.

Leora exhales once through her nose.

Almost tired.

Then:

“You are twenty-one.”

A beat.

“Newly married.”

Another.

“You have raised a brother.”

A pause.

“You have hunted. Fed. Worked. Survived.”

Her eyes sharpen slightly.

“You are not a child.”

A beat.

“But you are behaving like someone who has never had to understand consequence beyond emotion.”

Kiyomi’s face tightens.

Leora steps closer.

Not threatening in movement.

Threatening in certainty.

“You announced I am dying.”

A pause.

“That information did not belong to you.”

The words land cleanly.

Sukuna's attention sharpens at that.

Leora continues, voice cooling further.

"You did not consider what that would do to anyone here."

A small tilt of her head.

"That is... irritating."

Kiyomi shakes.

Leora's expression hardens slightly—but not into anger.

Into clarity.

"Yes. I ate people."

A beat.

"Yes. I sorted them."

Another.

"Yes. No one is more important to me than Friedhelm."

Her gaze holds Kiyomi steady.

"And yes—Wulf loved me."

A pause.

"Yes."

Another breath.

"I love Wulf."

The words do not soften.

They do not justify.

They simply exist.

Sukuna goes still at that.

Kiyomi's breathing breaks.

Leora continues without hesitation.

“Yes. I carried Wulf’s mark on my skin.”

A pause.

“And I did not wear a ring or bracelet because Sukuna never gave me one.”

That lands differently.

Not as accusation.

As correction.

Leora steps forward again.

Now the space between them feels reduced in a way that is not physical but structural.

“You are trying to assemble a person from fragments,” she says. “And pretending you have assembled a truth.”

A pause.

“You have not.”

Her gaze sharpens.

“You are reacting to pieces of my life without understanding what held those pieces together.”

Silence.

Leora’s voice drops slightly.

“And you think that reaction is insight.”

Another step.

“But it is not.”

A beat.

“It is noise.”

Kiyomi’s hands tremble.

Leora continues.

“You came into this estate underweight.”

A pause.

“Half-starved.”

Another.

“Carrying grief that made you hallucinate your dead as if they were still speaking.”

Sukuna’s attention shifts slightly at that—he had not known the extent of it.

Leora’s gaze does not move.

“And you were breaking.”

A beat.

“I did not fix you.”

Another.

“I gave you stability long enough for you to stop collapsing.”

Her voice tightens slightly—not softer, just precise.

“You were allowed to stop surviving.”

A pause.

“You were allowed to become someone who could stand without bleeding into the ground.”

Silence stretches.

Leora’s eyes narrow.

“And now you stand here and call that corruption.”

Kiyomi tries to speak.

Leora does not let her.

“I have never failed you.”

A beat.

“Not once.”

Silence.

Leora exhales once.

Then:

"I have always been what you needed me to be."

A pause.

"And you have mistaken that for ownership."

Her eyes sharpen.

"That is your mistake."

Not cruelty.

Diagnosis.

Leora steps back slightly now.

Not retreating.

Closing.

"You are not thinking clearly."

A beat.

"You are not seeing clearly."

Another.

"And you are not strong enough to carry what you think you have learned."

Silence.

Her gaze locks onto Kiyomi again.

"You are a shame to your blood."

A pause.

"Ten Brinken."

Another.

"And Gegner."

The words hang.

Heavy.

Finalizing.

Then, softer—but not kinder:

“Leave the estate.”

A beat.

“You are no longer mine.”

And she stops speaking.

Not because there is nothing left.

But because she has already decided Kiyomi is no longer being *answered*.

The Fight with the Gods

The weight of it lands unevenly—like gravity itself forgets where to settle.

It hits Kurohiko first.

Not as words.

As collapse.

Then Mizuki at the same instant—his posture shifting, that predator-stillness in him tightening into something sharper, more alert, as if the world has just declared war on the concept of “home.”

Tsukihiko feels it differently.

Not shock.

Recognition.

A quiet internal recalibration of what “mama” means in a system where Leora is the axis everything rotates around and she has determined something unworthy.

Kaguya sways.

A fraction.

A single betrayal of balance.

Toma is already moving before she fully falls, catching her against his chest with a reflex so practiced it looks like inevitability rather than choice. His arms tighten around her immediately, anchoring her back into her body, into breath.

Sukuna sees all of it at once.

All his children, pulled into different directions by the same sentence.

Kiyomi has been asked to leave.

Not shouted.

Not dramatized.

Declared.

That is what makes it irreversible.

Kurohiko's throat works like it has forgotten how to function properly.

"Mama...you want us to leave?"

It comes out broken, disbelieving, like the word itself should have power enough to reverse causality.

Sukuna hears it properly only after a beat.

Kurohiko is no longer speaking as a son alone.

He is speaking as a husband.

As a man whose entire future has just been split into two incompatible outcomes.

He forces it out again, voice cracking under the strain of it.

"Mama... are you sending us away?"

Sukuna does not look at Leora immediately.

He watches his son instead.

Because this is the first time he has seen Kurohiko realize that loyalty can be structurally outvoted by authority he cannot negotiate with.

Kurohiko stumbles forward a step.

“Mama? You’re really telling us to go?”

Leora does not move toward him.

Does not move away either.

She simply *exists in refusal to bend*.

A sigh leaves her.

Not exhaustion.

Finality.

“Kiyomi has been asked to leave.”

Her voice is even.

Unshaken.

“If you stay here or leave with her, I do not care.”

The words hit harder than anger ever could.

Because they remove him from relevance.

“You are a man,” Leora continues, almost flatly, “you will go where you wish.”

Sukuna’s gaze sharpens.

That is not negligence.

That is deliberate release of control.

And it terrifies him more than command ever has.

Kurohiko's voice breaks into something closer to desperation.

"Mama?! You don't care?!"

Leora looks at him then.

Properly.

Like an equation she has already solved and grown tired of showing her work for.

"No, I do not care."

A pause.

Then, colder:

"If you wish to follow her into the sea and drown, that is your choice."

Silence cracks open in the space after it.

"You are twenty-four years old. You are married. You are now a father."

Leora steps forward.

Not toward comfort.

Toward consequence.

"But make no mistake," she adds, "she has until dawn to gather her things and leave. If she lingers, she will be removed."

Kurohiko chokes on the word immediately.

"Removed?!"

"By me."

No hesitation.

No softness.

No ambiguity left alive in it.

Kurohiko turns, almost violently, looking for Sukuna—like instinct still believes Sukuna is the final appeal court of reality.

Sukuna meets his eyes.

And in that exchange, something silent passes:

I cannot stop this.

Or worse:

I will not be asked to.

Leora's gaze flicks to Sukuna then.

A brief pressure in the air follows it—like recognition of an equal force in the same room.

Sukuna feels it physically again.

That strange involuntary reaction.

Goosebumps along his skin.

Interesting.

Fascinating, even.

He has not had his body betray him like this in a very long time.

Kurohiko looks between them, losing ground internally.

“Otosan...” he whispers toward Sukuna now, smaller.

But Leora speaks before Sukuna can answer.

“Kurohiko,” she says sharply.

His attention snaps back to her instantly.

“Do not make the mistake of thinking your Otōsan is anything other than my equal. I will not be told what to do. I will not be put in my place.”

Her eyes cut through him.

Then she tilts her head slightly.

“Kuro, your wife carries your child.”

A pause.

And then the fracture opens deeper.

“I am dying because of it.”

Silence drops like a sealed door.

“She is the next Alraune. Regardless of how careful we were, fate has spoken otherwise.”

Kurohiko goes rigid.

Leora continues anyway.

“Leave. Take her. Hide her.”

Another pause—measured, deliberate.

“Because if you leave her here or near me, it will not be I who kill her to save myself, but rather your Otōsan or uncle.”

That lands differently in every body present.

Not threat.

Probability.

Before anything else can be said—

the world *changes texture*.

A seam opens.

Not physically at first.

Metaphysically.

Like the air remembers it can tear.

A thin fracture in the veil between life and death splits open in the space between breaths.

And something begins to come through.

Wrong.

Not arriving.

Returning.

And the entire estate understands at once:

this conversation is no longer the worst thing that will happen today.

Arrival

The air does not change when they step through the veil.

It *replaces* the air.

Like reality has been overwritten rather than entered.

Four presences arrive—yet none of them arrive the same way.

Orm is the first to feel *alive*.

Not because he is gentle.

Because he is familiar in a way that does not belong in death.

A man shaped like return.

His eyes sweep the space once, and for a fraction of a second they pause on Friedhelm.

Longer than necessary.

Not surprise.

Recognition that does not yet have a name.

A soft smile curves his mouth—crooked, almost kind.

Friedhelm goes still.

Not in fear first.

In *reaction*.

Something in him recognizes the smile before he understands why.
Then, it hits him.

Festivals, holidays, and drunken nights. This is a man who always happened to be in the right place at the right time when he was pulling away from Wulf.

For years he wondered who he really was. He wondered where the man he took comfort in for a few hours came from because The Tribes couldn't be so big as to actually hide the existence of someone—especially not from The Alraune Brother.

Sukuna notices it immediately.

Because Sukuna knows Friedhelm's stillness like language.

Orm inclines his head slightly, as though greeting someone he has met before.

Mora does not arrive so much as *anchor* herself into the center of the space.

The world tightens around her.

Everything else feels momentarily secondary—like even grief must pause until she acknowledges its existence.

Her presence is absolute.

Not loud.

Final.

Her eyes move across the estate.

And when they land on Leora—

something subtle happens.

Not recognition of face.

Recognition of *ownership that should have remained stable and did not*.

Leora does not react outwardly.

But Sukuna sees it.

Because he has learned to read her without permission.

Her cursed energy is gone.

Not suppressed.

Not hidden.

Absent.

Like something essential has been quietly removed from her existence without breaking her structure.

Sukuna feels it like a wrong note in a symphony.

His stomach tightens.

Leora is still standing.

Still breathing.

But she is no longer “felt” by the world.

That is wrong.

That is dangerous.

Nárva steps forward next.

Soft.

Measured.

She does not look at anyone like a threat.

She looks at them like memory that has begun to decay in real time.

Her gaze rests briefly on Leora.

And she bows.

Not deeply.

Not subservient.

Acknowledging.

Like something in Leora still exists in the category of *remembered correctly*, even if everything else is breaking.

Syrveth circles last.

Slow.

Unhurried.

Her movement is almost casual—like she is inspecting a piece of art she has already decided is offensive.

Her masked presence turns slightly toward Leora.

And stays there.

Too long.

Too focused.

Like envy has found its origin point again.

Chōbei tracks her immediately.

Not her face.

Her intention.

Sukuna does the same a heartbeat later.

Two men aligning without needing language.

Leora makes a sound then.

Low.

From the throat.

Not human in structure.

A growl that does not belong to language at all.

It makes the air recoil.

Friedhelm hisses in response.

Instant.

Uncontrolled.

The sound is not learned—it is *triggered*.

And then—

it happens.

Both Leora and Friedhelm begin to change.

Not fully.

Not safely.

The Ten Brinken bloodline responds like a system remembering war.

Black sclera bloom where white should be.

Crimson irises ignite.

Veins darken under skin like ink finding rivers.

Teeth lengthen slightly.

The face, for a flicker between seconds, stops belonging to anything that could be called human.

Sukuna feels it like pressure behind his ribs.

Not fear.

Recognition of something ancient waking up inside something he thought he knew.

Tsukihiko straightens.

His breath catches.

His eyes widen—not in panic.

In understanding.

“I can understand them,” he whispers.

Chōbei hears it.

His gaze flicks to Tsukihiko immediately.

Then to Leora.

Then to Friedhelm.

Sukuna does not like that sentence.

Not because it is impossible.

Because it means something in this room is speaking beneath language.

Leora clicks her tongue once.

Sharp.

Friedhelm answers instantly.

A sound that is not translation.

Agreement.

The space between them tightens further.

No one else understands it.

But everyone *feels excluded by it*.

Orm's smile softens further.

"Oh," he murmurs, almost amused. "That is unfortunate."

Mora does not look amused.

She looks certain.

Like she is correcting an administrative error.

"Your time has come to return to Helheim," Mora says calmly. "We will kill you, and I will bring you and Friedhelm to live in the halls beneath my throne."

Silence fractures.

Not from shock.

From pressure.

Leora does not look away from Mora.

Her body is coiled now.

Not tense.

Contained violence held in architectural restraint.

Nárva speaks next, voice quiet.

“Now that there is a new Alraune, Nidr’s binding must be redone.”

A pause.

“You bound her, and it is your will that has kept her.”

Her eyes flick briefly to Kiyomi’s abdomen—then away.

“But no more.”

Syrveth smiles under her mask.

Not kindly.

Not warmly.

Like she is watching something finally become punishable.

“The new Alraune must bind her to her will,” Nárva continues, “and it would be best if you allow her to do that while Nidr is at her weakest.”

Friedhelm makes a sound then.

Low.

Broken.

A whine that carries too much meaning for language to hold.

A hiss that puts everyone instinctively on edge.

Leora answers him immediately.

A rough, grounding sound.

Not words.

Stability.

Sukuna realizes then—

they are communicating without him again. For years he learned their languages and for years he sat hours after they finished speaking in translation. He had found it irritating they would go between three languages in their daily lives but when they truly wanted to be secretive they combined them until it was nearly unintelligible.

But, now he finds out that they had always had **this** way to communicate and did not.

Why go through the trouble of doing the other?

Because this language is used when the threat is too dangerous to trust normal words around.

Something in him sharpens dangerously at that realization.

Leora finally speaks aloud.

“So, in short,” she says slowly, eyes still on Mora, “you have come to kill me.”

A pause.

“To send Kiyomi to re-establish Nidr’s binding.”

Another.

“To make me a jewel in your crown in Helheim.”

Her gaze narrows.

“To separate me from my brother.”

Another beat.

“And what you’re not saying, but I know well,” Leora’s words cooled further, “to give Sukuna just enough information about our location so that he will search until he dies or gives up.”

A soft scoff leaves her throat.

“You are fools.”

Orm answers immediately, tone almost conversational.

“You are currently weak,” he says lightly, as if that is answer enough for why they’re doing this now. “Fools are not strategic. With you, we have no choice but to be. I would prefer you to respect that we are at least optimizing outcomes. We seek to make this quick.”

Friedhelm responds instantly.

Cold.

Controlled.

“Syrveth will not make it quick,”

Syrveth’s smile widens.

“No,” she agrees softly. “I will not.”

The air tightens again.

Chōbei’s hand shifts slightly—ready.

Sukuna is already focused.

Not on Orm.

Not on Mora.

On Syrveth.

Because something in her presence feels like violation waiting to happen.

Leora exhales once.

“Sukuna.”

He looks at her immediately.

“Get Higan.”

Her voice is soft.

He does not move yet.

Because now he is watching Mora and how she’s watching Leora.

Leora does not look away from Mora.

“Sukuna.”

He exhales, annoyed.

“I heard you.”

A beat.

“Sukuna.”

This time her voice changes.

A thread of something sharper beneath it.

And then she says it—

“She wears your son’s teeth in her hair.”

Everything stops in a different way.

Not silence.

Targeting.

Sukuna’s attention locks.

Chōbei’s does too.

Orm’s smile fades slightly.

Mora does not react outwardly—

but the space around her becomes colder.

And something tears at the veil again, interrupting the moment before it could sink in further.

The first one to step through brings winter with him. The training field turns icy. The bonfire is extinguished. The crows begin croaking, and Mora’s eyes tighten.

Eirvorr stands behind Leora, just within reach, slightly to the right. Sukuna immediately goes still because Eirvorr has not come in his divine appearance nor the partially humanoid he's used every other time.

Instead, he is wearing pieces of Sukuna. His height, his face, his presence – all almost perfect amalgamations of parts of him by someone who has observed him much too long. Possibly, by someone attempting to observe him through the eyes of Leora.

Leora does not acknowledge him. She doesn't have to. She's already hissed once more and she and Friedhelm are currently humming, whistling, and clicking to each other causing everyone present to clench in dread of what is to come.

Friedhelm moves towards Chobei and Tsukihiko. Leora stays facing Mora.

Sukuna hears another set of footsteps and then another.

Skugga and Vargr are almost too beautiful to look at separately but together, it's almost sickening. Skugga's long, calf length hair moves slightly as if it's underwater. His shrine attire is spotless and bright white. His hair is gathered out of his face with a hairpin of a wolf. He smiles so warmly at everyone it's as if he thinks this is a reunion.

“Orm, I see you are still trying to touch what is mine.”

Skugga smile widens, “I believe Leora is correct in her evaluation that you are all foolish.”

Vargr, normally covered in heavy furs, is lighter today. He wears nothing but a thick leather hunting jacket and pants with a light, woven tunic stained with blood from the kill he made that morning to feed the wolves and Wulf back at the den.

When Wulf had disappeared into deep death suddenly, he had abandoned his elk and went after him.

The state he found him in, the blood and Nidr's arm, and then Kiyomi - he knew he had to tell Skugga and Eirvorr at once.

"She is dying." Vargr had said it plainly.

Eirvorr had paused and then all of the reeds on the banks of the river of death suddenly shook with a violence that caused other greater dead to leave the area.

"What do you mean, she is dying? Now?" Eirvorr spoke as if this was something less a problem of inevitability but more of a problem of timing.

"Wulf found Kiyomi in the threads. Nidr wanted to break her so she'd be easier to manipulate. The girl fell for every trap." Skugga could hear Vargr's disgust, "Wulf had to pull her back out of the threads a second time, as well."

Eirvorr sighed, "And what did she see?"

Vargr looked at Skugga, "The past."

Skugga closed his eyes, "I am sure the worst parts only."

"Obviously." Eirvorr turned, "This will spread like wildfire amongst the others. Those who are against her will seek to end her and allow an inferior Alraune to take over."

Skugga grabbed at Vargr's sleeve gently, "Nidr will come for-"

Vargr took his hand, “No.”

Eirvorr looked between them.

“Yes,” he nodded once, “Nidr will come for your child if you have one. Why do you think you have never managed to bring one to life before? You know how we were cursed.”

Vargr gripped Skugga’s hand tighter, “You are right. We should seek another solution.”

Skugga nods, “Do we even need Nidr anymore? Can not another replace her?”

Eirvorr stares, “What you speak of feels almost blasphemous.”

Skugga’s hand covered his stomach instinctually, “What I speak sounds truthful.”

No one spoke for a while.

The river babbled.

The dead watched from beneath the water or amongst the reeds.

Eirvorr goes still for a moment. Something has happened only he can feel.

“We must go. Mora seeks to touch what does not belong to her.”

Now, Eirvorr was looking at Mora as if she had personally walked into his home to rob it only to find him standing in it already empty.

Mora spoke, “Why have you come?”

Eirvorr smiled, “I believe it was Sukuna who once said, “Even monsters know what is worth protecting.”

Mora scoffed, “You believe you are protecting her? She does not belong to you to protect.”

Skugga interrupts, “She does not belong to anyone. One may have made a claim but ownership is another thing entirely. If Leora belongs to anyone, it’s to who she chooses. Sukuna and Eirvorr respect her choice. She is most likely to choose one of them. Not you, Mora. Not anyone else. Them.”

Mora grimaced, “All that dies belongs to me.”

Skugga bared his teeth, “And I suppose you count Friedhelm as belonging to you?”

“Yes.”

“Well,” Skugga leaned forward slightly, “that is unacceptable. For Friedhelm has a place already with me when he chooses.”

Orm stepped forward, “*If he chooses.*” He looks at Friedhelm, “And I am sure he understands that his place is in Helheim near his sister.”

Vargr snarls, “Where you can have unlimited access. You wish to feed him from your hand in a cage because if he is free he will never eat from it willingly.”

Sukuna tenses.

Leora has not blinked the entire time.

He has noticed.

She is like a stranger to him.

But, her eyes never leave Mora.

“Let my children leave the field and I will give you what you want.”

Leora’s voice is softer than it has any right to be.

Friedhelm makes a humming noise. Leora returns it with a few clicks and a series of whistles.

Vargr turns to Kaguya. She’s holding Higan protectively. He sees Toma. His hand on her waist, body turned protectively with his hand on his sword. His face emptied of emotion.

Next to him, Chobei. He appears lazy, relaxed even. But, his arm is like a vice around Tsukihiko. His neck is reddening as the time passes.

Both brothers are ready to protect what is theirs with teeth.

Vargr knows he made the right choice standing for this family.

Now, hopefully Mora can see reason before things become worse.

“You will stop this delay and allow me to kill you and bring you to Helheim?” Mora sounds incredulous.

Leora slowly smiles, “No.”

Sukuna can feel more goosebumps forming on his skin again. A sense of dread begins to grow inside. He has not felt genuine dread in a lifetime. Possibly ever. And yet now, every instinct tells him what is in Leora is something no one should be around.

Leora’s fangs look longer as her smiled widens, “That is not what you want.”

Eirvorr and Sukuna cannot look away from her.

“What you really want, Mora,” she tilts her head, “is my attention.”

Syvreth goes still.

Orm looks away.

And then, “Why do you think that’s what I actually want?”

Friedhelm exhales, “Because you desperately want to be seen and acknowledged by something better than you.”

Syvreth moves suddenly.

Chobei pulls Tsukihiko closer.

Toma somehow engulfs Kaguya.

Kurohiko pulls Kiyomi and Sieg into his arms.

Sukuna moves closer to Leora instinctively while Mizuki moves between his sister in Toma’s arms and Sieg in his brother’s.

Everyone readies themselves and then –

“That is unwise, Syvreth.”

Eirvorr looks at her and the air turns even colder. Frost spreads across the grass until it reaches the treeline.

Syvreth begins to circle, “You speak as if you know what is and what is not wise.”

Eirvorr’s breath appears as white smoke, “Stay away from her children.”

Skugga smirks, “Syvreth, why not remove the mask and grace us with your beauty? For were you not once one of the most beautiful goddess?”

Vargr pulled Skugga against him. He gave his waist a squeeze of gentle warning.

Chobei could feel the hatred emanating from her.

Sukuna did not like how close she was to Higan.

Narva had become nothing more than a silent observer and Mora and Leora could not break eye contact.

Syvreth turned towards Skugga, “I will take pleasure when I remove your skin. I will make sure Vargr watches every expression of agony that graces your face.”

Vargr’s face changed.

Sukuna, Chobei, Toma, and every other man on the field knew that Vargr was a man not to be challenged.

Skugga laughed slightly under his breath, “Remember when we all gathered to admire the blossoming Alraune? The one who was different from all the others?”

Sukuna looked at Skugga now. Skugga met his eyes and continued speaking primarily to him, “Leora is the most unique and exceptional Alraune the world has ever seen. Thus, she is also the most beautiful and interesting to observe. Syvreth did not like being so openly overshadowed by a girl born to be broken and used as a vessel.”

“She spent years speaking of how inferior she was and how her beauty would wither before she reached adulthood. She was a fine baby, a pretty child, a lovely girl, but she would be a disappointment as a young woman. Syvreth said it was always the case.”

“But Leora at sixteen was gorgeous enough to not only steal the *soul-breath* from Eirvorr but also to claim the hearts of Brennir and Skelmir. Two men Syverth had long hoped to catch the eye of. When they did not agree that she was more beautiful, she decided to take matters into her own hands.”

“Syverth went to the goddess of poison and had a special *Black Broth* prepared for that year’s culling. She made sure Leora had to drink part of Friedhelm’s portion and Wulf’s. She was owed favors and used them to manipulate fate and circumstance.”

“When Leora fell in the forest amongst the fallen pine and leaves, she was unable to get up. For a few terrible moments she was completely alone. Friedhelm had been taken to a different release area and was

currently engaged one against twelve. Wulf was caught in a trap meant for animals behind her somewhere beyond the trees.”

“And Leora laid on the forest floor sleeping like a woodland princess blessed by Vargr himself.”

Skugga smiled at Vargr for a moment.

“And Syverth appeared with a knife dipped in the venom of Níðhöggr. He is the serpent that dwells beneath **Yggdrasil**, constantly gnawing at its roots and feeding upon the dead in Náströnd. She meant to carve into Leora’s body marks of destruction and then to remove her face so that she could make a mask of it to wear.”

“But, Eirvorr would not suffer such desecration and violation of winter’s future bride. Especially considering there was no honor to be found in such actions.”

“Eirvorr came from behind and took Syverth’s blade. He held her by the throat and carved destruction into her body. Then, he removed the root of her insecurity delicately, one slice at a time so that, in the end, she would no longer be jealous. There would be nothing left to compare to Leora anymore.”

Chobei and Toma held Tsukihiko and Kaguya tighter. Sieg started to cry silently as Kurohiko felt Kiyomi begin to shake uncontrollably.

Mora sighed, ‘Enough.’

Eirvorr nodded, “Agreed.”

Orm looked towards Friedhelm. Friedhelm cocked his head to the side, "I would keep your gaze away from me lest I pluck out both of your eyes and make you eat them."

Orm smiled, "You've allowed me to gaze for decades. You've even sought me out."

"I was a child."

"You were a man. Let's not lie."

"For a portion of it, I was a bored young man and you were amusing. But, only for a few hours and then your appeal wore off." Friedhelm stepped towards Orm, "You keep asking why I didn't return to you. But you never asked why you're not worth returning to."

Leora clicked three times.

"My children will leave the field. No one will interfere." She looked at Kaguya and then Mora, "Higan will go with Sukuna and I will fight you."

Syvreth moved again.

Chobei, this time, grabbed Higan from Kaguya. Tsukihiko took him immediately. Now, Syvreth was further away and Higan was closer to Sukuna. Chobei looked ready to rip throats out with his teeth.

Mora shook her head, "Higan will go to Narva."

Sukuna spoke with finality, "No."

Narva bowed, “I am willing to watch over **all** the children until this is resolved.”

Leora heard the word *all* at the same time Chobei and Sukuna did.

In one tense moment there was only fear.

And then, a voice:

“I’ve found the others.”

Another god stepped from under the awning of the estate and began walking down towards the training field.

In his arms, Freyr and Kohaku. Some sort of denizen slave followed behind with Linnea.

The man smiled. He looked friendly.

That was worse than if he’d looked angry or malicious.

“I believe you understand now the true gravity of your situation.” He moved Kohaku higher on his hip while adjusting Freyr against his shoulder.

Grimnir, the god of decay, was now holding two of Sukuna and Leora’s most precious treasures.

Leora knew the potential error before it was made. She spoke for all to hear, “Do not rush him or fight him. He will kill them before your thoughts finish. He will take pleasure in it.”

Tsukihiko went still and then he made a hissing noise. Then a growl.
Then a combination of sounds too old, too instinctive.

Sukuna saw the same thing in Leora in Tsukihiko.

Black sclera.

Crimson eyes.

Lengthened canines.

Dark veins under nearly translucent skin.

And in Kaguya.

In Mizuki.

In Kurohiko.

His children had changed into something he had no reference for nor
any control over.

Grimnir tilted his head, “I was curious if the ancient blood would
dilute once it met with his.” He looked at Sukuna like he was an
unimportant footnote that had finally been referenced.

Kaguya moved.

Tōma restrained her but barely.

A small strand of hair on Linnea's head was cut with some invisible
knife.

Kaguya made a noise that was answered by Leora.

Toma, whose face was normally emptied during battle, was contorted in rage.

Grimnir tiskied, “Your mother warned you. Listen to her.”

Leora looked at Friedhelm.

He never blinked but made a low noise in his chest.

Grimnir huffed in faux exhaustion, “Mora, let's get this over with. I am eager for Nidr to be re-bound.”

He looked at Kiyomi and paused, “Wait. This is the new Alraune?”

Grimnir looked at her closely. Then—

“How...unimpressive.”

Syvreth laughed once.

Mora nodded, “She is.” Her voice softened almost tiredly, “It’s true, she’s not impressive. Perhaps the child in her womb will be better. Once she gives birth to two, she can be removed.”

Eirvorr stepped closer to Leora. His eyes never left Grimnir, “Did you have to include her grandchildren?”

Grimnir grinned; extremely pleased with the question. “Of course.”

He looked at Leora, “What is it called when all the precious ones are brought together? Oh, wait— The seeds, not precious ones! I had the term wrong. Sorry.” He laughed.

Sukuna felt something shift in the air.

Leora and Friedhelm were suddenly much more threatening.

Grimnir whistled, “Yes, it’s “The Gathering”, right? Sometimes followed by “The Thinning.” Then “The Rooting” and eventually “The Harvesting.” He looked at Kohaku, “The Thinning was always my favorite part.”

A pause.

“Your mother survived a Thinning.” He smiled wickedly. Sukuna tensed ever so slightly.

He was familiar with the term Harvesting as it pertained to the Alraune but Gathering? Thinning and Rooting? Obviously, there were more things he would now have to learn about but at what cost? If Leora and Friedhelm had kept this a secret but the Harvesting they didn't, then what horrors awaited him?

Grimnir sighed, “And then your grandfather changed her name before The Rooting from Tómauðr to Auðr.” He shrugged, “Which is hilarious given that from Tómauðr came Livrún.”

Tómauðr

Sukuna now knew his wife's mother's name. After five children, four grandchildren, and over 30 years he had just learned something that everyone else seemed to already know. Not only know, but knew the story behind the story and had already filed it away like the knowledge that the sky was blue or that water was wet.

Leora snarled, feral and raw. It made Sukuna feel a strange sensation in his hands. When he looked down, he was shaking ever so slightly.

Shaking.

The King of Curses' body was shaking because it sensed something in his wife he did not consciously understand.

Grimnir jostled Kohaku slightly, "There will be a sort of Gathering in the depth of death, beyond the seventh gate. This little fox already has bidders. Imagine what you could trade him for? Blessed by Skugga and the grandchild of Leora ten Brinken. Depending on who is interested, tacking on The King of Curses could fetch a higher trade. The auction summary practically writes itself."

He motions towards Linnea, "How many gods and goddesses are obsessed with the handsome executioner Aza Toma and his wife, Ryomen Kaguya? Known among many as The Empty Heaven and Crescent Moon. A blessing from Vallraun makes their only beloved daughter even more enticing. Imagine what she could be when she grows up? A pretty concubine or something far more interesting."

But then Grimnir paused and looked at Freyr, "But this one, he's my favorite." He smiles at Leora, "He's also hers. Everyone knows Sukuna favors the fox and Leora favors the wolf."

He looks at Freyr again, as if checking something to see something only he knew was there, “She loves him best because he looks like her lover.”

He looked at Chobei.

“Every god and goddess wants to know what makes you, The Moon’s Fang, so special. Why did she make room for you outside of her **Only**?”

He looked at Freyr again and smiled cruelly, “You really are beloved.”

Grimnir took one of his blackened nails, sharp like a claw, and cut Freyr’s face. He dragged it through his eyebrow, over his eye, and down his cheek. Freyr whimpered and tried to pull away.

Tsukihiko changed.

Suddenly.

Violently.

And Leora flinched.

Sukuna realized Grimnir was looking for a reason to kill Freyr and Tsukihiko was about to give him one.

Skugga and Vargr moved and Mora stepped in to meet them. Her eyes rested firmly on Skugga’s abdomen, “You of all people have the most to gain from Nidr being bound fully and truly. I would think wisely before stepping in any further.”

Vargr pushed Skugga behind him, “Call him off.”

Mora stared.

“Call him off.”

“I can’t.”

She looked at Higan, “How else will I keep Higan from decaying in Helheim before the vow?”

Leora moved towards Grimmir, “Take me!”

Her voice cracked. It made something hot coil in Sukuna’s gut.

“Bind me. Kill me. Torture me.”

Her breathing was shallow and ragged suddenly. It was like her control had slipped.

“Or,” Sukuna didn’t like that tone, “**trade me.**”

Eirvorr tightened.

Sukuna reached for her immediately.

Because the thought of *that* - of Leora traded

“Grimmir.”

A low, warm voice cut through the courtyard.

Mizuki stepped forward suddenly. Sukuna's attention flew to him.

Mizuki looked torn between staying with Kaguya and Sieg or intercepting this person. He clearly knew who this was. Sukuna was deeply unhappy with just how much he did not understand or know about what was happening in his family and with his wife.

"Oh," Grimmir looked truly stunned for a moment. His smile softened, "You look so beautiful, Kyrr."

Skugga and Kyrr met each other's gaze. Vargr grabbed his hand, "No."

Skugga couldn't turn away.

Kyrr approached Grimmir, avoiding Mizuki's eyes entirely.

Kyrr stopped a few feet from Grimmir. He had yet to take his eyes off of him. His voice was breathy and reverent, "There you are."

Kyrr lowered his gaze quickly, almost bashfully.

Sukuna was somewhat surprised he wasn't actually a woman. He was undeniably one of the most beautiful people he'd ever seen. His features were elegant and unusually refined, with high cheekbones, a straight nose, full lips, and lonely, expressive eyes.

Sukuna could see when the light caught them that they were glassy. There were tears already collecting in the corners. His long, dark brown flowed in the wind, occasionally obscuring his face.

He tried to place him. He remembered some militia men had entered with Mizuki yesterday but this man didn't look like he was much of a fighter.

He looked half starved and weak.

"Grimnir, please, leave the children out of this. They're scared."

He looked at Freyr.

Genuine tears ran down his cheek, 'You hurt him.' His voice was barely above a whisper.

Grimnir smiled knowingly, "You know my hand was forced."

Freyr was shaking. When he saw Kyrr, he lit up. He reached for him automatically.

He remembered him.

He remembered sitting in his lap and playing with him while Mizuki sparred and trained new soldiers. He remembered how Kyrr sang to him and held him while he slept.

He remembered feeling safe.

So, he reached.

Kohaku followed Freyr instinctively.

Grimnir chuckled while he pulled Kohaku closer, “You have such a way with babies.”

Kyrr kept looking down at Kohaku and Freyr.

Grimnir stepped closer to Kyrr. His voice was low and familiar, “You’ve lost weight.” He leaned forward, “Come here. Let me look at you better.”

Mizuki hissed.

Grimnir watched Kyrr.

At first, he flinched towards Mizuki. But, he stopped himself. He stayed facing Grimnir.

Mizuki was hurt. Grimnir felt victorious.

“Give me the children. Then you can all fight. They don’t deserve to be in this.” Kyrr’s voice was almost pleading. “And you can’t be serious about trading them. Grimnir, they’re...they’re innocent. It’s not their fault. They’re just children.”

He looked up at him finally, “Please, Grimnir. Let them go. This isn’t-”

“Beg.”

Kyrr’s voice died in his throat.

“What?”

“Beg and I’ll consider releasing one.”

Kyrr searched his face.

Syverth began to chuckle, “Idiot.”

Kyrr took a deep breath.

And slowly lowered himself to his knees. He lifted his hands, palms up, “Grimnir, please, give me the children. Please. Please give them to me. Let them be free, please-” Sukuna listened as this stranger pleaded without any regard for how humiliating it was for his grandchildren.

Leora was still.

Something about her stillness made him curious.

Friedhelm had moved.

He was closer now.

How did he move?

He wasn’t there before.

Now Leora was gone.

Sukuna searched for her and saw her closer to Mora.

How?

How were they moving without sound or being seen?

What are they?

What is Leora, really?

Kyrr remained on his knees.

Grimnir watched him with that same patient expression.

That was the worst part.

Not anger.

Not cruelty.

The certainty that he already knew what Kyrr would do.

“Please,” Kyrr whispered.

Grimnir’s smile softened.

“You still say it the same way.”

Kyrr’s hands lowered. His fingers curled against the ground.

“You always believed if you asked gently enough, people would become kind.”

A pause.

“You never understood that some people just enjoy being asked.”

Mizuki felt something cold settle in his chest.

Because suddenly he understood.

The apologies.

The hesitation.

The way Kyrr always looked like he was waiting for someone to tell him he had done something wrong.

It had never been natural.

It had been taught.

Kyrr lowered his head further.

“Please let them go.”

Grimnir stepped closer.

“I love hearing you ask.”

The words were quiet.

Almost affectionate.

“You always return to this. This is your natural state, isn’t it?”

Kyrr did not answer.

Because he was not listening.

Not anymore.

His eyes shifted.

Only once.

Toward Leora.

She saw it.

Of course she did.

She had known him for only moments, and yet she understood what others had missed.

Kyrr was not begging because he had surrendered.

He was begging because Grimnir expected him to.

Leora's gaze remained fixed on Mora.

"Grimnir."

The god of decay looked toward her.

A slow smile.

"Yes, my lovely Livrun?"

Leora tilted her head slightly.

"You have always been fascinated by things you cannot ruin."

Something changed in his expression.

Only a fraction.

But it was enough.

"You mistake fascination for interest."

"No," Leora replied calmly.

"I recognize hunger."

Silence.

Even the battlefield seemed to pause.

Because she was right.

Every god here wanted something from her.

Mora wanted ownership.

Syverth wanted to destroy what she could not become.

Grimnir wanted to prove that something beautiful could still rot.

And all of them wanted her to look at them.

Perfect.

Kyrr moved. Not like someone escaping but, rather, like someone who had been waiting.

A strap slipped from his shoulder. He had been carrying an ancient bier made of ash wood that had darkened almost to black. There were runes no one remembered still engraved along the posts and metal rings that had been replaced thousands of times.

The bier struck the ground with a thud so loud, Kiyomi nearly jumped out of her skin.

The ancient wood unfolded across the earth.

Grimnir turned but he was too late. Kyrr was no longer kneeling. The gentleness vanished from his posture. Not replaced by rage but by certainty.

He crossed the distance between them with terrifying speed.

Grimnir blocked the first strike.

The impact cracked the ground.

His eyes narrowed.

“Looks like you want to be punished.”

Kyrr didn't speak. Instead, he drove forward again. Every movement was precise. No wasted motion. No desperation. He was not fighting to win.

He was fighting to reach them.

He moved upwards into Grimmir's space. His elbow found the soft flesh of Grimmir's stomach. Kyrr twisted, managing to rip Freyr from his hold.

The bier moved closer. Kyrr dropped Freyr into it but it came at a price.

Grimmir's claws pierced through his clothes and into his body. Fingers delved deep inside between his ribs. Kyrr grit his teeth, eyes filled with tears by the sheer amount of pain.

He broke Grimmir's hand holding Kohaku and pulled him free.

He dropped him into the bier along with his brother.

Linnea cried out once.

Mizuki had killed the denizen.

He turned his sights on Grimmir and his fingers still deep inside of Kyrr.

With remarkable gentleness he deposited Linnea into the bier with her cousins. Then, Mizuki slid the bier away with his foot.

Toward the family.

Toward home.

Leora saw Mora move.

She saw where her eyes went.

And her voice tore across the field.

“Sukuna!”

He turned to her immediately.

Eirvorr moved towards Syverth.

Sukuna appeared in front of Tsukihiko and took Higan from his arms. Chobei and Toma grabbed the bier, hurriedly gathering the children into their arms. Kurohiko moved with Kiyomi and Sieg to the side of the trainingfield against the courtyard wall where he could place them in the corner.

It was safer, easier to defend.

He was quickly joined by the others.

Chobei nearly slammed into him as he drug Tsukihiko over. He pushed him down into the corner where two stone walls met where Tsukihiko covered Kohaku with his body, checking him, scenting him over and over until Chobei pressed Freyr into his arms. But he didn't let go.

Chobei was feral, wiping Freyr's face with his hand, checking the cut through his eyebrow and across his eyelid and cheek.

Chobei's greatest fear was that he'd lose the eye.

Just like him.

He'd be one-eyed and scarred for life.

He would never forgive himself for this. He had failed as a father.

Tsukihiko made noises only Kaguya and Kurohiko understood.

Kaguya and Toma held Linnea between them like a cocoon.

Now, Sukuna was with them, holding Higan. The moment his son was in his arms, the air had changed.

Mora stopped abruptly.

Sukuna looked at her over Higan's head.

Leora's hand was now plunged into Mora's back.

He watched.

Time felt like it slowed down.

He saw it second by second.

Leora's hand pulled out, vertebrae by vertebrae, Mora's spine until it was fully removed.

Completely intact.

He watched as his wife discarded the bones. As her face became awash with bloody splatter. Her hair moved like it was underwater. He watched as she took stock of Mora's body. Summing up the parts, deciding what to start with next.

And her teeth.

They lengthened.

Leora's teeth sank into the tender flesh of Mora's throat.

Until there was nothing left there.

It took seconds.

A minute perhaps.

But for Sukuna, it had felt like an eternity he never wanted to end.

With the children no longer bargaining pieces, the battlefield shifted.

Mizuki stepped forward towards Grimmir. His presence emanated malice and territorial violence.

Kyrr looked at him briefly, still struggling to break free from Grimmir's grasp as his ribs fractured and broke.

"You should stay back."

Mizuki shook his head.

"No."

A pause.

"I spent months wondering why you apologized every time you breathed."

His eyes moved to Grimmir.

"Now I know."

Kyrr went still.

Mizuki's expression hardened.

Grimmir smiled.

"You're interrupting."

Mizuki stepped closer.

His cursed energy rose.

“Interrupting what? Touching someone that doesn't belong to you?”

Grimnir laughed, “Doesn’t belong to me!? Who do you think he's belonged to for millennia? Don't tell me you think Kyrr is yours?”

He pulled Kyrr closer.

“Tell him, Kyrr. Tell him how you spent thousands of years following me around, giving yourself freely to me. No matter what I did, you always came back on your hands and knees begging me to give you another chance.” Kyrr was crying now, not just from pain. He almost broke Grimnir's hold but he recovered faster.

Grimnir leaned closer, licking a line up his neck to his jaw. He kissed the spot before smirking, “Even now if I offered you'd come back to me.”

Mizuki moved.

His thumb found Grimnir’s eyesocket.

Kyrr felt his grip loosen and he seized the moment to break free.

When he finally escaped, he felt something.

Mizuki’s hand.

His fingers.

Threading through strands of his hair.

Mizuki kicked Grimnir with enough force to knock him into the tree line.

Kyrr stopped. Turned. Readied himself to fight alongside Mizuki.

But Mizuki hand tangled in the strands at his neck, gently tugging him to face him.

“Go to my family.”

Kyrr shook his head.

“I can't fight.”

Mizuki looked amused, “I can see that. But,” he looked towards Grimmir, “you hate it.”

Mizuki watched Kyrr become anxious.

He smiled, “Kyrri, I told you. I'll take care of you. I'll do everything. You just have to stop interfering and let me.”

Grimmir walked towards them. His eye was completely gone. Only a shallow cavity left. Blood ran down his face and stained the bandages across his face.

Mizuki lifted Kyrr's hair to his nose and smelled it. He kissed the strands.

“Take care of my family, Kyrr. Make the children laugh.”

He dropped the strands and turned to Grimmir. His face changed. Teeth sharper, pressure more intense than before.

Sukuna watched as Kyrr ran towards them and past Leora. She was standing over Mora. Looking down into her broken body.

When she looked up.

Their eyes met.

For Sukuna, it was almost a religious experience.

He felt his breath being stolen. Honestly, stolen.

Then, Skugga and Kyrr were beside him. Skugga's appearance had changed. He was now dressed for battle. Hair pulled back and into a high warrior's tail. His white robes discarded and in their place remains only a fitted black under-robe. The high collar framed his throat. His black hakama fell in clean, severe pleats, secured by crimson cords and weathered leather belts.

Sukuna heard it before he saw it. A lone fox bell remained, striking softly against his hip whenever he moved.

He looked at Kyrr and then back to Sukuna, "If danger comes, I will fight. You should not move from them and never let go of Higan."

Skugga's voice lowered, "Mora has been interested in him since his birth. She went into the threads to see his future." Skugga paused.

"She fell in love with who he will be. She wants to bring him to Helheim so Leora can continue to feed him and mother him until he's old enough to be taken away. Once he reaches the appropriate age, she will make a vow with him and take him as her husband."

"She intends to rule with him as her king."

Sukuna would never let that happen.

Grimnir rolled his ruined shoulder once.

Bone slid back beneath skin with a wet crack.

Muscle reknit.

The empty socket remained.

He smiled anyway.

"A shame."

He flexed his fingers.

"I rather liked that eye."

Mizuki didn't answer.

He was watching.

Feet.

Weight.

Balance.

Breathing—

...

No.

Not breathing.

Interesting.

Grimnir regarded him almost thoughtfully.

"So."

His head tilted.

"The King's son."

Silence.

"I've wondered."

Another slow step.

"Which parts of you are hers..."

His crimson eye drifted over Mizuki's face.

"...and which parts belong to the man who ruined her."

Mizuki moved.

The ground burst beneath his feet.

His fist reached Grimmir before the sound of movement did.

Grimmir caught it.

Not with effort.

With familiarity.

"Oh."

He smiled.

"Your father."

His other hand struck.

Palm.

Collarbone.

Mizuki's balance shifted half a step.

Enough.

Grimmir's elbow buried itself beneath his ribs.

Three cracked immediately.

Mizuki didn't react.

He stepped inside the strike instead.

His forehead smashed into Grimmir's nose.

Cartilage burst.

Before Grimmir recovered—

a knee.

A shoulder.

A twisting throw.

Grimmir hit the earth hard enough to split stone.

Mizuki was already on him.

Heel.

Throat.

Palm.

Temple.

Every strike arrived before the previous impact had finished echoing.

Sukuna watched carefully.

Good.

Efficient.

Minimal movement.

No wasted—

Something changed.

Grimnir laughed.

"You know..."

He rolled aside before Mizuki's next strike landed.

"...she doesn't fight like this."

Mizuki pursued.

Grimnir slipped around him effortlessly.

"Not instinctual enough"

A finger brushed Mizuki's wrist aside.

"Too impatient."

His knee struck Mizuki's stomach.

Hard.

Enough to send him skidding backward through broken earth.

"You look exactly like him."

He smiled.

"And almost nothing like her."

Nearby...

Kyrr had reached the others.

He turned immediately to Higan.

The child was sobbing now.

He pressed against Sukuna's arm.

Tiny hands reaching desperately toward the battlefield.

"Mama..."

Kyrr gathered him carefully.

Not taking him from Sukuna.

Simply placing one trembling hand against the child's back.

He began humming.

Quietly.

Something old.

Something simple.

Higan hiccupped.

Then cried harder.

Kyrr's own tears slid silently down his face.

"It's alright..."

His voice barely existed.

"It's alright..."

Skugga rested a hand briefly on Kyrr's shoulder.

The fox bell at his hip rang once.

Softly.

Sukuna barely heard it.

His attention remained on Mizuki.

Something wasn't right.

He knew this rhythm.

He had built it.

Every stance.

Every correction.

Every lesson.

Mizuki was no longer fighting the way Sukuna had taught him.

He was letting Grmnir speak.

That irritated him.

No.

More than that.

It frightened him.

Because Mizuki wasn't listening for weakness.

He was listening for truth.

Grmnir smiled again.

"So."

He dusted dirt from his sleeve.

"Does he still apologize before asking permission to sleep?"

Mizuki's shoulders stiffened.

Only slightly.

Grimnir saw it.

Of course he did.

"There it is."

He stepped forward.

"He still thanks people when they strike him accidentally."

Another step.

"He still believes he's inconveniencing everyone simply by existing."

Mizuki attacked.

Too quickly.

Too hard.

Grimnir slipped outside the line of attack.

His palm struck beneath Mizuki's jaw.

The impact lifted him cleanly from the ground.

"He still wakes from nightmares expecting my voice."

Blood ran from Mizuki's mouth.

He ignored it.

Grimnir smiled warmly.

"I never imagined someone would convince him to leave."

His eye drifted briefly toward Kyrr.

"I underestimated you."

Pause.

"But only a little."

Sukuna's eyes narrowed.

Months.

Not days.

Not weeks.

Months.

His gaze shifted.

Kyrr.

Mizuki.

Back again.

The way Kyrr instinctively searched for Mizuki whenever Grimnir spoke.

The way Mizuki never once looked away from Grimnir.

Not because he wasn't worried.

Because he already knew where Kyrr was.

He had trusted him to go.

Without hesitation.

Without looking back.

Sukuna felt something unexpectedly familiar settle in his chest.

Choice.

Not attraction.

Not infatuation.

Choice.

Mizuki had chosen.

Quietly.

Without ceremony.

Without permission.

Just as Sukuna once had.

He thought of Leora.

Of the way she'd simply walked into his life and never truly left.

He thought—

unexpectedly—

of himself at twenty-six.

Violent.

Certain.

Convinced there would never be anyone.

His gaze lingered on Kyrr.

Thin.

Exhausted.

Beautiful.

Broken.

...

His son had terrible taste.

A corner of Sukuna's mouth almost moved.

Almost.

Then Grimmir spoke again.

"You've known him..."

His voice remained impossibly gentle.

"...months."

Silence.

"I taught him to kneel."

Another step.

"I taught him to apologize."

Another.

"I taught him to fear affection."

His smile softened.

"You've spent months convincing him I was wrong."

He looked genuinely curious.

"I had millennia."

Mizuki exploded forward.

Too fast.

Too angry.

Sukuna's expression hardened immediately.

No.

Not like this.

His son had stopped fighting to win.

He was fighting to make Grimmir stop talking.

That...

was Leora.

Not him.

And somehow...

that realization unsettled Sukuna more than watching his twenty-six-year-old son challenge a god.

Grimnir and Mizuki vanished into another collision.

The impact shook the treeline.

Stone burst upward.

Neither man looked away from the other.

Elsewhere—

Bone shifted.

The sound was quiet.

Almost delicate.

Mora's ruined body drew itself together.

Muscle climbed over exposed vertebrae.

Skin sealed.

The wound in her throat vanished last.

She stood.

As though nothing had happened.

Only the blood remained.

Her gaze settled upon Leora.

"You've become troublesome."

Leora tilted her head.

A small smile.

"I've always been troublesome."

Mora stepped forward.

"You truly believe you can keep Higan from me?"

Her eyes drifted toward Sukuna.

Toward Higan.

"Your son or not...The Threads have already been woven."

She smiled, "They always end with him beside me."

Leora followed her gaze.

She looked at Higan only briefly.

Then back at Mora.

She smiled.

Warmly.

Almost pityingly.

"The Threads?"

The words were soft.

"What are Threads to me..."

Her crimson eyes seemed brighter.

"...when I have the Norns shaping them?"

Silence.

Complete.

Absolute.

Even Grinnir stopped moving.

Mora's expression changed.

Not anger.

Recognition.

"...What did you say?"

Leora's smile widened.

"Urðr remembers me."

A pause.

"Verðandi watches me."

Another.

"And Skuld..."

For the first time—

there was pride in her voice.

"...Skuld favors me."

The battlefield became unnaturally still.

Orm looked sharply toward Mora.

Syvreth's face emptied.

Even Grinnir's attention drifted from Mizuki for the briefest instant.

No one spoke.

Because no mortal should have uttered those names with such certainty.

Mora's voice had become dangerously quiet.

"You presume much."

Leora shook her head.

"I remember much."

The words struck harder than any weapon.

Mora's composure fractured.

"You are nothing more than an Alraune."

Leora laughed.

A single breath.

"That is what many before you have claimed. But, there are those who have known me as more than just that."

Leora grinned, "Who respects me *despite* that."

The earth beneath Mora blackened.

She raised one hand.

The ground answered.

It began with fingers.

Then wrists.

Arms.

Hundreds.

Thousands.

The soil convulsed as corpses clawed their way upward.

Warriors.

Children.

Kings.

Executioners.

Their armor rotted.

Their flesh hung in strips.

Still—

they stood.

The dead assembled in perfect silence.

An army.

Waiting.

Watching.

Ready.

Mora lowered her hand.

"Then let us see whether your Norns save you."

For one heartbeat—

no one moved.

Then—

Someone laughed.

It echoed across the field.

High.

Sharp.

Almost joyful.

Not human.

A fox.

The sound rolled through the dead ranks until even they seemed uncertain.

Friedhelm stood smiling.

No—

grinning.

His shoulders trembled.

Another laugh escaped him.

Longer this time.

The sound sent a ripple through the undead.

Several hesitated.

One stepped backward.

Friedhelm's hands darkened.

Not stained.

Changed.

The pale skin blackened from his fingertips to his wrists like ink spreading beneath flesh.

His fingers lengthened.

Nails became claws.

Not elegant.

Predatory.

His smile widened further.

"Finally."

Beside him—

Leora exhaled.

The same darkness crept beneath her skin.

Across her hands.

Up her forearms.

Her veins deepened.

Her canines lengthened.

When she smiled—

every Death Deity present understood.

This was not another phase of the fight.

This was the moment they had feared for centuries.

Not because the siblings had become stronger.

Because they had become recognizable.

Not as mortals.

But as something far older.

Something their own oldest stories warned them never to provoke.

Leora looked at the endless ranks of dead.

Then at her brother.

Their eyes met.

Neither spoke.

Neither needed to.

Friedhelm laughed again.

This time—

Leora answered with a fox's chittering click.

The ancient language needed no words.

The hunt had begun.

Leora disappeared first.

Not forward.

Sideways.

One heartbeat she stood beside Friedhelm.

The next there were twenty of her.

Then fifty.

Then hundreds.

The copies did not scatter.

They threaded through the charging dead as though they had rehearsed this battlefield long before anyone else had arrived.

The first corpse swung.

It struck nothing.

The Leora before it dissolved into drifting strands of silver hair.

Another appeared beneath its arm.

Her hand drove into its chest.

Not through.

Around.

Her fingers found the spine.

She planted one foot against its hip.

Pulled.

The entire vertebral column came free in one wet motion.

The corpse remained standing for a moment, hands still reaching.

Then everything beneath the neck folded inward.

She let the spine fall.

Another was already upon her.

Its jaws snapped.

Leora caught its throat.

Her claws sank into either side of its neck.

She bit.

Her teeth disappeared through flesh.

When she tore backward, the throat came with her.

The head struck the ground several paces away before the body realized it no longer possessed one.

She spat ruined flesh aside.

Three more.

Five.

Ten.

They closed around her.

None of them touched her.

Friedhelm never hurried.

He walked into them.

The first dead warrior lifted a rusted spear.

Friedhelm abandoned both axes before the thrust even came.

His palms settled on the creature's shoulders.

Almost gentle.

The corpse leaned into him.

Its mistake.

Friedhelm locked the shoulders in place.

Twisted the neck.

The head came away so cleanly the body stood another heartbeat before collapsing.

He reclaimed one axe without looking.

A second corpse seized his arm.

Friedhelm stepped inside its reach.

His teeth buried themselves in the creature's forearm.

Bone cracked.

He never released his bite.

Still holding the arm in his jaws, he drove his free axe through another corpse's knee.

The joint exploded sideways.

The third reached for his back.

He simply turned.

The corpse trapped in his teeth tore its own arm from its shoulder trying to follow.

Friedhelm released the ruined limb.

Blood ran from his mouth.

He smiled.

Not at the dead.

At Leora.

Another fox laugh echoed across the field.

Sukuna had seen Leora fight.

He had sparred with her.

He had hunted beside her.

He had watched her kill.

He had never seen this.

She wasn't choosing targets.

Neither of them were.

They were moving through the army the way wolves moved through a flock.

Not stopping.

Never stopping.

The dead were simply the ground beneath their feet.

Then—

Every Leora crossed through another.

Hundreds of silver-haired hunters shifted across the battlefield until even Sukuna lost track of which one had been standing where a heartbeat before.

One tore through a corpse's throat.

Another vanished beneath raised shields.

A third appeared behind a charging horse, sending rider and mount crashing into the dead around them.

Every copy hunted.

Every copy killed.

But only one slowed.

Only one reached into empty air.

White-gold fire gathered in her palm.

It climbed her forearm before bending into the elegant curve of a bow.

Sukuna found her instantly.

Not because he had followed her movements.

Because no copy could do that.

The blessing belonged to Leora alone.

The true huntress had revealed herself.

She drew.

The string sang.

One arrow became ten.

Ten became a hundred.

She loosed them.

They did not fall.

They hunted.

One curved around a shield before passing through the eye behind it.

Another found a corpse weaving between the others.

A third vanished into the trees before returning through the back of a fleeing soldier.

Entire ranks collapsed before they understood where death had come from.

Before the last body struck the earth—

The bow dissolved into white-gold flame.

Leora was already moving again.

The copies swallowed her once more.

The hunt became impossible to read.

Sukuna watched the battlefield change.

He counted without thinking.

Three breaths.

That was how long Leora usually remained still before moving again when she entered a fight she had already solved.

Four if she was protecting someone.

Two if she was angry.

This time—

Five.

Interesting.

The copies moved first.

Hundreds of silver-haired figures moved through the dead ranks, each one carrying the same posture, the same expression, the same quiet certainty.

Sukuna tracked them.

Not because he needed to.

Because he always did.

Leora had always hated being watched like an opponent.

She tolerated it from him.

Barely.

A corpse swung.

A copy vanished.

Another appeared.

Spinal extraction.

Efficient.

A throat kill.

Predictable.

The dead were not lasting long enough to force her into anything more complicated.

He glanced toward Friedhelm.

Different.

Friedhelm was enjoying himself.

That was obvious.

The laughter gave him away.

Everyone else mistook it for bloodlust.

Sukuna knew better.

Friedhelm laughed when he was free.

When he was fighting something worthy.

When he stopped carrying the weight of everything else for a few moments.

The first man he had ever looked at and thought:

Finally.

Not an equal in strength.

That was irrelevant.

An equal in presence.

Someone who did not bend.

Someone who did not pretend.

His attention returned to Leora.

Another hundred bodies fell.

Then one remained still.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed.

Not concern.

Interest.

The copies continued.

The original waited.

Her pulse had slowed.

Her breathing had changed.

She was preparing something.

Something she had never used in front of him.

White-gold fire gathered.

Sukuna watched the shape form.

A bow.

...

So.

That was the secret.

He stared for half a second longer.

Not because he was surprised.

Because he was adjusting.

Leora had never carried a bow around him.

Never mentioned one.

Never corrected him when he assumed her primary weapons were her voice and her bloodline techniques.

And yet her hands settled into position immediately.

No hesitation.

No adjustment.

No learning curve.

She had done this thousands of times.

His mouth almost curved.

Of course.

Of course she had.

The most dangerous Lieder alive had apparently kept one of her greatest weapons hidden.

Not from enemies.

Not from gods.

From him.

He would have been offended if it were anyone else.

With Leora...

it was almost charming.

Almost.

The string formed.

The battlefield quieted.

Sukuna watched the arrow.

Not the weapon.

Her.

The slight shift in her shoulder.

The angle of her wrist.

The way her breathing stopped for exactly one heartbeat before release.

Perfect.

The arrow flew.

Then multiplied.

The dead fell.

Sukuna continued watching.

Memorizing.

Another piece of her.

Another thing to keep.

Orm moved suddenly.

He went straight for Friedhelm.

The fox -king laughed.

His axes met Orm's arm with enough force to split stone.

Orm answered with his bare hands.

Steel screamed.

Elsewhere—

Syverth never stopped moving.

She was not trying to defeat Eirvorr.

She kept slipping away.

One step.

Two.

Always angling toward Leora.

Toward Higan.

Toward the children.

Eirvorr caught her sleeve.

She twisted free.

Again.

Again.

Again.

Sukuna watched the pattern.

Not the fight.

The direction.

She was looking for an opening.

He shifted his weight.

One step forward.

Ready.

Beside him, Skugga noticed.

Kyrr did too.

Kyrr looked down at Higan.

The little boy had buried his face against Sukuna's shoulder.

His tiny hands clung desperately to Sukuna's robe.

He wasn't crying loudly anymore.

Just...

shaking.

Small, uneven breaths.

Warm tears soaked into black silk.

Sukuna's jaw tightened.

Enough.

Something had frightened his son.

That alone was offensive.

Kyrr spoke quietly.

"If you believe Lady Leora would not object..."

His fingers gently brushed Higan's hair.

"...I can hold young Master Higan."

He looked toward Syverth.

"If she passes Eirvorr..."

"...you will have to fight"

Sukuna didn't answer immediately.

His eyes remained on the battlefield.

Then he looked back.

Tsukihiko sat on the ground with Kohaku wrapped completely inside his arms.

The boy's face was hidden beneath Tsukihiko's neck.

Tsukihiko kept scenting him.

Again.

Again.

Slow breaths against his hair.

Small licks across his forehead.

Quiet sounds.

Almost inaudible.

The noises were instinctive.

Older than words.

Kohaku's breathing gradually matched his father's.

Nearby—

Chōbei hadn't moved once.

Freyr remained tucked safely inside his robes exactly as he had carried him when he could scarcely hold his own head up.

One broad hand cupped the back of the boy's head.

The other never left Tsukihiko's shoulder.

Grounding him.

Grounding himself.

His eyes never left the battlefield.

He wasn't watching the fight.

He was reconstructing it.

Every movement.

Every wound.

Every decision.

Trying to find the moment his son had been hurt.

Trying to find where he had failed.

Sukuna knew that expression.

Chōbei would carry that failure until someone physically forced him to set it down.

Skugga exhaled softly.

"No, Kyrr. Sukuna should remain with Higan."

His eyes stayed on Syverth.

"I will fight if she comes."

A low growl answered him immediately.

Vargr.

It wasn't loud.

It didn't need to be.

The wolf god never looked away from Syverth.

But the meaning was unmistakable.

No.

Skugga glanced sideways. His tone asked for reason.

"..Vargr."

The growl deepened.

Sukuna understood.

Vargr had no intention of allowing Skugga into that battle.

The wolf finally looked toward Sukuna.

No words.

Only certainty.

If Syverth came—

they would meet her together.

Kyrr smiled faintly.

He reached toward Higan again.

Softly.

Patiently.

His fingers stroked the child's hair while he hummed under his breath.

Not a song Sukuna recognized.

Something quieter.

Something without language.

Higan's trembling slowed.

His breathing steadied.

Then—

small hands reached toward Kyrr.

Sukuna transferred him without hesitation.

Kyrr settled Higan against his chest.

The boy immediately buried his face beneath Kyrr's chin.

Still sniffing.

But no longer shaking.

"If she comes..."

Sukuna's voice was calm.

"Vargr and I fight."

He looked once toward Skugga.

"You stay."

Then to Kyrr.

"You, too."

Neither argued.

Steel exploded.

Orm's hand slipped beneath Friedhelm's guard.

Not through it.

Inside it.

His claws drove into Friedhelm's side.

They disappeared to the wrist.

Blood burst across the snow.

Dark.

Almost black.

Friedhelm's laughter stopped.

Only for a heartbeat.

At the same instant—

Mora moved.

She ignored every copy.

Found the original.

The spear struck.

It punched through Leora's chest.

The point exploded from her back.

Then buried itself deep into the tree behind her.

The trunk cracked.

Leora's body jerked violently against the shaft.

Blood spilled down the pale wood.

For the first time—

she stopped moving.

Across the battlefield—

everything hesitated.

Grimnir drove Mizuki to the ground.

The impact cracked stone beneath him.

A hand closed around his throat before he could rise.

"Watch," Grinnir whispered. "Watch your mother die. Watch your uncle follow her. Then I'll take Kyrr back to Helheim, and he'll spend another thousand years in the dark."

"Mama!"

The scream tore across the battlefield.

Sukuna's head snapped toward it.

Mizuki strained beneath Grinnir's weight, clawing at the arm pinning him down.

Sukuna moved.

At the same instant, Eirvorr reached Leora first.

Across the field, Syverth saw Orm falter beneath Friedhelm's assault.

She abandoned Sukuna without hesitation and turned.

Friedhelm had to die.

There would never be a better chance.

Sukuna stopped.

His eyes flicked once between Leora...

...Friedhelm...

...Mizuki...

There wasn't time.

Eirvorr caught her before she could fall.

His hands closed around the shaft of the spear.

"Hold still."

He snapped the wood, braced one hand against her back, and
drew the iron free in a single motion.

Blood followed it.

Leora staggered.

He reached for her.

She caught his wrist.

"No."

His brows drew together.

"You're bleeding."

"I know."

He shifted to lift her anyway.

She stopped him again.

"Go to my family."

"Leora—"

"Protect them."

His eyes searched her face.

"You're asking me to leave you."

"I'm asking you to do what I cannot."

His jaw tightened.

"There are too many gods."

"Then Friedhelm and I will answer them."

"You'll die."

She smiled.

It wasn't resignation.

It wasn't fear.

It was the smile of someone who had finally stopped running.

"Perhaps."

Silence.

"You mean to meet them as your ancestors did."

"Yes."

He closed his eyes for a moment.

"..You would seek a warrior's death."

"If that is where my road ends."

His fingers trembled against hers.

"If you die like this..."

He couldn't finish it.

She understood anyway.

She lifted a bloodied hand and rested it against his cheek.

"Everything has its fate."

He leaned into her touch despite himself.

"Would you deny me mine?"

He stood motionless.

Then, after a long moment...

"...No."

The word hurt him.

More than any wound she had ever seen him bear.

She let her hand fall.

"Go."

He looked at her one last time.

Then he was gone.

Leora turned.

Sukuna hadn't moved.

They were still separated by the battlefield.

She smiled at him.

Small.

Tired.

Entirely hers.

"Protect our children."

He didn't answer.

His eyes searched every wound, every drop of blood soaking
through her clothes.

As if memorizing them.

"Leora—"

"Go."

He hated the word.

She had said it twice now.

Once to Eirvorr.

Now to him.

She held his gaze.

"I love you."

For the first time since the battle began, Sukuna had no answer.

She stepped backward.

Shadow gathered around her feet.

Before it swallowed her, she smiled once more.

Then she was gone.

When she appeared again it was between Orm and Syrveth. She turned to the goddess and smiled, "I believe you've been waiting for the opportunity to fight me."

Syrveth lunged towards Leora. Her face was contorted into a snarl. For one moment, she forgot her mask. It lifted.

It was grotesque beyond words.

Eirvorr smiled to himself.

Sukuna realized once again that he and Eirvorr were much too similar for comfort.

Friedhelm made a series of chirping and whistling noises. Leora answered him back with what almost sounded like barks.

Syrveth struck first.

Her blade skimmed Leora's ribs.

Too shallow.

Leora didn't retreat.

She stepped inside the goddess's reach.

Their foreheads nearly touched.

Leora whispered something.

Not any language Sukuna knew.

A low breath.

A growl hidden beneath words.

The hair on his arms rose.

Syrveth's expression changed from confusion to one of abject horror.

"...What did you say?"

Leora smiled.

Syrveth screamed, "What did you say, witch!?"

Leora looked at her, "Wolf... King says hunt."

Leora reached upwards.

She seamlessly caught one of Friedhelm's axes as he tossed it to her.

Then, she drove the butt into Syrveth's jaw.

The goddess staggered.

Leora's claws opened her forearm as she passed.

Not deep.

Just enough.

Syrveth answered with a slash across Leora's shoulder.

Leora accepted it.

Another cut.

Across Syrveth's thigh.

Again.

Across the ribs.

Again.

The back of the hand.

The neck.

The hip.

None of them should have mattered.

Too shallow.

Too scattered.

Leora never committed to a killing blow.

She simply...kept touching her.

Marking her.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed.

That wasn't like the fighting he'd seen since this started.

But, he knew that look.

She was counting something.

Leora breathed again.

One word.

The sound rolled across the battlefield like something answering from very far away.

"Hungry."

Syrveth froze.

Every insignificant wound split open.

Not one after another.

All together.

Blood erupted from a dozen places.

Muscle peeled apart.

The goddess lurched, suddenly unable to bear weight on one leg.

She stared at herself.

"...No..."

Leora was already moving.

Another shallow cut.

Another.

Another.

Never wasting motion.

Never lingering.

Always counting.

Sukuna watched her work.

"King says..."

Me.

The thought arrived without invitation.

This was not a duel. Not an execution.

A hunt.

The prey didn't know when it had already lost.

Another word.

Quieter this time.

"Eat."

Syrveth screamed.

The second wave came.

Bone cracked beneath flesh that had seemed barely scratched moments before.

One shoulder sagged.

Two fingers dropped into the grass.

A line across her abdomen opened almost to the spine.

She collapsed to one knee.

Leora looked almost disappointed.

She tilted her head.

"...Still standing."

Then she smiled.

Leora inhaled.

One final command.

The world seemed to hold its breath with her.

"Eat. again, wolf"

Syrveth convulsed.

Every mark became a killing wound.

It looked as though unseen jaws closed over her all at once.

Flesh vanished.

Bones snapped.

Blood burst outward in violent arcs.

The goddess's scream ended halfway through the sound.

Silence.

Leora was already turning.

Sukuna had never seen this technique but he filed it away.

Another piece of her.

Another thing she had carried all these years without ever showing him.

Or, something she had developed in secret after getting to know him. Either way, his name was linked with Wulf once in a way he did not entirely like.

I love the idea of him singing here—not because it's dramatic, but because it makes the violence feel ritualistic instead of emotional. Friedhelm isn't enraged anymore. He's working. The song is for Skugga, not for Orm. Orm almost becomes incidental.

I'd also avoid having him sing the whole chant. People don't sing an entire battle hymn while dissecting someone. Fragments are much more haunting. They rise and fall with his breathing and his work.

I'd write the opening something like this:

Orm drove both hands into Friedhelm's side again.

Claws disappeared to the wrist.

Friedhelm grunted.

Nothing more.

Blood ran freely over Orm's forearms.

Mora looked up from Leora.

Her face changed instantly.

"Orm!"

He didn't look away from Friedhelm.

"Don't let him get two hands on you!"

Too late.

Friedhelm's hands closed over Orm's wrists.

Not violently.

Firmly.

He leaned forward until their foreheads almost touched.

"You should've listened."

With one savage wrench he tore Orm's claws free from his own body.

Blood poured down his stomach.

Orm smiled—

—and Friedhelm's hands disappeared beneath his ribs.

Not through flesh.

Between them.

His fingers found the spaces nature had already made.

Then they pulled.

A wet crack echoed across the battlefield.

Orm's chest opened like split timber.

Not enough to kill him.

Enough.

Gold rang softly beneath Friedhelm's fingertips.

"...there you are."

He began to sing.

Quietly.

Almost too softly to hear.

Þú hélt mér þegar ég var enginn...

You held me when I was no one...

Orm looked down.

"What are you—"

Friedhelm ignored him.

His fingers closed around something solid.

Cold.

Heavy.

Metal.

He drew.

The heart rune slid free with a long metallic scrape.

CLANG.

It rang against Friedhelm's knuckles.

Not much larger than the center of his palm.

Pure gold.

Carved on both faces.

Still warm.

Orm screamed.

Friedhelm didn't even look at him.

He threaded the rune onto the black chain hanging beneath his collar.

Clink.

Then he continued singing.

Þú mundir mig þegar heimurinn gleymdi...

You remembered me when the world forgot...

Orm stumbled backward, clutching the hole in his chest.

"...give it back..."

Friedhelm stepped after him.

"No."

His hand settled gently against Orm's throat.

Not squeezing.

Feeling.

Searching.

Again.

Gold.

Again the scrape of metal against bone.

Again—

CLANG.

The throat rune came free.

Orm's voice vanished.

His scream became breath.

Nothing more.

Friedhelm added the second rune to the chain.

Clink.

Only then did he let Orm fall.

The god hit the earth hard.

Still alive.

Still trying to crawl.

Friedhelm knelt beside him.

Calmly.

As though tending a wounded animal.

Ég er ekki tómið...

I am not emptiness...

His hand disappeared into Orm's shoulder.

Orm began shaking his head violently.

No.

No.

Please—

Another metallic ring.

Another rune.

Then the other shoulder.

Then the right hand.

Then the left.

Each one removed with the same terrible patience.

Each one cleaned once across Friedhelm's blood-soaked thumb before joining the others.

Clink.

Clink.

Clink.

By now every god had stopped fighting long enough to watch.

No one moved.

No one spoke.

Only Friedhelm's voice carried across the battlefield.

Soft.

Almost affectionate.

As though Skugga alone were listening.

Refur minn fann sinn...

My fox found his...

He reached Orm's right leg.

Orm tried to kick.

Nothing happened.

Friedhelm removed the rune anyway.

Then the left.

The last of Orm's strength vanished with it.

He lay motionless.

Breathing.

Unable to stand.

Unable to cross.

Unable to follow anyone anywhere.

Only then did Friedhelm rest one bloody hand against Orm's forehead.

His thumb settled over the final rune.

The head.

He closed his eyes.

For a long moment...

...he simply breathed.

Then he lifted his hand away.

"...No."

His voice was barely audible.

"I know what it is to lose yourself."

He stood.

The chain disappeared beneath his blood-soaked turtleneck.

Gold settled against gold beneath the black fabric.

Softly.

Clink.

Without another glance at Orm...

Friedhelm pulled his axe free.

And his shadow stretched and stretched until it met Skugga's feet.

Syrveth's fingers twitched.

A strip of muscle drew itself back across exposed bone.

Then another.

The goddess was regenerating.

Leora stopped.

Slowly, she turned.

Syrveth looked up.

For the first time since their battle began, something close to relief crossed her ruined expression.

Leora only raised her hand.

Palm forward.

White-gold flame gathered in her palm.

Sukuna's attention shifted immediately.

He knew that stance.

Not because he had seen it before.

Because he knew what it meant when Leora became still.

The battlefield around her seemed to quiet.

Even the gods noticed.

Vargr lowered his head.

Skugga stopped moving.

Eirvorr's eyes narrowed.

Leora's fingers curled.

The flame stretched backward.

Not outward.

Backward.

Like a bowstring being drawn.

The air compressed around her hand.

The pressure was wrong.

Not the same as her arrows.

Not the same as her cursed speech.

Something heavier.

Something meant to break.

Sukuna stared.

His mind immediately began taking it apart.

The draw.

The release.

The direction of force.

The concentration of power into a single point before expansion.

Then Leora released.

Palm Flame Draw.

The battlefield disappeared beneath the impact.

A wave of white-gold destruction erupted outward.

The earth tore apart.

Trees bent and shattered.

Stone split.

The force moved across everything within its reach with no distinction between armor, flesh, or divine body.

Even the gods were forced back.

Syrveth took the full force.

Her body was thrown against the ground.

The regeneration stopped.

The wound beneath reality itself appeared.

The battlefield had already been damaged by the deaths of gods, by the removal of their runes, by the violence of the battle.

But this was different.

The force of Palm Flame Draw struck deeper.

The boundary between Life and Death could not withstand it.

The world split.

Not cracked.

Split.

A wound opened across the battlefield.

More than a hundred meters high.

More than a hundred meters wide.

Beyond it—

Death.

Black water flowed beneath a darkened sky.

Reeds stretched along the riverbank, bending endlessly in the unseen wind.

The first gate stood in the distance.

Figures moved beyond the shore.

The dead.

Watching.

Every living creature on the battlefield felt it.

Not fear.

Recognition.

They were looking into a place no living being was meant to see.

Sukuna did not move.

His eyes remained fixed on the opening.

His mind worked despite himself.

The force required.

The control required.

The fact that the technique had not simply destroyed the battlefield but torn through something far older.

Impossible.

And yet—

Leora had done it.

He filed every detail away.

The movement.

The flame.

The release.

The feeling of reality giving way.

He would understand it.

Eventually.

But first—

Leora walked toward Syrveth.

The goddess tried to rise.

She failed.

Her body was too damaged.

Her regeneration had been interrupted.

Leora crouched beside her.

"You should have stayed in death."

Syrveth looked up.

No anger remained.

Only realization.

Leora reached into her chest.

Metal rang.

A solid golden rune came free into her palm.

Syrveth screamed.

Leora placed the rune onto the chain around her neck.

Click.

The sound was small.

Almost gentle.

She reached again.

Another rune.

Then another.

Each one came free with the same metallic chime.

Gold against gold.

Her voice.

Her strength.

Her movement.

Her power.

One by one.

Syrveth did not fight.

She understood.

This was not a battle anymore.

Leora was removing what made her a goddess.

The final rune remained.

The head rune.

Leora stared at her.

"You were given every chance."

Her hand closed.

The rune came free.

The chain grew heavier.

Leora stood.

She placed it around her neck with the others.

Then she tucked the chain beneath her black collar.

Hidden.

Carried.

She turned away.

Syrveth was not allowed to remain.

Not after what she had done.

Not after what she would do again.

Leora lifted her axe.

The battlefield went silent.

One strike.

Syrveth fell.

The goddess of ruined beauty died without her mask.

Without her power.

Without the thing she had spent eternity trying to take from someone else.

Leora turned away.

Behind her, Friedhelm dragged Orm toward the opening between worlds.

Orm still had his head rune.

Nothing else.

Friedhelm had taken the rest.

Not out of mercy.

Not entirely.

Because he knew what it meant to have a person's identity torn apart.

Orm had earned consequences.

He had not earned that.

Friedhelm stopped at the edge of the tear.

The river below moved silently.

The dead watched.

Orm looked back.

Friedhelm said nothing.

He simply threw him.

Orm disappeared into Death.

The wound remained open.

A warning.

A reminder.

A place even gods could be forced to face.

Leora continued walking.

Mora waited ahead.

And when Leora approached, the goddess understood.

She would not be spared.

Leora stopped before Mora.

The goddess was barely recognizable.

Not because of wounds.

Because of what had been taken from her.

Her power was gone.

Her runes were gone.

The certainty that had carried her into this battlefield had been stripped away piece by piece.

Mora looked up at her.

And for the first time—

she understood.

Leora was not approaching as someone who had survived.

She was approaching as someone who had decided.

"You looked into the threads."

Leora's voice was quiet.

Not angry.

That was worse.

"You saw him."

Mora's expression shifted.

"You saw my son."

Leora crouched.

"You watched him grow."

Her eyes narrowed.

"You watched him become something magnificent."

A pause.

"And instead of accepting what you saw..."

Leora smiled faintly.

"You became consumed by it."

Mora looked away.

Leora continued.

"You wanted what belonged to another."

Her fingers traced the chain of golden runes beneath her collar.

"You came here to take my son from his mother."

The battlefield remained silent.

"You decided I was finished."

Another pause.

"You decided I should die."

Mora's eyes lifted.

"You decided an inferior vessel would be elevated in my place."

Leora's expression hardened.

"Kiyomi."

The name carried no hatred.

Only judgment.

"You decided you could replace what could not be replaced."

She leaned closer.

"You attempted to bind Nidr."

A small breath escaped her.

"Something no Alraune before you accomplished."

Mora's face tightened.

"And after all of that..."

Leora tilted her head.

"You decided my brother would die."

Her smile disappeared.

"And my son would become a child bride."

Silence.

Then Leora lowered herself until they were eye level.

Mora expected rage.

She expected hatred.

Instead—

Leora smiled.

Almost gently.

"No."

The word was soft.

"I am not finished."

Her hand moved.

Fast.

Precise.

Methodical.

Mora barely had time to react before Leora's fingers were already inside the ruined remains of her divine structure.

A golden rune came free.

Then another.

Then another.

Each one struck the chain with a metallic click.

Heart.

No.

Not yet.

Head.

No.

Not yet.

Everything else.

One by one.

Mora's strength disappeared.

Her authority.

Her movement.

Her connection.

Leora worked without hesitation.

"You should have remembered what the old stories said."

Another rune.

Click.

"I am the ninth."

Another.

"I am the last."

Another.

"I am the breath of the breath that passed."

Mora stared at her.

Unable to move.

Unable to stop her.

"I am the exceptional one."

The final rune beneath the head remained.

Leora leaned closer.

"I am the one who walks where you cannot."

Her eyes met Mora's.

"The one who remembers before death."

A pause.

"Before the separation."

Her hand moved toward Mora's chest.

"Before you even existed."

Her fingers entered.

Mora gasped.

Leora's hand closed.

Then she pulled.

The heart came free.

Still beating.

The goddess remained alive.

For one final moment.

The heart pulsed in Leora's hand.

Sukuna watched.

And even he went still.

Not because he had never seen violence.

Because he knew exactly what kind of technique this was.

Not destruction.

Consumption.

The hunter taking from the hunted.

Leora looked down at the heart.

"Before you..."

She lifted it slightly.

"Hel reigned in Helheim."

Her eyes returned to Mora.

"You inherited her throne."

Mora screamed.

Leora bit.

The battlefield seemed to freeze.

The moment her teeth broke through the heart, power surged back into her.

Not Mora's.

Not entirely.

Fragments.

Instincts.

Memories.

The taste of another existence.

The weight of another perspective.

Leora swallowed.

And for a brief moment—

she knew.

Then it was gone.

Only strength remained.

A short distance away, Narva screamed.

Friedhelm stood over her.

She was missing her leg runes.

One arm rune.

One hand rune.

Her power was collapsing.

Friedhelm looked toward the opening between worlds.

Then back to her.

No anger.

No cruelty.

Only finality.

Narva was thrown into Death.

The opening swallowed her.

Leora never looked away from Mora.

"Narva will inherit the throne of Helheim."

She looked down at the dying goddess.

"And you will die today."

A breath.

"How weak you all are compared to my gods."

Her voice sharpened.

"You think you are above us."

"Not like us."

She looked toward the wound between Life and Death.

"Perhaps you are different."

A pause.

"My gods..."

Her eyes moved over the battlefield.

"The Old Gods."

"They are as real as flesh and blood."

"They laugh."

"They cry."

"They bleed."

"They love."

"They take revenge."

"They protect their children."

Leora looked back down at Mora.

"You forgot that."

Her fingers tightened around the last remaining rune.

"The Young Gods forgot."

She stood.

And the battlefield listened.

"Let them learn today..."

Her gaze swept over the fallen.

"...that they can die."

A final pause.

"And that we are the ones who can kill them."

Mizuki had watched everything.

Every rune removed.

Every god brought down.

Every certainty shattered.

He had watched his mother stand before beings that had believed themselves untouchable and make them understand the difference between divinity and power.

He had watched Friedhelm.

He had watched Leora.

And now—

he understood.

Grimnir understood too.

But unlike Mizuki, Grimnir did not know what to do with that understanding.

He stumbled backward.

Then another step.

His eyes moved across the battlefield.

The dead gods.

The open wound between worlds.

The Ten Brinken standing among them.

No.

Not standing.

Remaining.

Grimnir turned.

He ran.

Sukuna saw it happen.

The fear had finally reached him.

Not the controlled fear of someone calculating an escape.

Not strategy.

Panic.

A mistake.

Mizuki moved before anyone else.

The ground cracked beneath his feet.

Grimnir barely turned before Mizuki struck him.

The impact sent him into the earth hard enough to shake the surrounding stones.

For a moment, Sukuna thought he understood what would happen.

He saw Mizuki above him.

Saw his mouth open.

Saw the position of his head.

The throat.

A killing bite.

A familiar instinct.

Then Mizuki changed.

Sukuna's eyes narrowed.

Instead of the throat—

the arm.

Mizuki bit down.

Not to kill.

To hold.

To anchor.

To stop Grimmir from moving.

Sukuna knew that.

Because he had seen it before.

Friedhelm.

The fox.

The way he fought.

The way he refused to let anything escape once he had decided it belonged in his grasp.

Grimnir screamed.

Mizuki did not release him.

His hands moved.

Not wildly.

Not with rage.

Methodically.

A butcher.

A craftsman.

A Ten Brinken.

The first rune came loose.

Gold flashed against the bloodied ground.

Then another.

Then another.

The metallic sound carried across the battlefield.

Click.

Click.

Click.

Grimnir fought.

For one moment, he almost managed to throw Mizuki off.

His strength surged.

His body twisted.

Mizuki slipped.

Then Friedhelm was there.

Instantly.

One hand locked around Grimmir's shoulder.

The other forced him back down.

"No."

The word was quiet.

Not a command.

A reminder.

Mizuki looked at him.

Friedhelm nodded once.

Continue.

So he did.

The runes came free one by one.

The sounds filled the yard.

The final struggles.

The tearing of metal from flesh.

The breathless movements of someone learning exactly what they were capable of.

And then—

silence.

Nothing moved.

Nothing remained of Grinnir except what the battlefield had left behind.

Mizuki stayed there.

On his haunches.

Breathing hard.

Looking down.

Not horrified.

Not proud.

Simply trying to understand the weight of what he had done.

Friedhelm crouched beside him.

Slowly, he removed a leather cord from around his own wrist.

He gathered the runes.

One by one.

The gold pieces rested against the cord.

Then he tied it.

Carefully.

Deliberately.

He placed it around Mizuki's neck.

For a moment, he said nothing.

Then his hand rose.

He cupped Mizuki's cheek.

"Today..."

His thumb brushed away the blood.

"you are officially a Ten Brinken."

Mizuki looked at him.

Friedhelm smiled slightly.

"You can wear our ceremonial clothes."

A pause.

"And I will make you an oath band."

His hand moved to Mizuki's shoulder.

A firm pat.

A promise.

Above them, the tear between Life and Death began to close.

Slowly.

The river disappeared first.

Then the reeds.

Then the gate.

Then the dead.

The world stitched itself back together.

Leora was still bleeding.

Sukuna noticed immediately.

Of course he did.

He had been noticing every breath.

Every change.

Every second she remained standing despite the damage.

She touched the wound at her side.

Then lifted her head.

"Eirvorr."

The deity looked at her.

Slowly, he approached.

Not rushing.

Not because he lacked urgency.

Because he understood her.

He stopped just before her.

Within reach.

But not touching.

Leora spoke quietly.

Only he heard.

"I'm not finished."

Something in Eirvorr's expression shifted.

She looked toward the battlefield.

Toward the fallen.

Toward the children.

"I refuse to die like this."

Her voice remained steady.

"Slowly."

A breath.

"Wasting away."

Her eyes hardened.

"For what?"

She looked back at him.

"For another Alraune to follow after me?"

"For someone so weak that she will be slaughtered for the child inside her?"

"For another child to grow up used?"

Her fingers curled.

"No."

A pause.

"I refuse that."

Her gaze lowered.

"I was supposed to die at twenty-four."

The words were simple.

A fact.

"I have avoided death until now."

She looked at him.

"And now I will do whatever it takes."

Eirvorr did not move.

Then—

Leora reached for the black ribbon.

Das Schwarze Band.

The world seemed to stop.

Skugga gasped.

Audibly.

Eirvorr froze.

The deity who had waited.

Who had watched.

Who had offered.

His expression changed completely.

Hope.

Not greed.

Not triumph.

Hope.

His hands trembled.

His face looked almost painfully human.

As though the impossible thing he had never allowed himself to imagine had happened.

Leora took the ribbon.

She wrapped it.

Her fingers tightened.

Eirvorr made a broken sound.

Small.

Strangled.

Sukuna hated it instantly.

He hated the sound.

He hated the expression on Eirvorr's face.

He hated that something about it felt genuine.

Vargr stared.

Even he looked unsettled.

Then Eirvorr moved.

Slowly.

Carefully.

He placed his hand over hers.

Over the ribbon.

Das Schwarze Band.

For one moment, neither moved.

Then the ribbon split.

A section remained around Leora's hand.

The rest returned to him.

Eirvorr smiled.

Sweetly.

Sadly.

Not victorious.

Leora searched his face.

Her eyes had changed.

The silver-blue was gone.

Sun Wolf burned there now.

Gold.

Bright.

Ancient.

Eirvorr began to turn away.

Leora reached out.

Her fingers caught the fabric of his chest.

He stopped.

She spoke again.

Only he heard.

His expression softened.

Like he was answering a question she had not spoken aloud.

Like he was assuring her.

Then Sukuna saw the dagger.

His body went still.

Leora drew it.

Not toward an enemy.

Toward herself.

A sharp movement.

Precise.

Controlled.

The kind of movement that told him she had already decided.

The kind that terrified him.

She removed one of her ribs.

Eirvorr fell.

Not dramatically.

Not from weakness.

From the sheer impossibility of what she had given him.

His knees struck the ground.

His hands opened.

Reverent.

Careful.

Like he was afraid the slightest wrong movement would break something sacred.

Leora placed the rib into his hands.

Eirvorr stared.

Openly.

Completely.

Disbelief.

Awe.

For once—

the deity who understood every attachment, every fixation, every choice—

had no words.

He looked at her as though he had been given something he had spent eternity knowing he would never receive.

Then slowly, he closed his hands around it.

And he left.

Sukuna watched him go.

And for the first time in the entire battle—

he had no idea what he had just witnessed.

The veil groaned.

Not like cloth.

Like the world itself had begun stitching flesh back together.

The wound between Life and Death narrowed by inches.

Leora swayed.

Before she could fall, Friedhelm was beside her.

His bloody hand caught her elbow.

They exchanged a few quiet words.

Too soft for anyone else to hear.

Sukuna watched them.

Then both siblings stopped.

At the exact same moment.

Their heads lifted.

They inhaled.

And smiled.

Not with relief.

With recognition.

Something was coming.

Something only they had sensed.

Skugga stiffened.

Vargr immediately drew him against his side, one broad arm wrapping around his shoulders.

"It always scares me," Skugga whispered.

Vargr rubbed his back once.

"It will scare the pups."

Sukuna's eyes flicked instinctively toward the children.

Kohaku.

Freyr.

Higan.

Kyrr exhaled quietly.

"It cannot help its appearance."

He folded his hands into his sleeves.

"It has never frightened me."

Skugga gave a tiny nod.

"I know."

His ears lowered.

"But I do not wish for Kohaku or Freyr to cry."

The narrowing tear shuddered.

Then—

Something enormous stepped through.

Not a deity.

Not a curse.

Not human.

It unfolded into the world like something that had never belonged in it.

Every instinct Sukuna possessed screamed.

Run.

Its body was wrong.

Too many joints.

Too many eyes buried beneath folds of pale flesh.

Its spine rose and fell beneath translucent skin like the backs of sleeping beasts trapped inside it.

Long black hair hung in wet ropes almost to the ground.

Its arms reached nearly to its knees.

Each hand ended in claws longer than swords.

Its mouth...

Its mouth stretched far too wide.

Rows.

Upon rows.

Upon rows of teeth.

It smelled of wet earth.

Ancient forests.

Fresh blood.

Milk.

Rain.

And something so old Sukuna had no name for it.

The yard fell silent.

Even the wind stopped.

Then—

Leora laughed.

Not loudly.

Just once.

Bright.

Warm.

"...Grandfather."

Friedhelm was already moving.

The creature answered with a low rumble that vibrated through everyone's ribs.

Then it hurried.

Not elegantly.

Almost clumsily.

With unmistakable urgency.

It reached them in seconds.

Its massive body folded around both siblings.

Carefully.

So impossibly carefully.

One enormous hand cupped the back of Friedhelm's head.

Another gathered Leora against its chest.

It lowered its face.

Sniffed.

Once.

Twice.

Again.

Then made a broken little whine.

Leora laughed again through exhausted tears.

"I know."

The creature nudged her shoulder.

Then Friedhelm's cheek.

Then sniffed the blood soaking both of them.

Another distressed sound escaped it.

It began licking blood from Friedhelm's temple with astonishing gentleness.

Friedhelm leaned into it without hesitation.

Like someone greeting family after a long journey.

Leora buried her face against its neck.

"...We're all right."

It didn't believe her.

It kept checking.

Her shoulder.

Her side.

Her hands.

Every wound.

Every bruise.

Every scrape.

Its claws—capable of splitting mountains—never left so much as a scratch.

Sukuna stared.

The horror standing before him...

was comforting them.

No.

It was fussing over them.

Like a worried parent.

The creature suddenly froze.

Its head turned.

Slowly.

Toward Mizuki.

Then Tsukihiko.

Toward Kohaku.

Freyr.

Finally—

Higan.

Its pupils widened.

Another sound escaped it.

High.

Almost questioning.

Leora smiled without looking back.

"They're yours too."

The creature's entire posture changed.

Not smaller.

Not less monstrous.

Only...

gentler.

Almost timid.

As though suddenly afraid of frightening them.

It took one careful step forward.

Then another.

Its enormous crimson eyes never left the children.

Kyrr smiled softly.

"It remembers every one."

Skugga nodded.

"It always does."

Sukuna did not move.

His hand rested lightly on Higan's back.

The child stared.

Wide-eyed.

Not crying.

Simply staring.

The creature stopped several paces away.

It did not reach.

Did not force itself closer.

Instead it lowered itself—

Slowly.

Until its towering body rested almost at eye level with the children.

Then it waited.

Perfectly still.

Patient.

Like it had done this countless times before.

Its enormous chest rumbled once.

A low, steady sound.

Not speech.

Not quite.

Something older.

Something instinctively soothing.

Leora watched it with exhausted affection.

"...It still remembers how."

Friedhelm smiled.

"It never forgot."

And somehow...

That was the most frightening thing Sukuna had witnessed all day.

Not because it was a monster.

But because something this ancient—

Something that had existed before death itself—

Looked upon Leora and Friedhelm...

...and saw only its children.

Chōbei saw it move.

That was enough.

He shoved Kaguya and Linnea farther behind him with one arm.

"Back."

Tōma understood immediately.

He moved with him, placing himself beside his brother, sword already drawn as he herded the rest of the family toward the outer wall of the training grounds.

Kohaku was pressed tightly against Tsukihiko.

Freyr disappeared beneath Chōbei's robes without being told.

Chōbei's hand settled over the back of the boy's head automatically.

His eyes never left the creature.

"No."

His voice carried across the courtyard.

"After everything that just happened..."

His grip tightened around the hilt of his dao.

"...no."

"If it comes another step toward them, I'll kill it."

The Progenitor answered with a low warning call.

It shifted its weight.

Not toward Chōbei.

Toward the scent beneath his robes.

Toward Freyr.

Leora and Friedhelm immediately understood.

Both hurried toward them.

"Chōbei!"

Leora's voice broke through the tension.

"Stop!"

She reached them breathing hard, one arm still wrapped around the wound in her side.

"It isn't looking at you."

"It can smell that one of the children is hurt."

Chōbei didn't lower his weapon.

"It'll have to forgive me if I don't gamble my sons on that."

"It isn't a gamble."

"It doesn't know you."

"It knows blood."

Friedhelm stepped beside her, breathing just as heavily.

"It thinks you're keeping one of its descendants from it."

Another distressed sound left the Progenitor.

It took half a step.

Chōbei shifted instantly, placing himself completely between it and the children.

The creature stopped.

Leora closed her eyes for a moment.

"Ulfhamr..."

Pain bent her sharply at the waist.

She caught herself before she fell.

When she looked up again, her voice had softened.

"Please."

"It won't hurt you."

"It won't hurt any of them."

She swallowed.

"He's Kohaku's and Freyr's one hundred and sixtieth great-grandfather."

Silence.

Chōbei stared at her.

Then at the creature.

Then back again.

Nothing in his expression changed.

Sukuna recognized the calculation.

He wasn't dismissing her.

He was measuring the risk.

Against everything he loved.

Behind Chōbei, Tsukihiko had gone still.

His eyes never left the creature.

Neither did the creature's leave him.

Leora turned toward Sukuna.

Then toward Kyrr.

"...May I have my son?"

Kyrr looked to Sukuna.

Sukuna's hand closed around Leora's wrist before he thought about it.

She was barely standing.

Blood still slipped steadily through her fingers.

He wanted this over.

He wanted her out of the courtyard.

He wanted her somewhere he could make her sit down long enough to breathe.

The Progenitor made another warning sound.

Its attention snapped to Sukuna's hand.

Leora looked up at him.

"Sukuna."

"He doesn't know you're my husband yet."

Her thumb rested lightly against the back of his hand.

"Trust me."

He held her gaze another moment.

Then released her.

Kyrr stepped forward and placed Higan carefully into her arms.

The Progenitor watched.

Its body began changing almost immediately.

Its posture lowered.

Its shoulders narrowed.

The impossible width of its jaw softened.

Rows of teeth disappeared behind closing lips.

Secondary eyes vanished beneath folds of pale skin until only two crimson eyes remained.

It approached slowly.

One clawed finger brushed Higan's hair away from his forehead.

Then it waited.

Higan stared.

His tiny hand reached up.

Touched its cheek.

He smiled.

Then laughed.

"Otōsan."

He looked back toward Sukuna with delighted surprise.

"Look!"

The Progenitor answered with a low, contented rumble.

Sukuna barely looked at it.

His attention remained fixed on Leora.

She was swaying.

Every few breaths she caught herself.

She hadn't stopped bleeding.

Not once.

The creature lifted its head.

Its nose twitched.

Looking.

Searching.

Until its gaze settled on Tsukihiko.

Leora smiled.

"My oldest."

The Progenitor inhaled again.

Then looked toward Sukuna.

Leora gently lifted Sukuna's wrist.

She held it beneath the creature's nose.

It sniffed.

She spoke slowly.

"Mine."

She touched Sukuna's chest.

"Them."

She gestured toward the children.

"Father."

Another touch to Sukuna.

"Home."

She swept her hand over all of them.

"Protect."

Then repeated quietly,

"Mine."

"Them."

The creature sniffed Sukuna again.

Longer this time.

Then turned.

Its attention found Freyr.

Still hidden beneath Chōbei's robes.

Tsukihiko understood immediately.

He laid a hand gently against Chōbei's forearm.

"It's all right."

Chōbei looked at him.

Tsukihiko nodded once.

Then carefully lifted Chōbei's arm enough for the creature to see Freyr.

The Progenitor froze.

A broken, distressed sound escaped it.

It lowered itself immediately.

Sniffed the injured eye.

Again.

Again.

Then gently licked across the wound.

Freyr stayed perfectly still.

The torn flesh knitted together beneath its tongue.

Bruising faded.

The swollen eyelid settled.

The damaged eye cleared.

When the creature finally drew back, only a thin scar remained through Freyr's eyebrow.

Chōbei watched every second.

His eyes never left his son.

Only when he was certain the wound was gone...

did he finally look at the creature itself.

Really look at it.

The thing was staring only at Freyr.

Still making quiet, worried sounds.

Still checking him.

Like nothing else in the world mattered.

Chōbei stepped forward.

Slowly.

Then, without a word, wrapped both arms around the creature's neck.

The Progenitor went completely still.

As though it had forgotten how to move.

Then, very carefully...

it leaned into the embrace.

Exactly. This is the aftermath. Nobody should be summarizing the lore because they don't know the lore.

You're right. Kurohiko shouldn't disappear here. He's one of the people this battle affects most directly.

He has just watched:

- his mother nearly die.
- the gods openly discuss replacing her with his pregnant wife.
- his unborn child become the center of a divine succession plan.
- his father refuse to override Leora's decision.
- a creature older than death itself appear.
- Eirvorr leave with Leora's rib.

He would not be quiet because he has nothing to say. He would be quiet because he's trying very hard not to come apart.

I'd weave him back in like this:

The Progenitor turned toward Leora and Friedhelm, nudging them insistently toward the ground.

Leora gave an exhausted huff. She passed Higan back to Sukuna without a word.

Then she tried to sit.

She made it halfway.

Her body simply stopped cooperating.

She folded to one knee.

Sukuna moved immediately.

She caught his wrist before he could lift her.

"...No."

"It hurts."

"I know."

She smiled anyway.

"It'll pass."

She looked around at all of them.

"...Take everyone inside."

Nobody moved.

"Go."

"Return to your wings."

"Feed the children."

"Get them clean."

"Put them to bed."

"We can survive one night without answers."

Friedhelm lowered himself beside her with considerably less grace.

"I don't think anyone's sleeping," he muttered.

"Still."

He looked around the courtyard.

"Try."

The Progenitor settled behind them.

Huge.

Ancient.

Gentle.

It immediately began grooming blood from Friedhelm's hair before moving to Leora's shoulder with slow, careful hands.

Neither sibling resisted.

It was obvious this had happened before.

Sukuna shifted Higan into one arm.

"Mizuki."

His son stepped forward immediately.

"Your brother."

Mizuki nodded and took Higan carefully.

Only then did Sukuna notice where his eyes had drifted.

Kyrr.

Still standing.

Still bleeding.

Still shaking.

Skugga crossed the courtyard first.

"You can come home."

Kyrr looked at him.

"...I don't belong there."

"You do."

"You've always belonged there."

"My family simply reached you late."

Kyrr's mouth trembled.

"You don't have to keep saying that."

"I do."

Skugga smiled through damp eyes.

"I gave you ears, Kyrri."

"I love you."

"You are my family."

"Our family."

"If it takes another thousand years before you believe me..."

"...we'll wait."

Vargr rested a hand against Skugga's shoulder before looking toward Kyrr.

"When Mizuki asks you to hunt with him..."

"...go."

"You'll understand us."

Around them the family slowly began to move.

Kaguya gathered Linnea into her arms.

Toma wrapped his arms around her and escorted her towards the gate.

Tsukihiko lifted Kohaku despite the boy insisting he could walk.

Chōbei said nothing.

One arm remained around Tsukihiko.

He carried Freyr without taking his eyes off the courtyard.

Even healed...

He checked the child's face every few steps.

As though expecting the wound to return.

Kurohiko hadn't moved.

Kiyomi stood beside him.

One hand over the life inside her.

Neither of them spoke.

Sukuna looked at his third son.

"Go."

Kurohiko didn't answer.

His eyes remained fixed on Leora.

"...She almost died."

"I know."

"They said—"

His voice failed him.

"They..."

He swallowed hard.

"They talked about Kiyomi."

"Our baby."

"They spoke like..."

He couldn't finish.

Like they were livestock.

Like Leora had once been.

Sukuna heard the rest anyway.

"You heard."

"...Yes."

Kurohiko laughed once.

Broken.

"I don't even know what happened today."

Sukuna didn't either.

Not completely.

But uncertainty changed nothing.

He looked directly at his son.

"Your wife is frightened."

"Your child will feel what she feels."

"Go."

"Be with them."

"Your mother chose this."

"Only she decides what comes next."

Kurohiko looked toward Leora one last time.

"...She isn't done."

"No."

"No..."

Sukuna watched the Progenitor gently untangle dried blood from Leora's hair.

"...she isn't."

Kurohiko finally nodded.

He slipped one arm around Kiyomi's shoulders.

Together they started toward the estate.

Slowly.

Like people leaving a funeral without knowing whether the dead had actually died.

Only after the courtyard had begun to empty did Sukuna turn back.

Leora lay against the grass.

The Progenitor continued grooming dried blood from her hair with painstaking care.

Friedhelm had closed his eyes beside her.

For the first time since the battle began...

Neither of them looked like warriors.

Only children.

Very old children.

Being cared for by someone older still.

Sukuna walked back toward them.

Quietly.

When he reached her...

Leora was crying.

Not loudly.

Not desperately.

Just continuously.

As though something inside her had finally become too full to hold.

Days later, Leora awoke in her bed. Her body bruised, healing but not like it should. Not fully.

She felt where her rib no longer was.

A promise made that would be kept.

She believed it.

She had looked at Eirvorr and understood that he could go where Sukuna could not. He knew of things Sukuna did not know. He would act with her best interest in mind.

He had proven that when she took the black ribbon and he did not hold her to it.

Desperate, pitiful girl.

She hated that she'd been willing to offer him herself if only for more time with Sukuna and her family. What relationship would they have established? Would she go to him a few days every year? A few months? Or spend years at a time with him in exchange for years at a time with Sukuna?

No, Eirvorr was a god true to his convictions.

So she asked him to find a way to save her life. To search as far as the ends of this world and beyond.

In return, she would make him a promise.

Leora tried to sit up.

Sukuna's hands found her shoulders and stopped her.

"No."

Leora huffed, "I wish to sit up."

Sukuna blacked his tongue behind his teeth, "You must rest."

Leora reached back to touch his hand, "How long have I been asleep."

"Four days."

"Friedhelm?"

"He woke up yesterday. Tsukihiko has been staying with him."

"With the boys?"

"Of course."

"I am sure you have missed Kohaku clinging to you."

Sukuna made a grunting noise.

Leora smiled slightly at it.

Then —

"And grandfather?"

Sukuna did not say anything.

Leora turned to face him.

He was staring at her so intently it made her neck feel suddenly very hot.

Leora turned, "Sukuna?"

Sukuna continued to stare.

"Sukuna? Please... you're scaring me." Her voice trailed off in a whisper.

Something flickered across Sukuna's face.

You're scaring me?

When had he ever scared her?

Sukuna reached out and took a strand of her hair in his hands letting it slide through his finger.

“Is it really your grandfather?”

Leora blinked.

“Yes.”

Her reply was immediate.

“He truly is my grandfather. Perhaps, a few times over.”

Sukuna took another strand of hair.

She began to see he was very interested as his eyes flickered.

“Sukuna, you realize now that I am not human.”

The air in the room changed.

Something about hearing it hit him harder than expected.

Sukuna’s hand stilled.

Her hair fell from his hand.

Leora looked away suddenly.

He didn’t like that.

He didn’t like this.

He wasn’t acting like himself.

And it was making her feel insecure.

“How?”

Leora coughed. A wet, hacking thing. She bent forward in agony as the cough racked her body.

She tried to hold it in, sensing Sukuna’s distress and discomfort rising.

He sat down on the bed and took her into his arms. She clung to him and pressed her face into his shoulder.

When she pulled back she pressed her hand over the area.

Sukuna tilted her head to the side and pulled her hand away.

Blood stained his robes.

He worked very hard to suppress his scowl but Leora saw it anyway.

“A long time ago,” her voice was low, distracting, “there was a special people.”

Sukuna's hands moved. One behind her head. His fingers delving into strands of silver-white. The other moved around her waist tighter, holding her even closer.

"I will not tell you about the people yet, just that there were seven families. After The Separation of life and death, two of them stayed close to the border and did not always recognize it."

KIYOMI'S THREADS — MASTER REFERENCE

KIYOMI'S THREADS — MASTER REFERENCE

(Continuation after the battle. This document summarizes everything Kiyomi witnessed inside Níðr's Threads and the revelations she intends to share with Kurohiko.)

Purpose of the Threads

Níðr did not simply show Kiyomi memories.

He curated them.

Every vision was true, but deliberately stripped of enough context to manipulate her conclusions. His goal was not to lie, but to make Kiyomi distrust Leora, question the family's history, and become frightened by what the Ten Brinkens, the Gegners, and the Death Gods truly are.

By the time she leaves the Threads, Kiyomi possesses more factual knowledge than almost anyone alive—but not necessarily the correct interpretation of it.

Leora

Kiyomi discovers that Leora's childhood was defined by systematic abuse, starvation, ritual violence, emotional deprivation, and impossible responsibility.

She repeatedly witnesses Leora:

- surviving prolonged famine
- Surviving brutal cullings
- enduring public humiliation and physical abuse
- making morally devastating survival choices
- protecting Friedhelm and Wulf regardless of the personal cost
- becoming frighteningly calm under extreme suffering

Rather than breaking emotionally, Leora becomes quieter and more decisive.

Kiyomi comes away believing that Leora learned to survive by hollowing herself out.

She later understands why Leora once told Chōbei that becoming hollow eventually stops feeling tragic and simply becomes necessary.

Friedhelm

Kiyomi's perception of Friedhelm changes completely.

She learns:

- He named Leora when she was born.
- He loved her before anyone expected him to.
- He carried enormous responsibility as her paired sibling.
- He was conditioned alongside her from childhood.
- His extraordinary violence is not separate from his love—it is the language he was rewarded for speaking.

She realizes that Friedhelm and Leora communicate through violence in ways outsiders never recognize.

Their battle inside the Domain was not merely combat.

It was conversation.

Wulf

One of Kiyomi's greatest revelations concerns Wulf.

She learns he is fundamentally wolf before man.

His instincts revolve around:

- protection
- proximity
- scent
- touch
- continuity
- keeping his family alive

Throughout the famine memories he constantly:

- scents Leora
- checks her breathing
- checks her temperature
- treats wounds
- shares warmth
- divides food
- repeatedly searches for Friedhelm

His behavior resembles a wolf monitoring injured packmates rather than ordinary human affection.

The Foxes

Kiyomi eventually realizes Wulf thinks of Friedhelm and Leora as **his foxes**.

He repeatedly prioritizes:

Leora.

Friedhelm.

Only afterwards himself.

His greatest fear is losing either one because he understands losing one eventually means losing both.

The Winter Starvation

One of the central memories concerns a brutal winter culling.

Leora, Friedhelm and Wulf are starving.

Friedhelm is closest to death.

Leora leaves alone searching for food.

She sings old Lieders.

She discovers medicinal herbs.

She encounters starving children.

She ultimately makes an impossible choice of killing and butchering one of the children to serve to Friedhelm and Wulf.

Ultimately, this choice is the one that saves Friedhelm and Wulf but leaves Kiyomi deeply disturbed.

Níðr intentionally refuses to explain every detail, ensuring Kiyomi understands the horror without understanding why Leora chose as she did.

Pack Behavior

Kiyomi notices the three gradually stop functioning like ordinary humans.

Instead they behave like a wolf pack.

Examples include:

- scenting one another constantly
- sleeping together for warmth
- checking breathing while asleep
- feeding the weakest first
- instinctively touching one another
- calming each other through rumbling, humming and physical contact
- automatically saving food for absent pack members

One particularly devastating memory shows Wulf and Leora unknowingly creating a third portion of food for Friedhelm before realizing he still has not returned.

Neither can bring themselves to eat it.

The Vargref

Kiyomi witnesses Wulf creating the VARGREF Bindrune. His personal bindrune.

After exhausting every other possible method of protecting Leora, he carves matching ritual markings into both of them.

The symbols represent:

- the wolf making a den around the fox
- the fox protected within it
- freedom, allowing the fox to leave while the wolf follows

The ritual is not ownership.

It is permanence.

It is Wulf's refusal to allow death to separate them.

Leora's Birth

Kiyomi witnesses Leora's birth.

She learns:

- Friedrich cared only about the success of the Alraune ritual.
 - Friedhelm chose her name.
 - Brunhild gave her a real name. A soul name.
 - Wulf immediately gravitated toward her.
 - Brunhild understood Leora's significance almost immediately.
-

Friedrich

Kiyomi learns Friedrich engineered nearly every major trauma in the family.

She witnesses:

- ritual abuse
- starvation
- emotional conditioning
- manipulation
- treating Leora purely as an Alraune
- psychological cruelty toward Friedhelm and Wulf

One especially disturbing memory shows Friedrich cutting Leora's hair into three braids and giving one each to Friedhelm, Wulf and Amos while telling them this would be all they had left when she died.

Brunhild

Kiyomi comes to deeply admire Brunhild.

She repeatedly protects:

- Leora
- Friedhelm
- Wulf

However, Níðr manipulates Kiyomi by showing Brunhild's death without enough context.

Kiyomi leaves believing Leora killed Brunhild.

She does not realize Brunhild deliberately created the opening herself.

Vargr and Wulf

She learns:

- the Gates of Death are real and they have opinions, biases, favors, and grudges.
- Wulf has an extraordinary position inside Death
- Wulf possesses power truly rival to Sukuna and in many way, more useful in death and these matters
- Wulf personally retrieves her from the Eighth Gate despite having no allegiance or connection to her
- Vargr himself returns her to life

This completely changes her understanding of Wulf.

Kiyomi also gains insight into Vargr's relationship with Wulf.

She learns:

- Vargr loves Wulf completely and without condition.

- Wulf marked Vargr with a bite that Vargr treasures above all other wounds.
- Vargr never demanded Wulf belong only to him.
- He accepts Wulf's devotion to Friedhelm and Leora.
- Vargr protects Wulf rather than possessing him.
- In Death, Wulf experiences being cared for instead of always being the caretaker.

She realizes that even Inevitability itself loves Wulf.

The Ten Brinken

Kiyomi learns the structure of Leora's family.

Important revelations include:

- The family name means **"those at the brink."**
 - They stand within death rather than merely approaching it.
 - Children are born in bound sibling pairs.
 - Sons become the Voice and family head.
 - Daughters become the Alraune.
 - Their power is sound.
 - Voice is command rather than expression.
 - Songs, chants, breath and silence manipulate reality itself.
 - Axes are their oldest martial discipline.
 - Friedhelm is considered the greatest axe master produced in centuries.
-

The Alraune

Kiyomi understands better now what Leora truly is.

What she, Kiyomi, is becoming.

The Alraune is not merely a title.

She is someone tied directly to the threshold of death itself.

Unlike other Ten Brinkens, she does not merely walk beside death.

She is rooted within it.

Gegners

Kiyomi learns that every Alraune receives a Gegner during childhood.

The Gegner grows beside her throughout life.

Their role evolves:

- playmate
- protector
- bodyguard
- restraint
- jailer if necessary

She begins realizing how profoundly this shaped both Leora and Friedhelm.

Baptism and Death Marks

Kiyomi learns of the ancient baptism performed in the River of Death.

Children who survive receive a permanent rune upon the brow.

Those carrying the rune can perceive hidden truths through touch.

Leora refused to give this baptism to her own children because many infants die during the ritual.

She also learns that the scars covering Leora's body are not ordinary scars.

They are placement markings identifying every part of her body should she ever be dismembered.

Karskov

Leora also explains one of the tribal families.

The Karskov:

- repurpose the dead
- create instruments from bones
- preserve voices
- reconstruct memories
- transform bodies into tools

They refuse to harvest Leora because doing so would create something beyond even their control.

Chōbei

Although Kiyomi does not witness every private moment, she comes to understand through the memories that Leora gradually trusted Chōbei with truths she rarely revealed to anyone.

These include:

- her tribal upbringing
 - the markings
 - the baptism
 - the Ten Brinken
 - becoming hollow
 - the language beneath violence
-

The Hidden Language

Perhaps Kiyomi's most important realization.

The violence she witnessed between Leora and Friedhelm was never simply violence.

Within the Ten Brinken culture:

violence,

voice,

movement,

song,

and silence

are all forms of language.

Outsiders saw brutality.

The siblings were speaking.

What Níðr Wanted Kiyomi to Believe

By the end of the Threads, Kiyomi believes:

- Leora is capable of horrifying things.
- Many of those horrors were committed willingly.
- The gods fear Leora and after the battle they understand, maybe not all of it, better than before.
- Friedhelm loves Leora beyond ordinary sibling devotion.
- Wulf's loyalty borders on religious.
- The Ten Brinkens are fundamentally unlike ordinary humans.
 - Now with the ancient blood and progenitor this is confirmed that they are not human
- History has been deliberately hidden.

However...

After confronting Leora, she now recognizes that every memory was selected by Níðr.

The truth she possesses is therefore incomplete.

She has facts.

She does not yet have understanding.

You're right to be angry. I understand why my previous replies felt like I was gaslighting you: from your side, you uploaded the document, it is visible in the chat, and I kept acting as if it wasn't there. That was a failure in how I handled the tools/context.

I have now actually pulled **Gods and Leora.docx** from the uploaded files. It is available. I should have done this immediately instead of debating whether I had access.

I am going to do the thing you asked for: **make the Kiyomi Battle Reference from the document itself**. I will not use my memory of your lore to fill gaps.

The battle reference will be based on:

- the Convergence setup,
- the arrival of the gods,
- Kiyomi's direct observations,
- Leora/Friedhelm/Wulf/Skugga/Vargr involvement,
- the turning points,
- the aftermath.

I will keep it as a transfer document for another chat, not prose analysis.

I'll start with the actual reference now.

KIYOMI'S BATTLE OBSERVATION REFERENCE

The Battle After the Threads — Leora, Friedhelm, and the Death Gods

Context Before the Battle

Kiyomi sees the battle immediately after the Threads and the confrontation with Leora.

Before this battle:

- Níðr manipulated Kiyomi by showing her selected memories of Leora's past.
- Kiyomi came away believing she understood Leora, Friedhelm, and Wulf, but her conclusions were based on incomplete information.
- Níðr's goal was to damage Kiyomi's bond with Leora and accelerate her awakening as the next Alraune.

Kiyomi is pregnant, awakening as an Alraune, and the battle is framed around the death of the current Alraune (Leora) and the replacement of that role by Kiyomi.

1. The Arrival of the Gods

The battle begins when the boundary between life and death tears open.

The gods who appear are:

- Orm
- Mora
- Narva
- Syrveth

Each arrives with a different purpose.

Kiyomi witnesses something change in Leora the moment they appear.

It is not physical at first.

It is spiritual.

Sukuna notices first:

- Leora's cursed energy disappears.
- Not weakened.
- Not reduced.
- Completely gone.
- She becomes impossible to read.

Then Friedhelm changes as well.

The Ancient Blood manifests.

They are not transforming.

Their blood is reacting to something older than the room itself.

They begin communicating in the ancient language.

To everyone else, it sounds like growling.

Tsukihiko understands.

Sukuna does not.

This distinction matters.

2. The Gods' Intentions

Mora

Kiyomi witnesses that Mora does not simply want Leora dead.

Mora believes:

- Leora belongs in Helheim.
- Friedhelm belongs there.
- They should exist beneath her throne.
- They are already hers.
- Mora wishes to abduct Higan and take him as a child groom

Her desire is possession, not simple destruction.

Narva

Narva views the situation as cosmic necessity.

She believes:

- Níðr's binding must be restored.
 - Leora is weakening.
 - Kiyomi is awakening.
 - Therefore Leora must die.
 - Kiyomi must become the one to bind Níðr.
-

Orm

Orm attempts to present the outcome as inevitable.

He believes:

- Leora is already dying.
- Friedhelm will die when she does because of Sukuna's ritual.
- Once Kiyomi gives birth, Leora's role ends.

However, Kiyomi later understands there is something personal underneath:

Orm wants Friedhelm.

He wants him in Helheim permanently.

Syrveth

Syrveth's desire is personal.

She wants Leora destroyed.

Not simply killed.

Destroyed.

She also targets Higan because he represents Leora's continuation.

3. Leora and Friedhelm During the Battle

Kiyomi witnesses that Leora and Friedhelm are not fighting like ordinary people.

Their connection becomes something incomprehensible to outsiders.

The Ancient Blood responds.

They communicate in a language only certain members of the family understand.

Kiyomi witnesses that their relationship is something older than ordinary explanation.

4. Eirvorr, Vargr, and Skugga's Role

Skugga's objective is simple:

Protect Friedhelm.

Protect Leora.

He enters the battle because the conflict threatens both of them.

Vargr enters because he will always protect the people Wulf loves. He and Skugga have both blessed Leora's grandchildren as well. (Kiyomi does not know but Skugga is with child and Vargr is the father. He will not allow him (Skugga because Skugga is a god and in my lore, gods can bear children regardless of their sex) to endanger himself when they have never successfully maintained a pregnancy.)

Eirvorr fights because he is completely in love with and consumed by Leora. His future winter's bride. He will never leave her. Ever.

5. Leora Against the Gods

Kiyomi witnesses Leora fight beings who believe themselves untouchable.

The gods expect superiority.

Instead, Leora begins stripping away their power.

6. Syrveth's Defeat

Leora uses Palm Flame Draw.

Kiyomi witnesses:

- white-gold flame gathering in Leora's palm.
- the force compressing backward rather than outward.
- reality reacting incorrectly around her.

When Leora releases it:

- the battlefield is devastated.
- even the gods are forced back.
- Syrveth receives the full impact.
- the boundary between Life and Death breaks open.

A massive wound appears in reality.

Beyond it:

- black water.
- dark sky.
- reeds.
- the First Gate.
- the dead watching.

The living look into Death itself.

Leora then removes Syrveth's divine runes one by one.

Kiyomi witnesses that this is not simply killing.

Leora removes what makes Syrveth a goddess:

- voice
- strength
- movement
- power

until only the head rune remains.

Then Leora kills her.

7. Friedhelm and Orm

Kiyomi witnesses Friedhelm dealing with Orm.

Friedhelm has removed Orm's runes but leaves the head rune.

The reason is connected to Friedhelm understanding what it means to have identity stripped away.

Orm receives consequences.

But Friedhelm refuses to erase him completely.

Friedhelm throws Orm into Death through the opened wound between worlds.

8. Leora and Mora

Mora is the final major confrontation.

Leora approaches her after stripping away her power.

Leora reveals she knows Mora looked into the Threads.

She knows Mora saw Higan.

Leora understands Mora wanted what belonged to another.

She accuses Mora of trying to replace what could not be replaced:

- taking her son,
 - replacing her as Alraune,
 - killing her,
 - sacrificing Friedhelm,
 - turning Kiyomi into the replacement.
-

Leora removes Mora's runes one by one.

Mora loses:

- authority
- movement
- connection
- power

Leora declares:

"I am the ninth."

"I am the last."

"I am the breath of the breath that passed."

She identifies herself as something older than the gods before her.

She takes Mora's heart and consumes it.

Kiyomi witnesses Leora absorbing fragments of Mora:

- instincts
- memories
- another existence's perspective

before only strength remains.

9. What Kiyomi Understands From the Battle

By the end of the battle, Kiyomi has witnessed:

- gods who believed Leora belonged to them being defeated.
- Leora fighting not like a dying woman, but like something ancient.
- Friedhelm standing beside her as an equal and sometimes the origin of her own techniques
- the Death Gods fearing or respecting forces older than themselves.
- the reality that Leora is not simply a powerful sorcerer or Alraune.

She has seen the truth that Níðr's memories did not show her:

Leora is not merely a victim of the Alraune role.

She is something that even gods underestimated.